

## **Saint Severus of Antioch**

### **Censure on the Tome of Julian**

Saint Severus, Archbishop of Antioch, writes to Julian, Bishop of Halicarnassus, highlighting how the inspired Scriptures and the Church's doctors, who have interpreted them in the Spirit, teach the way to think and speak about the incorruptibility of the most holy body of "the great God and our Savior Jesus Christ.

An apostolic law has been observed in the holy Church since its origin; it imposes on those who proclaim the gospel and on those who preach or teach the faith it contains the obligation to make it known to one another, both with modesty and discernment, and to maintain a unique and common hope. This is what the great Paul did, who was called from above for the ministry of preaching and, for this very reason, referred to himself as the "called apostle"—because he had not been counted among the apostles from the beginning, but the dignity of the apostleship was conferred upon him with his calling, and at the same time, he had been numbered among those who then believed in Christ and had also shone among the apostles by crowning this divine college. Indeed, he had received the testimony of the one who called him that he alone, more than the others, was able to bear "the name that is above all names," which is why he was called a "chosen vessel," because he was capable of containing the rich and abundant influx of knowledge, difficult for others to bear. It is therefore he, this remarkable man, who, writing to the Galatians, stated that he had gone up to Jerusalem, by revelation, to those notable among the apostles to manifest the gospel he preached; he also pointed out the reason for this journey, declaring with a humility of spirit worthy of praise: "lest by any means I should run, or had run, in vain" (Galatians 2:2). He gave the same warning to the Corinthians to be vigilant and not to waver. He also urged them not

to trust even in their own selves, not to discover some novelty, and not to welcome foreign teaching, but to carefully consider the model of his preaching and to examine every opinion according to this standard, speaking to them in these terms: "Examine yourselves, whether you be in the faith; prove your own selves" (2 Corinthians 13:5).

It is therefore to imitate this beautiful example of the teaching of the Word that the revered pastors of the churches, who were the heirs of the apostles, competed with zeal, and regarding the problems that constantly arose among them, in their apprehension and great concern, they wrote to one another. To avoid speaking of events that are too distant from us, this is how Dionysius, who presided over the holy church of Alexandria, had written to his namesake, I mean Dionysius, who at that time was also at the head of the spiritual flock of Rome, and before him, to Cornelius and Stephen, who had directed the same flock, when, after having received a response, he wrote to them again as if to provide a remedy for the difficulties that had arisen before them. Likewise, Pistus, bishop of the church of the Corinthians, had written to the great servant of God Athanasius.

Following their steps and obeying the law of the Church, your Holiness also wrote to me at the outset to criticize those who declare so absolutely that the body of "our great God and Savior Christ" is corruptible, and you also sent me what you had been compelled to write to them on this matter; you asked that after reading and examining it, a response be drafted regarding what should be firmly and consistently thought about this question.

For my part, I dread to speak! I fear that, feeling quite distant and overshadowed, for example, by "those divine towers and those citadels of truth" of the ministers of pious words, this very fact might give the impression that the illusion of glory drives me to compare myself to them without reservation. However, it is not without danger for those

who are counted among the bishops to remain silent on such subjects, as the servant described in the divine Gospel shows: because he had been more the servant of his laziness than of his master, having secretly buried his talent, he found himself, with bitterness and deep sorrow, stripped of the divine grace that had been granted to him, and he was cast into outer darkness. The holy Apostle proclaims without hesitation, "It is a stewardship that has been entrusted to me"—thus he calls the ministry of the evangelical word—"and woe to me if I do not proclaim it!" (1 Corinthians 9:17).

Given the extreme fear we experience in the face of divine threat, it is essential that, with the proactive action of divine grace within us, all healthy words and thoughts emanate, and according to the limited means at our disposal, we proceed as briefly as possible and express a clear opinion on these subjects, avoiding all violent and superfluous ideas so as not to appear to discourse on anything other than what we have prepared to discuss. We must also follow, alongside the inspired writings, the chosen men and guardians of the Law, who, throughout the ages, have been teachers of the mysteries of the holy Church, not only in their doctrines but also in the terminology that expresses those doctrines, and we must regard as true what they have said and false what they have not said. For my part, I confess to being aware of my weakness; and in every circumstance of my life, I strive to align my mind with their terminology and ideas and to conform my language to theirs, resorting to their expressions in my speech and writings whenever circumstances require it, and not to recognize them as Fathers on one hand while elevating myself against their inescapable declarations, which are the expression of authentic doctrine, on the other. For it is not they who spoke, according to the true word of our Savior, but the Spirit of their Father who spoke in them and made known to them what was appropriate to say and also what should be

kept silent, according to the traps set by the wicked cunning of heresies, which leave us absolutely nothing outside of critique and discussion. Thus, it is certainly of great importance for our generation, as we are counted among the doctors, to grasp and articulate fully and without alteration the fruit of their labor and discussions.

I therefore pray that your piety does not take offense at the fact that this exposition proceeds in the form of an inquiry and examination, recommended by the truth, rather than as a discussion of a controversial question. However, perhaps it is in vain that I have made this request, since you had previously encouraged us to explore what you had written and not merely to receive it with pure goodwill. Thus, we believe that, following the apostle's prayer, the peace of Christ will calm our hearts as we seek the truth; moreover, charity bears all things, because it is the bond of perfection (Colossians 3:14).

Who then is unaware that all these eminent doctors have stated, following divine Scripture, that the Son of God and his Word, who is before the ages, became incarnate at the end of times, taking on human form from the Holy Spirit and the Mother of God, Mary, ever Virgin, without any change or alteration? It is understood that he united hypostatically with a body endowed with an intelligent soul—elements that also constitute our humanity—excluding sin, which is not considered inherent to human constitution and nature, since it is a weakness and a disease of the spirit that has deviated, through the exercise of free will, towards illegitimate desire. Indeed, he too was affected by this infirmity, and because his concerns had turned towards pleasure, Adam was overcome by the allure of the fruit of the tree that was forbidden to him. Now, an infirmity being a defect of health, this infirmity is also an alteration of a spirit that has abandoned healthy concerns. Therefore, if someone chooses to maintain thoughts that are healthy and pleasing to God, he will be free from sin and weaknesses.

It is already known that sin, which results from a defect and an alteration of health, is something without substance or hypostasis. Thus, as long as he enjoyed health, that is to say, as long as he observed the divine command, Adam bore no trace of sin within him; but when, through a voluntary impulse, he turned his mind towards the allure of pleasure and became enslaved to abominable desire, having strayed from the right path, it is said and understood that he was subjected to sin.

This depended on his full will, to sin, I say, and not to sin. Thus, he was also stripped of the grace of immortality, disturbing by the shadow of sin the image of divine likeness, by virtue of which, formed as an intelligent being in regard to his soul, he had been filled with the companionship of the Holy Spirit and made capable of all knowledge and all virtue; indeed, this is what the breath of life means, which, as the divine Word has said, was breathed into his face by his Creator; for he had previously received the threat: "On the day that you eat of it, you shall surely die" (Genesis 2:17). Here, true death is considered: the separation from life and the distancing from God, who is life by nature and immortality, and it is in this regard that it has also been written by one of the divine sages: "God is not the author of death" (Wisdom 1:13). Moreover, God had previously formulated the threat of what was to result from sin, so that man, remaining steadfast in observing the divine command and delighting in the favor and enjoyment of divine companionship, would render death ineffective and not separate from God. But when he sinned against him, God, in his mercy and compassion for what he had formed, did not inflict a cruel but a very gentle condemnation. Indeed, since it is proper for composed beings to dissolve, decreeing upon him: "You are dust, and to dust you shall return" (Genesis 3:19), he dissolves the one who had been constituted by composition, while allowing for regeneration and resurrection

through his divine incarnation. Not to dissolve the one who had been affected by sin would have meant allowing the evil that arose from it to remain immortal. Furthermore, before the transgression, it was the whole man that God threatened with death in case he broke the commandment; he declares without discrimination: "On the day that you eat of the forbidden food, you shall surely die" (Genesis 2:17) to restrain, through fear, any voluntary inclination toward sin. But after he had broken the commandment and sinned, God condescended to pity and granted forgiveness to the rational soul, which had deviated toward the pleasures of the earthly body due to its conjunction with it; for "He knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust" (Psalm 103:14), according to the word of the psalmist. He split the dark judicial sentence, reduced the decree by half, so to speak, and reserved for the body alone the condition of being mortal, saying, "You are dust, and to dust you shall return" (Genesis 3:19) to prevent the rational soul, again condemned by the divine word, from completely straying from God, so that it could not absolutely rise again or look toward the heights from which it had fallen.

However, we must affix to what has been said the seal of the words of the holy Fathers and the doctors. Indeed, when we have cited testimonies regarding each of our assertions, the exposition will be entirely worthy of faith, clear, and adorned, moreover, with the words of the testimonies as a sort of ornament and an invincible breastplate, since it will refrain from making certain declarations and will not introduce, into the debate, statements from the doctrine of the Fathers that have a different meaning.

Thus, Athanasius has bequeathed to us the foundation of infallible faith regarding the incarnation, namely that we must confess a single nature of the Word of God who became flesh. Gregory the Theologian called his doctrines the standard of orthodoxy; Saint Cyril also declared that

he had, with his apostolic and irresistible thought, attacked the innovations of the futile discourses of wicked heretics, and that through his expositions, like the sweet fragrance of a prepared ointment, he filled with joy, delight, and cheerfulness all that is under heaven, and that all had attested to the orthodoxy and precision of his doctrine. It is he who, in a treatise entitled Catechesis on the bodily manifestation of the Son of God, our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, who became man for us, wrote the following: "For God is good; indeed, he is the source of all goodness. Now, in one who is good, there is no jealousy for anything. Therefore, because he does not experience the jealousy that would cause him to deny existence to anything, through his Word, who is our Lord Jesus Christ, he made everything out of nothing, and he took more pity on the human race than on anything else on earth. And as he saw them unfit, by the nature of their origin, to remain forever, granting them an additional favor, he did not simply create humans like all other living beings that populate the earth, but he made them in his image, giving them afterward the grace that derives from his Word; thus, if one can say, holding shadows of his image and becoming rational, they enjoyed the life that is truly that of the saints. Because he knows, moreover, that the will of men can lean in both directions, he beforehand provided, through a law and the choice of a place, the grace that had been granted to them. Indeed, after introducing them into his paradise, he gave them this law: if they kept the grace and remained good, they would have, in paradise, a life that knows no sadness, affliction, death, or anxiety; but if they deviated, if they changed and became wicked, they would know that they would themselves suffer, through death, natural corruption, and that from then on they would no longer live in paradise, but that, dying henceforth outside of paradise, they would remain in death and corruption.

He clearly calls death, which separates the soul from the body, a corruption according to nature. This is because dissolution is inherently part of the nature of composites. Now, dissolution is death and the separation of the soul from the body and everything that constitutes the body; for the human body was not formed solely from earth, but also from elements that are connected to it: God, who is both its author and its creator, indicated this clearly when he looked down upon Job and, as if to question him, said, "Have you, too, taken clay from the earth and formed a man, and placed him on the earth endowed with speech?" (Job 33:6). For clay is undoubtedly dust mixed with water; it also partly consists of an alloy of air and light from which bodies are made. As for the living being endowed with speech, who was placed on earth by the one who formed him and who evolves there, what does it signify except the rational man, composed of an intelligent soul and a body, who would not have undergone the dissolution of death and natural corruption if he had possessed the grace of immortality and had not first experienced the corruption of the soul that is outside of nature, had he not deviated into abominable pleasure and transgressed the command? For the doctor reveals two things: that immortality, as well as divine companionship and illumination, was a grace, since he says that God has safeguarded, through a law and the choice of a place, the grace that had been granted to them, and that deviation was malice; he indeed said, "if they deviated, if they changed and became evil." Now malice is a passion of the soul towards which the spirit has inopportunately turned; by saying, "if they deviated," he perfectly and adequately designates a masterful impulse of itself and indicates that it was possible for them not to change.

Saint Cyril also establishes the point that it is not from nature, but from grace that man has been stripped due to his defection, in his instruction "On Solutions," which he composed for Deacon Tiberius and his



colleagues. He states perfectly, as if he were enunciating a rule, "For we have lost nothing of what we possess by nature!" Furthermore, in the first book of his Commentary on the Gospel of John, he writes the following: "Man is therefore a rational animal, but composed, meaning of a soul and this earthly and temporal flesh. Because he was made by God and came into being, he did not possess incorruptibility or indestructibility by his own nature—these belong by nature to God alone—he was marked by the spirit of life, acquiring, through an intimate relationship with God, a good that surpasses nature; for 'He breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and man became a living soul' (Genesis 2:7). Receiving the punishment for his defection, he then heard justly, 'You are dust, and to dust you shall return' (Genesis 3:19). He was stripped of grace, and the breath of life departed from the earthly flesh, meaning the Spirit of him who said, 'I am the life' (John 14:6). Thus, the living Peter fell into death according to the flesh alone, while the soul remained in immortality, for it was of the flesh alone that it was said, 'You are dust, and to dust you shall return' (Genesis 3:19).

This is what the wise Athanasius clearly stated in the aforementioned work, where he further added the following and indicated what the corruption of sin is, which is outside of nature, and what, on the other hand, is the natural corruption of death that continually attacks man: "Man is mortal by nature because he has become something that is not; but thanks to his resemblance to him who is, if he had preserved it through the contemplation of God, he would have suppressed the natural corruption and remained incorruptible; as Wisdom says: 'The observation of the law is the guarantee of incorruptibility' (Wisdom 6:18). Now, as long as he was incorruptible, he lived as if he had been divinized, as divine Scripture also shows when it declares: 'I said: You are gods, you are all sons of the Most High; but you will die like men

and fall like one of the princes' (Psalm 82:6-7). And this came about through consent given to the serpent: 'As Wisdom also says: "God created man for incorruptibility and made him in the image of his own eternity; it is through the envy of the devil that death entered the world"' (Wisdom 2:23-24). And when this was done, men were struck by death; moreover, corruption triumphed over them, further strengthening its hold on all of humankind, especially since they had previously received the threat from God that weighed upon them in the event of transgressing the commandment.

This apostolic doctor clearly declares and teaches that the death of man and the dissolution of his composite nature is a natural corruption, which he has suffered by losing the grace of incorruptibility and immortality; he did not preserve it by remaining faithful to the law and the commandment given to him, but by yielding to the cunning of the serpent and directing his free will towards desire, he has been, as the Apostle said, corrupted in his thoughts; afflicted by this infirmity, by a corruption that is outside of nature, he has chosen to "think outside of what he ought to think" rather than enjoying God, and he has selected what seemed desirable to him while straying from his duty. How then could we take the word "corruption" in a single and the same sense and attribute it solely to the corruption that is outside of nature, to sin, I ask? And shall we not also say that the death of man, I mean the dissolution of his composite nature, is a natural corruption? Conversely, if we reduce the term to an inadequate meaning, shall we say: What then! Is God the author of corruption? To speak in this way is certainly the act of a fool. For it is from an inaccurate use of this term that it results that God is also the cause of the corruption that is outside of nature, that is to say, of sin.

Every creature is indeed subject to change and alteration, for immutability belongs solely to the uncreated God and to substantial

life, as He is the one who is; on the other hand, the armies of angels above and all those beneath God, including rational creatures, are changing natures susceptible to alteration. This is attested by the devil and those who have transgressed with him: having previously belonged to the armies of good angels, they willingly turned their gaze away from the vision of God, became swollen with pride, and were afflicted by the infirmity of change and corruption that lies outside their nature. The prophet Ezekiel also attests to this, representing the God of the universe allegorically addressing the prince of Tyre, and in reality the devil, to show him what he had become and how he was banished by changing his disposition; he spoke to him thus: "You have sinned and have been banished from the mountain of God, and a cherub has expelled you from the midst of the fiery stones; your heart was lifted up because of your beauty, and your wisdom was corrupted by your beauty; it is because of the multitude of your sins that I have cast you to the ground" (Ezekiel 28:16-17). He has thus named the armies of angels "fiery stones," since another prophet also called the holy men who behaved like angels in this way when he said, "Holy stones were falling to the earth" (Job 38:6). Furthermore, he named the high rank of the heavenly armies "holy mountain," from which the cherubim, who in some way serve as lancers, expelled the devil who had corrupted his wisdom and, through pride, had forgotten his rank. For among the angels, there is also a wisdom that prevents them from losing sight of the arrangement of ranks; this is why the divine book of the Song of Songs refers to these spiritual and immaterial armies as "ranked" by designating them as the "ranked army." Shall we then say that God is the author of the change and corruption that lie outside the nature of pure intelligences? Not at all, but although He is the creator of changing creatures and natures, since immutability by nature is proper to the uncreated nature, He has, on the other hand, granted them sufficient light, since they are rational beings, a joy that allows them to

delight in the vision of God and His glory, and enables them to establish and affirm themselves in immutability, and not only that, but also to say with the Apostle, "The love of Christ compels us" (2 Corinthians 5:14). It is therefore because they willingly turned their gaze away from this enjoyment of beatitude and glorification of God that the devil, along with his armies, accomplices in his rebellion, became for themselves the cause of the change and corruption of their intelligences and entered into darkness. Darkness is indeed the separation from true light, and true death is the abandonment of true life.

Thus, as we say for these reasons that God is the creator of changing creatures, and not of change and corruption, we also rightly confess that when it comes to the formation of man—since he is a composite and mortal nature—God is its creator, but not of death, dissolution, and natural corruption. Indeed, he would have had the power to preserve the grace of reflecting the divine image and of immortality if his spirit had not first changed and if it had not been affected by corruption arising outside of nature, which caused it to return to dust, as Ecclesiastes states (Ecclesiastes 3:20), leading to dissolution and natural death; for it is proper to composite nature to dissolve once it is stripped of the grace of God. This is what he himself declared by decreeing, "You are dust, and to dust you shall return" (Genesis 3:19); he did not say, "Now you have become dust," but "You are," meaning that what you are by nature, you will become and you will dissolve; for dissolution is linked to the earth, and you would not have suffered it if you had kept the garment of incorruptibility that would have guaranteed you indissolubility. Indeed, we have heard the words of the great teacher Athanasius, who teaches, "Man is mortal according to his nature, because he has become from things that are not; but thanks to his resemblance to the one who is, if he had been preserved by the

contemplation of God, he would have suppressed natural corruption and remained incorruptible; as Wisdom says, 'Faithfulness to the Law is the guarantee of incorruptibility'" (Wisdom 6:18).

That angelic spirits, being purely intellectual and immaterial, are subject to change is yet another doctrinal statement found in the same unidentified treatise in the manuscript recension: "And from him again: And because a composite always contains within itself by nature the dissolution of the elements of which it is composed, the Fathers have rightly called it a corruption according to nature; and it is so that it does not reach man that, by grace, he has received from the God who loves gifts incorruptibility, that is to say, immortality." Indeed, this is what Basil, the divine sage, teaches in a letter addressed to Amphilochius on the Holy Spirit, where he shows that these beings also need the assistance of the divine Spirit: "They maintain their dignity through their perseverance in good; while their will enjoys free will, they never fail in their constancy in true good; to the extent, however, that if one were to withdraw the Spirit from them in thought, the choirs of angels disintegrate, the principalities of archangels are destroyed, and everything falls into confusion; their life becomes lawless, unordered, and indeterminate. How indeed could the angels say: Glory to God in the highest, without being comforted by the Spirit? For no one can say: Jesus is Lord, except in the Holy Spirit, and no one, if he speaks in the Spirit of God, says: Jesus is anathema. This is what the evil spirits, their antagonists, say, whose fall confirms the fact that purely intellectual armies enjoy free disposition of themselves and have an equal inclination toward virtue and vice. That is why they need the assistance of the Spirit.

Saint Cyril expresses a similar thought concisely, as if stating a rule, in his work addressed to the faithful Emperor Theodosius: "For whatever has begun to be in any way has from that moment the inherent change

within itself. But God, who surpasses all understanding, who possesses eternity, who transcends and escapes becoming and corruption, is above change." Likewise, in the sixth book of his Commentary on the Gospel of John, he states: "Indeed, everything that has been made is corruptible, even if it is not yet corrupted, because, by the will of God, it is maintained in incorruptibility. But God is incorruptible and eternal by nature, not having acquired this through the will of another, as creatures do, but because he always exists in his own goods, among which is also eternity." This aligns with what the Apostle writes to Timothy regarding the God who is above all: "King of kings and Lord of lords, who alone possesses immortality" (1 Timothy 6:15-16); creatures maintain their immortality and incorruptibility only by his will and the grace that emanates from him, needing to receive help from him, even if they possess it. This is further confirmed by the wise Cyril in the forty-fifth homily on the Gospel of Luke, where he says: "It belongs solely to the supreme nature to have the power to give life to the dead; it alone possesses immortality, and it is from it that all that has been called by it returns to movement and life.

It is thus demonstrated that, just as God is the creator of changing creatures and natures, and not of change itself, he is also the creator of mortal and corruptible nature, and not of dissolution, death, and corruption, since he had conferred from the beginning what was lacking to nature through the grace of immortality, divine fellowship, and divine illumination, which needed to be carefully preserved. However, Adam did not maintain this grace because, by his own will, his spirit had weakened through the desire for the forbidden fruit; through change, the beginning of corruption, and the action of sin, he became for himself, being composed and mortal, the cause of his return to natural dissolution and corruption.

It is for this reason that the Word of God, the author of our being, through whom God made everything, wishing out of pure goodness to restore what had fallen, to elevate it to its original state and to grant it the grace of immortality, did not act by constraint through his divine power, but decreed, in accordance with the demands of justice, that the very one who had fallen would fight again to repair his defeat. And since it did not belong to any man to prevail in this struggle, nor could the power of another creature annul the judicial sentence of God, which had declared, "You are dust, and to dust you shall return" (Genesis 3:19), it was necessary that man triumph over Satan, who had first seduced him and reserved death for him. In this seemingly hopeless situation, God himself, the Word, the Wisdom, and the Power of the Father, provided a way out. He himself, without undergoing any change, became man while remaining what he is as God, and he turned back upon his own head the wicked schemes of the perverse demon: he made him discover that the very one he had seduced by saying he would become God if he ate the forbidden fruit was truly both God and man. Thus, since, as I have said, the intention was the following: to undertake the battle once more to repair the defeat, he hypostatically united, with the exception of sin, as we have said, the entire human composite, which was by nature corruptible and mortal, which had been defeated and had lost the grace of immortality; in this way, by grappling with the devil in what is mortal and suffering, by coming to blows as in a struggle, he was to, through the voluntary death of redemption, achieve victory in accordance with the Law and the demands of justice. For, having tasted death in what is mortal, he was able to conquer the one who had the power of death, that is, the devil (Hebrews 2:14). naturally capable of suffering, that is to say in the flesh, he also demonstrated that the enemy was defeated by the resurrection; through it, he resurrected all of humankind, revealing himself to us as the firstborn among the dead. Indeed, he accomplished

and effected all this for us who believe in him, who are baptized in the likeness of his death, and who, to the extent possible, imitate the three days of his burial through our triple immersion in the mysterious waters, from which we draw the strength and assurance of a resurrection, even if we undergo common death and the corruption of nature. For baptism, conferred in the death of our Lord, is a regeneration; he came to experience death in the flesh and tasted it only in itself, as it is written, and by his resurrection, he destroyed the power of death. Thus, writing to the Hebrews, the very wise Paul taught that The Word of God shared the same nature as ours, as it was subject to the power of death, so that by confronting death in it, he might destroy its power along with Satan, who had brought it upon us. He indeed said, "Since the children have flesh and blood, he too shared in their humanity, so that by his death he might break the power of him who holds the power of death—that is, the devil—and free those who all their lives were held in slavery by their fear of death" (Hebrews 2:14-15). Here, the herald of the nations, the appointed steward of God's mysteries, proclaims the reason why the Word of God took on these traits like us, namely flesh and blood: it was because he wanted, through these elements, to confront the dominion of death, to struggle with death, and, as I have said, to undertake the battle anew to rectify our defeat.

The eminent doctors of the churches have taught throughout the ages, and John, who was the bishop of the church of Constantinople and who abundantly spread the spiritual drink, clearly attests to this in his Commentary on the Epistle to the Romans, writing, "What is great is the modality of victory. Indeed, it is not another flesh that he took, but the very same that had been humiliated, like a man who, upon seeing a vile woman publicly beaten, would claim to be her son, even though he is the son of a king, thus rescuing her from those who forcefully drag



her away. This is what he himself did: he professed to be the 'Son of Man,' he became the helper (of the flesh) and condemned sin; thus, sin dared not strike her again. Nevertheless, he struck her with the blow of death, and from this arose condemnation and perdition, not for the flesh that had been struck, but for the sin that had struck it. And this was a marvelous thing above all! Indeed, if victory had not occurred in the flesh, it would not be so marvelous, since the Law also achieved a similar effect; but what is marvelous is that victory was established with the cooperation of the flesh, which had been humiliated many times by sin, winning a splendid victory over it. Consider how many wonders have occurred: one, that sin did not conquer the flesh; another, that it was defeated and that it was defeated by the flesh itself, for not being conquered and going on to win the victory are not equivalent for what had always been humiliated; a third, that it not only defeated it but also punished it; indeed, if it is by not sinning that it did not know defeat, it is also by dying that it conquered and condemned it, making that flesh, which it had previously despised, appear as an object of fear; and thus it also destroyed its power and killed the death that had entered through sin. Indeed, as long as it made sinners its prey, it imposed death upon them in accordance with the demands of justice; but since it delivered to death a body it found without sin, it was condemned for having violated justice. You see how many victories have been won: the flesh is not conquered by sin, the flesh even conquers and condemns it; it does not merely condemn it, but it condemns it because it has sinned. For it begins by reproaching it for having violated justice and condemns it on that basis, not simply by virtue of its power and authority, but according to the demands of justice. This is indeed what he made clear by saying, 'For sin, he condemned sin in the flesh,' as if to say: he reproached it for having gravely failed in justice and then condemned it. You have seen that it is sin that was condemned everywhere and not the flesh, but that the flesh

triumphed even and pronounced a judicial sentence against it. Now, if he says that he 'sent his Son in the likeness of sinful flesh,' do not think that his flesh is different; indeed, it is because he said 'a flesh of sin' that he added 'likeness.' For Christ did not have sinful flesh, but while being similar to our sinful flesh, it was without sin and was also, by nature, the same as ours; thus, it follows from this that the nature of the flesh is not evil. It is not after having taken another flesh instead of the first or after having transformed it in its nature that Christ prepared it to resume the battle in that state; rather, by allowing it to persist in its nature, he made it wear a crown (of triumph) over sin, and then, after the victory, he resurrected it and made it immortal.

Your piety will undoubtedly have clarified from what the doctors have said that he who arranged our redemption confronted death in mortal flesh, renewed the battle, and won the victory to repair our defeat by making the flesh that was subject to death immortal through his resurrection. For the doctor clearly stated of our Lord's flesh, "And then, after the victory, he resurrected it and made it immortal," after having said that Christ did not have sinful flesh, but that, while being similar to our sinful flesh, it was without sin and the same as our nature.

Thus, we already know that, regarding the corruption resulting from sin, there is not the slightest trace of it in the flesh of our Lord, for it was holy and without sin from the moment of his conception. The holy Scriptures also proclaim this clearly through the prophecy of Isaiah: "Before the child knows good and evil, he will reject the evil" and further, "He committed no sin, and no deceit was found in his mouth" (Isaiah 7:15; Isaiah 53:9). That he was subject to the corruption that comes from death, to other sufferings, and to blameless passions, which do not fall under the guilt of sin, because he is by nature mortal and subject to death, and that all these traits were indeed found in him,

this is what we profess. For it was not by an effect of his power and might, as the Doctor has said, but according to the demands of justice that Emmanuel wished to renew the battle to repair our fall. Now, it was impossible for this to be realized according to justice if he had not contended with death in a flesh that was subject to it, and if he had not thereby shown the resurrection to be effective, rendering incorruptible and immortal the flesh in which he had accepted to undergo the trial of death. Indeed, although, according to the prophecy of Isaiah, at the time of his voluntary sufferings, he was without appearance and glory and had neither grace nor beauty, but his appearance was despised and disfigured compared to that of all men, and he was a man of sorrows, he nonetheless bore our infirmities; he himself bore our sins on the tree, willingly taking upon himself our crimes, and he alone was sufficient to carry the weaknesses of us all. For he was truly God, even when, without undergoing alteration, he became incarnate and became like us. And this is why the prophet also said: "Because of the sins of my people, he was led to death" and without limiting himself to this, he also added: "His life was taken away from the earth" (Isaiah 53:8): it is indeed the life of one who, by his will, descended into death that was taken away from the earth. And he was exalted, he walked and passed above the heavens, because he was the King of glory, the substantial Life according to his nature, and the Lord of hosts. He also occupies a throne in the heights, so that even the heavenly hosts have recognized and confessed him, although, due to the economy realized for us and the voluntary stripping away, he became subject to the reproach arising from passions and to the contemptible character of what is on earth, which was normally given to him by the flesh that was united to him hypostatically and without separation. The passion and reproach had arisen in it, and while striving to attack the incarnate God, they were incapable of reaching the Impassible, because there lies the impossibility.

The holy bishop John reaffirms these words in the eightieth book of his Commentary on the Gospel of John, writing as follows: “Glorify me, Father, with the glory I had with you before the world existed.” And where does this glory reside? If it happens that you were among men, normally devoid of glory because of the garment that covered you, how could you seek to be glorified also before God? What does he mean here? It is a matter of economy, since the nature of the flesh had not yet been glorified, it did not enjoy incorruptibility, nor did it share in the throne of royalty. That is why he did not say “on earth,” but “with you.” It is from this same glory that we too will enjoy our measure, if we have been vigilant. This is why Paul also said, “If we suffer with him, we will also be glorified with him” (Romans 8:17). What could be more illuminating than these words that clearly show that the doctor is again speaking of the flesh, of which he had previously said that the Emmanuel resurrected it and made it immortal after having grappled with death, that it enjoyed incorruptibility which it did not have before his passion? For the Wise One willed—not because he was incapable of making his flesh incorruptible, impassible, and immortal from the very moment of his union with it, that is, from the instant he became incarnate—that it be by virtue of the demands of justice, and not by the effect of the abundance of his divine power, that he renewed the battle: to repair our defeat, it was in a passible, corruptible, and mortal flesh that he fought with death and uprooted it, becoming the firstborn among the dead, so that we, after the trial of death, might enjoy, from the resurrection of the dead, immortality and glory in the kingdom of heaven. For the Doctor has said: “It is from this same glory that we too will enjoy our measure, if we have been vigilant.” Indeed, the Word of God, who lacked nothing, did not wish for anything to be added to him by the incarnation to increase his glory—for we have seen his glory, the glory that the only Son receives from his Father, full of grace and truth (John 1:14)—but

he humbled himself by becoming man without undergoing any change; he comported himself with us according to our measures, he was proposed as the way to follow in all our vicissitudes that he himself traversed, and he truly died in a flesh subject to death; thus, by the resurrection of the dead, he inaugurated for us immortality, incorruptibility, and impassibility, so that we too might walk in his footsteps. How then could it be a disgrace for one who, while being rich as God, is poor because he became incarnate, to undertake, in a corruptible, passible, and mortal flesh, a struggle that was imposed upon us, to triumph over death, borrowing traits that are ours, a victory in accordance with justice and not due to violence, and to chart for all of us believers, to whose nature he participated in becoming incarnate, a path that leads to resurrection, to immortality, and to incorruptibility?

Consider, I pray you, that this same Doctor, in his Commentary on the Epistle to the Romans, says: “Do not allow the body to live now, so that it may live then; kill it so that it does not die. For if it remains alive, it will not live, but if it dies, then it will live.” This will also occur at the general resurrection: it must first die and be buried, and then it will become immortal. This is what also happened at baptism: he was first crucified and then buried, and then he rose again. This is what also happened to the body of the Lord: he too was crucified and died, and then he rose again. Let us behave likewise: let us always mortify it in its actions, I do not mean the nature, not at all, but the impulse that leads to evil actions, since that is also life, or rather, is that life?—to tolerate nothing that is human and not to become slaves to our desires. In all things, therefore, Christ has become for us a guide, as he himself said in the Gospel, because he took upon himself the likeness of us, with the exception of sin. By nature, he was indeed of our kind, and not by sin, which is not an entity but a weakness of the will. What our nature is, its definition shows: it includes all rational

and mortal animals capable of intelligence and knowledge. Thus, the wise Cyril also wrote: "Here, my friend, is the definition of human nature, which is also called essence: a rational and mortal animal." Similarly, in the sixth book of the Commentary on the Gospel of John, he states: "The notion of man, that is, the definition of his essence: a rational and mortal animal, capable of intelligence and knowledge.

Thus, the author of our nature, who made it both mortal and rational, has hypostatically united himself with that very nature he created, being one from two perfect elements, divinity and humanity, and the same, God and man, in a single hypostasis and a single nature incarnate of the Word himself, to restore to us what we lacked, namely the grace of immortality through the resurrection, which is the return to our original state. For what he said when he was preparing to undergo voluntary crucifixion and to take on, through death, the battle against Satan, who held power over death, is not equivalent to saying, "It is impossible for me to have a passible and mortal body," but rather, "It is impossible to see in me the slightest sin or a trace of guilt or fault." It is the devil who first invented sin, and it is he alone who possesses, so to speak, that sin, which is neither a substance nor a hypostasis, but an infirmity affecting the will of those who love sin, who are inclined to the unrestrained desires to commit wrongs that are carried out in the world; and for this reason, he is also called "Prince of the world" because he has become the principle and guide of the evil that has spread throughout the world. This is what the Evangelist John also stated in his letter: "Do not love the world, nor the things of the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him; for all that is in the world, the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life, is not of the Father but is of the world" (1 John 2:15-16). And this is why our Lord also said to the disciples in the Gospel: "You are not of this world" (John 17:14), meaning: of the pleasures of

passions and of lawlessness, of which the devil is the principle. For the author and king of human nature, as well as of any other creature, is the Word of God, Christ, with the Father and the Holy Spirit. Indeed, even if it has been stripped of the grace of immortality due to Adam's defection, is it not, even in this state, an object formed by the one who created it? And the fact that he chose to incarnate in mortal flesh, endowed with intelligence, to achieve a rightful victory over Satan, who holds the power of death, did not bring him disgrace. For if Christ had been the cause for which human composition lost the grace of immortality, like the first Adam who sinned, the mortal condition of the flesh would have accused him; but if he found it mortal, sick, and weak, if he took it on as a physician, hypostatically uniting himself with it and fighting in it against the one who held the power of death, then, since there was no trace of sin in him—because he did not commit any, he who cannot fail in justice—it is quite justly that he said before the redemptive crucifixion: "The Prince of the world comes and he has nothing in me" (John 14:30).

This is further attested by the glorious and authoritative words of Cyril in the tenth book of his Commentary on the Gospel of John, where he writes, "But the prince of this world comes, and he has nothing in me; let us understand: I will not be convicted of injustice, but there will be no legitimate reason for the Jews to repudiate me, and Satan possesses nothing in me that belongs to him; for indeed, evils belong to him, and the emergence of sin finds its principle in him." Sin, then, is the death of the soul; it provokes in her the separation and deprivation of God, who is true life. As for the death of the body, it is conceived only as a separation from the soul and from this present sensible life. Saint Gregory, Bishop of Nyssa, expresses the same idea in his Catechetical Discourse: "Just as we call death the separation of the flesh from sensible life, so also, regarding the soul, we give the name of death to

the separation from true life." In this same sense, it is said that Satan is dead and has been rendered powerless, and at the same time, those armies that transgressed with him, because he has been deprived of God, who is true life. Thus, in his fall, he heard God say to him, as Isaiah states, "As for you, you will be banished to the mountain, like a corpse that is a horror, with many corpses struck by the sword that go down to Sheol" (Isaiah 14:15-19).

Who, then, is the one who acts irrationally and opposes the divine Scriptures to the point of calling the death of our God and Savior Jesus Christ, which is nothing other than the separation of the soul from the body, a separation from God that results from the presence of sin in the soul, while he himself committed no sin and no deceit was found in his mouth? Therefore, let no one reject, out of attachment to vain pretexts, the true and redemptive death he suffered in the flesh, which had to occur in a body capable of being the second Adam, the head of the body of the Church, the firstborn from the dead; he, by the resurrection, made his flesh, which was previously corruptible and suffering and mortal, incorruptible, impassible, and immortal, becoming for us the way and the principle of our resurrection, our incorruptibility, our impassibility, and our immortality.

The words of Saint John, Bishop of Constantinople, in his Commentary on the Evangelist Matthew, reaffirm these ideas when he clarifies what our Lord said to his disciples: "From now on I will not drink of this fruit of the vine until the day when I drink it anew with you" and adds the following: "Indeed, you who are my witnesses, you will see me resurrected. And what does this word 'new' mean? In a new manner, that is to say, in a way that is not customary, since I no longer have a passible body, but now an immortal and incorruptible one that does not experience the need for food. Therefore, it is not out of necessity that he ate and drank after the resurrection—his body no



longer had that need—but to confirm the fact of the resurrection.

The doctrinal word thus proclaims more loudly and with greater clarity than a trumpet that incorruptibility, impassibility, and immortality are one and the same thing, and that what is corruptible is mortal and subject to suffering, and that the body of our Lord, after the resurrection, possessed incorruptibility, impassibility, and immortality. Therefore, why did your Holiness say, while considering his opponent, “How can one not believe that incorruptibility affected the passible body of our Lord, even when he voluntarily suffered for others?” Furthermore, “How will you also understand this word of Saint Cyril: ‘From now on incorruptible’? Not that he was previously corruptible, but that he was only considered as being corruptible, and that he was manifested only after the resurrection as being incorruptible.” Additionally, “What is corruptible by its common nature, and not in any other way—indeed, it was assumed from what is corruptible—has been manifested as incorruptible through the union with the Word, not contracting any corruption either in conception or in death, as if it escaped the common character of our nature,” as Gregory of Nyssa also states in the catechetical discourse.

Let us examine how these ideas align with the words of the orthodox doctors who, with the help of the Holy Spirit, have elucidated the thought of the holy Scriptures. The venerable John, in the texts cited above, writes in his own terms that the flesh of our Lord did not enjoy incorruptibility before the resurrection and states, "Since the nature of the flesh had not yet been glorified, it did not enjoy incorruptibility nor did it partake of the throne of royalty." And you, who love God, have said that incorruptibility always affected the passible body of our Lord, even when he voluntarily suffered for others. Therefore, if he was incorruptible, impassible, and immortal, how do you call him the same, passible? For, being incorruptible and impassible, he ceased to be

naturally capable of suffering! Thus, the death of our Lord is an imaginary thing and not a truth. How could death have seized one who is immortal, incorruptible, and impassible? He who possessed the power of death, according to the word of Paul (Hebrews 2:14), would not have been destroyed if he had not been defeated by what he possessed. This is why the Apostle said that the Word of God shared with us blood and flesh, to destroy by his death him who had the power of death, that is, Satan. If, by the very fact that the Word became flesh, his flesh was incorruptible, impassible, and immortal, the power of death was already destroyed, the cross of Christ was superfluous, and it was in vain that the Apostle said, "to destroy by his death him who had the power of death." For he was already completely destroyed by the fact that the flesh was not subject to death nor to passions free from sin. But it is not so, no, it is not so, nor is it as you say: "...not that he was previously corruptible, but that he was considered to be corruptible and that he was 'manifested only by the resurrection as not being corruptible.'" For if it is concerning the corruptibility characterized by sin and shameful passions that you say the flesh of Christ was incorruptible, impassible, and holy from the very union, it did not require that this state be manifested by the resurrection, as you have said. Indeed, he had in his favor the testimony of his impeccability—"who committed no sin, and in whose mouth no deceit was found" (1 Peter 2:22)—that he rejected evil, as it is written, from the very cradle and that he was in perfect possession of good, because he was God and also good by nature, he who truly took upon himself to incarnate and become man. This is why he also said to the Jews with an assurance befitting God: "Which of you convicts me of sin?" (John 8:46).

But if you say that in the suffering he voluntarily endured when he was crucified and experienced the trial of scourging and other similar

tortures, his flesh was incorruptible and impassible even before the resurrection, and that it was called corruptible and passible solely because it was taken from our corruptible and passible nature and race, while from the very moment of union it possessed incorruptibility, impassibility, and immortality, then the voice of the teachers of the mysteries of truth rises up absolutely against this assertion. Indeed, we have heard John declare in the texts cited a little earlier: "For Christ did not have sinful flesh, but one that, while being similar to our sinful flesh, was without sin and by nature the same as ours, so that it follows from this that the nature of flesh is not bad" (Romans 8:3). It is not after having taken another flesh instead of the first or after having transformed it in its nature that Christ prepared it to resume the battle in this state; rather, by allowing it to persist in its nature, he crowned it with a triumph over sin, and then, after the victory, he resurrected it and made it immortal. By these two things, he clearly made it understood that after the resurrection he rendered it incorruptible and immortal, and that before the resurrection he allowed it to persist in its nature so that it might renew the battle to repair our defeat and conquer death through what is, according to its nature, mortal, passible, and capable of suffering and dying. On the other hand, this same flesh, of which the same teacher has said here that it became immortal through the resurrection, he has called both incorruptible, impassible, and immortal. For we have heard him declare also this: "...because he does not have a passible body, but now an immortal and incorruptible one that does not experience the need for food. Therefore, it was not out of necessity that he ate and drank after the resurrection, for the body no longer experienced that need, but to confirm the fact of the resurrection" (Luke 24:43). Furthermore, he demonstrates in the Commentary on the First Epistle to the Corinthians that it is not from the incarnation but rather following the death and resurrection of Christ that immortality and the destruction of the tyranny of death and its

power occurred, when he writes: "Have you seen how gradually, due to their discourse and their unbelief in the resurrection, the entire economy is destroyed? However, until now he has said nothing about the incarnation but about the resurrection! For it is not by being incarnate but by dying that he destroyed death, since, when he had flesh, the tyranny of death held him in its power.

The Fathers do not say that the holy and sinless body of our God and Savior Christ is impassible and incorruptible before the resurrection, but rather that it is capable of suffering and, since it is naturally apt to endure and be subject to natural passions, provided they are blameless, it is corruptible, and that he truly experienced these infirmities that were his, with the permission of the Word and when he wished; they do not say, as your Holiness has declared, that he was considered corruptible because he assumed a corruptible nature, but that in reality he is neither corruptible nor apt to suffer from the moment of the incarnation, which is further demonstrated by the same doctor John in the seventy-seventh discourse of his Commentary on the Gospel of John, when he comments on the words of Christ: "Now my soul is troubled..." elucidating: "As if someone were saying: 'Even if we are troubled and even if we are in fear, let us not flee from death, since I too, who am troubled at the moment, do not speak of fleeing'; for we must endure what comes. I do not say: 'Deliver me from this hour,' but what? 'Father, glorify your name.' Indeed, that very thing which troubled me led me to say the opposite: 'Glorify your name,' that is to say: 'From now on, lead me to the cross.' He emphasizes very well the humanity and the nature that does not want to die but seeks to live the life of this world, indicating that it was not outside of human passions. For just as neither hunger nor sleep are reprehensible, neither is delighting in the life of this world. Now Christ had a body free from sin, but not exempt from natural necessities; otherwise, there would

have been no body at all. However, in expressing himself this way, does the Doctor deny that Emmanuel voluntarily experienced these? Not at all! But on the royal path, without deviating to the right or to the left, as it is written, his exposition of the orthodox faith progresses in its midst. Indeed, he says in the eighty-fifth discourse of his Commentary: "After this, knowing that all was accomplished," let us understand that nothing was lacking in the Economy. For he always strove to show that his death was a strange thing, if it is true that everything was in the power of the one who died and that death reached his body only at the moment he himself wished. Now he wanted it to happen after he had accomplished everything. That is why he also said: "I have power to lay it down and I have power to take it again" (John 10:18). Therefore, knowing that all was accomplished, he said: "I thirst" (John 19:28). And here again he fulfilled a prophecy.

This very text was explained by the eminent Cyril, who is the treasure of all expressions of doctrine, in the twelfth book of his Commentary on the Gospel of John. Indeed, we must weave a chain that is suspended in heaven as to truth and holds its reasons from above, which is truly golden due to the tested and unaltered character of the exposition, and we must make it clear that the harmonious voice of the doctors is one. What Cyril stated is presented as follows: "When all the impiety stemming from the wickedness of the Jews against Christ was completed, and nothing more was lacking for their cruelty, which exceeded reason, to fully appear, in the end, the flesh experienced something that is proper and natural to it. It allowed itself to be penetrated by thirst, having been dried out due to various wounds. This is because violent pains generally provoke an overwhelming thirst, absorbing, under the effect of an inexpressible physical heat, the moisture found in the depths of the body and consuming, through inflammatory pangs, the interior of the patient. It was not difficult, in

fact, for the Word of God, who can do all things, to also remove this from his flesh. But since he had willed to endure all the rest, he also experienced this by will. That is why he asked for something to drink. You have noticed the rigorous accuracy. By stating that suffering was natural to the flesh, he did not separate thirst from it; rather, he also added this: while the Word of God made flesh—a flesh that is such according to its nature—could repel this suffering, he himself voluntarily experienced it, just as he did all the others, he who is above all sufferings, and he asked for something to drink, he who is the life and sustenance of all; for the flesh, which is naturally inclined to thirst, was his and it asked for something to drink.

In the same book, the wise servant of the Word states, "It is therefore in complete accordance with the economy that, at that time when he had not yet transformed his temple into the glory that is due and fitting for him, our Lord Jesus Christ appeared in his original forms, because he wanted to reveal the truth of the resurrection not in another form and another body, but in the one he had taken from the Virgin, in which he died after the crucifixion, as it is written, the power of death rushing upon the flesh alone from which it was also expelled. For if it is not his body that experienced death that has risen, what death has been conquered? And where would the power of corruption have found itself without strength, when none among rational creatures has died, neither soul nor angel, not to mention the Word of God? Therefore, when the power of death was only felt upon that which is naturally subject to corruption, it is rightly understood that it is also upon this that the power of the resurrection operates. Our Lord enters through closed doors; he is ranked among the other wonders by the wise." Thus, shall we still contest that Saint Cyril, the other admirable heralds, and the doctors of sound faith have said that the body of our Lord was passible and corruptible before the resurrection, not because,

as your piety has said, it was assumed from our passible and corruptible nature and race, but because it was naturally apt to be corrupted, to suffer, and to be subjected to natural passions free from sin, as well as to death, so that the tyranny and power of death might be destroyed by the resurrection? And this is why the doctor said, "If it is not his body that experienced death that has risen, what death has been conquered? And where would the power of corruption have found itself without strength?" Thus, the victory over death and the weakening of corruption have come about through the resurrection.

It is through this resurrection that Peter, chosen among the apostles, declared that it was realized and accomplished for our Lord not to remain under the power of death, and for his flesh not to see corruption. He did not say that it was because he did not die that he did not remain under the power of death, but he spoke to the crowd of Jews about our Savior Christ, saying, "This one, as he had been predestined by God, you delivered into the hands of the wicked, you crucified and killed" and he added, "It is he whom God raised up, having loosed the pains of death"—and from now on he introduced the resurrection—"because it was not possible that he should be held by it," signifying by "held" eternal detention. It is excellently said that he called the resurrection the "loosing of the pains of death" because Christ rose from the bonds of death and the depths of Sheol as from the womb that experiences the pains of childbirth, and that, by the resurrection, he was as if born from a wonderful birth. Hence, he is also called the "Firstborn from the dead": the prophet Jonah and the belly of the fish prefigured this well. Indeed, he who, while being devoured and alive in the belly, said, as emanating from the person of our Savior whom he prefigured, in addressing a prayer to God the Father, who took pleasure in delivering us from the bonds of corruption through the death of his Only Begotten: "From the depths of

Sheol you have heard my voice!" and again: "Bring my life up from corruption to you, O Lord my God," he calls "the womb of Sheol and corruption" the belly of the fish, which prefigured the true womb of Sheol and corruption, where Emmanuel, when he was there, was not held because of the resurrection. This is also why the Apostle Peter, reiterating the expression, again speaks of the resurrection, for which, he says concerning Christ, he was not abandoned to Sheol, and his flesh did not see corruption. Indeed, this is how he speaks of the prophet David: "For he was a prophet and knew that God had sworn to him to seat one of his descendants upon his throne; foreseeing this, he spoke concerning the resurrection of Christ: he was not abandoned to Sheol, nor did his flesh see corruption" (Acts 2:30-31).

This is what Saint Cyril also understood, as he comments on the prophet Jonah, saying, "But we find the divine Peter attributing to him what was said by the voice of David: 'Because you have not abandoned my soul to Sheol, nor have you allowed your Holy One to see corruption' (Psalm 16:10). For his flesh did not see corruption; he indeed rose on the third day because it was impossible that, being life by nature, he could be held by the bonds of death." That his flesh did not see corruption but was incorruptible and immortal is what Peter assigned to the resurrection on the third day, as well as to the fact that he was not held by the bonds of death, which signifies complete detention. For no one opposes the divine Scriptures to the point of saying that the body of Christ our Savior, that is, the incarnate Word, was in any way subject to the power of death or that he tasted it in a flesh that was subject to death. Indeed, we have heard him say in a previously cited text, "...the power of death rushing upon the flesh alone from which it was also expelled. For if it is not his body that experienced death that has risen, what death has been defeated? And how could the power of corruption have been found without strength,



when none among rational creatures has died, neither soul nor angel, not to mention the Word of God? Therefore, when the power of death was felt only upon that which is naturally subject to corruption, it is rightly and truly understood that it is also upon this that the power of resurrection operates, so that the strength of the tyrant may also be destroyed." Furthermore, in the treatise he composed for the pious Emperor Theodosius regarding the complete detention that results from the descent into hell and burial, and the corruption that ensues, he speaks thus: "For it is not permissible to say that it was ever possible for the flesh united to the Word to become prey to corruption, nor that the divine soul was held captive by the gates of Sheol; for he was not abandoned to hell, as blessed Peter also said." Now, if, as your Holiness has said, we understand the word "never" without discrimination, in the sense that the corruption resulting from passion has in no way approached the flesh and that it did not experience the trial of death, nor hunger, nor thirst, nor the pains or wounds of crucifixion, Saint Cyril intervenes to respond! Explaining himself, he tells us and cries out forcefully, on multiple occasions, the same things: it is in that which is naturally apt to corruption, in which the power of death was felt, that the power of resurrection operates; and if it is not his body that experienced death that has risen, what death has been defeated, and where would the power of death have been found without strength? Thus, on one hand, corrupting death took possession of that which was naturally apt to corruption, to suffer and to die, and Emmanuel died for us all in the flesh; on the other hand, that which held him in its power was found powerless by the resurrection, vomiting, like the fish did with Jonah, the one it had devoured. In the same way, Proclus, also of blessed memory, who was bishop of Constantinople, in a homily delivered in the church of Anthemius, where he celebrated the feast of the saving passion, said in few words: "Death has vomited the one it had devoured without knowing him; the

tomb, the treasure of resurrection...

But your piety, wishing to confirm its exposition, deemed it necessary to take the term corruption in its etymological sense: in this way, one would understand that Christ was in no way tempted and that he did not experience the corruption of suffering and death itself, which occurs only in a body naturally subject to corruption, as the very wise Cyril has said. You indeed wrote this: "Thus it has been said that he did not see corruption." Now, the profane say that corruption is the path that leads, as through a transition, to death. If he did not see corruption from the beginning, how could he have fallen under death, which was revealed neither at the beginning nor at the end? To whom among the wise profane do you refer for such a statement? I cannot know, for I am personally without competence and still a novice in profane wisdom: indeed, after having begun to apply myself somewhat to it, I quickly despised it in comparison to the philosophy that is attached to Christ and out of attraction to simpler concerns. But I know, yes, I know clearly that Saint Cyril, who was very well-versed in both profane and sacred wisdom, indiscriminately called death corruption, implying that there was no difference between them. What the prophet David and the Apostle Peter called corruption—one, by saying, "You have not permitted your Holy One to see corruption" (Acts 2:27), and the other, by writing, "And his flesh did not see corruption" (Acts 2:31)—is the very thing that the very wise Cyril called death, adding the words of the Apostle: "It is not permitted to say that it was possible for the flesh united to the Word to become prey to death, nor that the divine Soul was held captive by the gates of hell; for he was not abandoned to hell, as the divine Peter also said." But the words of the inspired writings, which David himself pronounced, "You have not permitted your Holy One to see corruption," give to this last, in the prophet Jonah, the name of death. He, who was in the belly of the fish,

prefiguring the one who was in the womb of hell, cried out: "You will bring up my life from the pit" (Jonah 2:6). Now, it is in commenting in the heart of the earth for three days and three nights that he even reached the sources of the sea and advanced into the depths. He penetrated into the ravines of the mountains and descended to the earth, whose locks are the laws that govern it eternally. After he had depopulated hell, made a proclamation to the spirits there, and destroyed the invincible gates, he came out again; for his life rose from death. All this attests that death and corruption are terms used without discrimination.

It is indeed very easy for us to demonstrate through divine words that the term "destruction" does not equate to an entry, a beginning, or a transition, as you have said, but rather refers to the complete and abundant possession of authentic destruction, which is separation from God. For the death of man, by dissolving the composite and corrupting the very one who is its prey, does not necessarily imply, furthermore, separation from God. Indeed, as the prophet David sings and teaches, "precious in the sight of the Lord is the death of his saints" (Psalm 116:15) and conversely, "the death of the wicked is the worst" (Psalm 34:21). Who then is unaware that no one has been more corrupted than the devil, who has been corrupted by an authentic and complete destruction? And behold, God himself, speaking through the prophet Ezekiel, said to him, "Your wisdom and your beauty have perished; it is because of the multitude of your sins that I have cast you to the ground" (Ezekiel 28:17). And David, resorting to the term "destruction" to denote complete perdition, says, "And you, O God, have brought them down to the pit of destruction" (Psalm 55:24). Similarly, Jeremiah said, "And I went to the Euphrates River; I dug and took the belt that I had hidden there; and behold, it was ruined and unusable" (Jeremiah 13:7). Furthermore, "And I will bring against

them four kinds of destroyers, says the Lord: the sword to kill, the dogs to tear, the beasts of the earth, and the birds of the heavens to devour and to destroy them" (Jeremiah 15:3). However, it would be superfluous to cite other similar words; for it is now known, through the texts we have cited, that destruction does not indicate the beginning or entry into destruction, but rather its end, and that the injury penetrates into the one who is its victim and completely seizes him, like arrows piercing a body that is struck, or like a flame of fire sweeping through a forest that it devours entirely. I have added this, while having previously stated that in the treatises the terms "destruction" and "perdition" are used without discrimination.

In the second book of the work called *The Treasure*, the eminent Cyril writes in harmony with what has been said earlier: "For since he took a corruptible, mortal body and was subjected to similar sufferings, he necessarily appropriated, along with the flesh, its sufferings; and as the flesh endured them, he himself is said to have endured them. Thus, we say that he was crucified and that he died, while it was the flesh itself that underwent all this and not the Word taken in isolation." Furthermore, in the *Letter to the Monks*, which begins with "Some have come...", he writes: "How then is it said that he who was alive is dead? By undergoing death in his own flesh, so that, by vivifying this flesh again, he appears alive." Shortly thereafter, he adds: "For if he had not suffered for us according to humanity, he would not have accomplished for us, according to divinity, what pertains to our salvation. It is indeed said that he died first as a man and that afterward he returned to life because he is God by nature.

The words of doctrine emit a ray brighter than the sun, openly proclaiming that it is in a mortal, corruptible body, subject to ungovernable passions, that the Word of God, Christ, was crucified, suffered, and died; he who, without change, became incarnate, vivified

his flesh through the resurrection, and made it incorruptible. Now, if from the moment of the union he was incorruptible, impassible, and immortal, how could he have returned to life through the resurrection? For "not having been the prey of corruption" means not having remained in it and not experiencing or undergoing dissolution in the tombs, like other dead, who have not returned from the graves or from hell, but have been completely seized by death, which exerts its dominion even over those who have not sinned and holds them all in an equal manner; this is clearly shown in the book of Acts. Indeed, it presents Paul, pronouncing the same words as Peter before the crowd of Jews, recalling the same prophetic words and revealing the meaning we have stated, in these terms: "That he was raised from the dead and would not return to corruption, this is what he declares: I will grant you the holy things assured to David" (Acts 13:34). This is why he says elsewhere: "You will not allow your Holy One to see corruption" (Acts 13:35). David indeed served his generation, fell asleep by the will of God, was gathered to his fathers, and saw corruption. But the one whom God raised did not see corruption.

Here is the wise Cyril, who, while we do not have the competence to explain what pertains to him, clearly and expressively shows that for Christ, the fact of "not seeing corruption" or "not being the prey of corruption" means that he does not remain in the tomb; similarly, the fact that his soul is not abandoned to Sheol indicates that it descended there and was under the gates of hell, yet it was not held there, but rose up, thus forcing the locks and bars that could not be broken. It was necessary for him to pass through everything we had gone through, with the exception of sin, and through all of this, he destroyed the power of death, not only as a mighty God but also as a man who himself was above condemnation and had not even provided death with any reason to be incriminated, except for being free among the

dead, as it is written. The exposition of the Doctor, written in Letter 4 to Acacius regarding the question of Azazel, is as follows: "Let us see then in the scapegoat Emmanuel reduced to death according to the flesh, but for the destruction of death and sin. For he was free among the dead, that is to say, he was not convicted of sin, nor was he subject to a death sentence with us. Let us also see him in the other goat, the one that is alive and expelled, who, while suffering according to humanity, did not suffer according to divinity, and, while being dead according to the flesh, was above death, who, according to the estimation of the Jews, did not remain with us in the tombs and was not held with the others by the gates of hell. Indeed, as his disciple said, 'he was not abandoned to Sheol, and his flesh did not see corruption'; for he returned to life and stripped Sheol, and he said to the prisoners, 'Come out,' and to those who were in darkness, 'Show yourselves!'"

Saint John, Bishop of Constantinople, also writes in the sixth discourse of his Commentary on the Epistle to the Colossians: "There was a kind of singular combat. Death struck Christ, but Christ, while he had been struck, ultimately killed it himself: it is in a mortal body that that which believed itself to be immortal was destroyed." Thus, the immortal and indestructible power of death over humankind was not destroyed by the fact that Christ did not die, but rather after Christ's death, through the resurrection, because the body was not the prey of total corruption and destruction resulting from death and burial, but rather, through the resurrection, he made the tomb the seat of incorruptibility. In the fourth discourse of his Commentary on the Epistle to the Hebrews, he writes the following: "He who was momentarily made lower than the angels, we see that it is Jesus, because of the death with which he was affected. And after that, on the contrary, these privileges of being crowned with glory and honor." Have you seen how he applied all this? Indeed, that "momentarily," what other term could apply than that of one who was

in Sheol for only three days, and not to us who suffer corruption for a long time?

Athanasius, in his treatise *On the Faith* directed against the impious Apollinaris, speaks of our Savior Christ, saying, "He has thus accomplished the condemnation of sin on earth, the abrogation of the curse on the wood, the suppression of corruption in the tomb, and the destruction of death in Sheol. It is to achieve the salvation of every man that he passed through all things, showing in his person the resemblance to our image. Otherwise, why would God require the birth from a woman, or the ages the growth in stature and the counting of years, or even the cross, the tomb, or hell, to which we are subjected, if he had not sought us?"

Thus, enlightened in the same manner by these doctrines, when we find some Fathers declaring that the body of Christ our Savior was not subject to the corruption of death, we should not think that he did not truly die in the flesh or that he did not experience the condition of a mortal, but rather that he was not subjected to the corruption of the tomb or to complete dissolution, thanks to the divine miracle of the resurrection. For it is evident from all these testimonies that the Word of God, through the resurrection, rendered his holy flesh incorruptible, that is to say, impassible and immortal.

However, let no one speak blasphemously about the corruption that results from sin, of which there was no trace in Christ, as we have said many times; for it is because he did not sin that the flesh is holy and incorruptible, and this is from the union with the Word of God. Thus, Cyril, the divine sage, refuted Diodore, who claimed that the holy body was an ordinary body, which first formed the child from Mary, according to his own words, and then housed God as if by mere favor: "I say, my dear, that you utter foolish and completely aberrant words by their stupidity. The holy body indeed came from Mary, but from the

very beginning of its composition and constitution in the womb, it was holy, as the body of Christ, and one cannot see a moment when it was not his, but ‘ordinary,’ as you say, and comparable to other flesh.” He also rebukes Theodore, who says that what was lacking in holiness and strength during the trial against the Enemy was supplied to our Savior Christ by the indwelling of the Holy Spirit in him in the form of a dove, and he declares the following: “That one, opening his mouth wide and wandering insatiably into blasphemy, declares that he had a defective holiness and that he was not perfect in this respect before the Holy Spirit descended upon him in the form of a dove. Therefore, it must be said in truth: How was he not perfectly holy? What is such is not exempt from sin; for one who is only partially holy is also considered partially weak. Otherwise, what deficiency would one estimate to have been filled by the Holy Spirit so that he was rendered perfectly capable of even destroying the assault of the demon and not being deficient in everything else, as the adversary has said?

He was not only holy and perfect in terms of holiness, but he was also perfect in power, healing afflictions and diseases of every kind. We even confess that he is life-giving, to the point of raising the dead, from the moment of his union with the Word, the substantial power of God the Father; not that an external operation acted in him, as it did in the prophets and the apostles, who benefited from grace, but in that he was equal in power to the Word because he was hypostatically united to him. Indeed, this same teacher, further along in the same treatise, writes: “While he is God by nature and the authentic Son of God the Father, he became in a state of resemblance to men and took on the flesh from the holy Virgin; it is the flesh of God, full of the strength appropriate to God. It is for this very reason that he is also life-giving, that he heals the sick and brings about the destruction of death.” Similar ideas are found in the fifth book of the Commentary on the



Gospel of Matthew, when, discussing Simon's mother-in-law and the healing of the fever that afflicted her, he said: "For he healed her as God, by granting the touch of his hand to one who lay ill. And for what reason? To show that his body was equal in power to his nature, I mean that of divinity, through his action on the sick. For it was not the body of an ordinary man, but of the Word who can do all things.

The reason he took on a body, so perfect in holiness and life-giving power that it even raised the dead, while maintaining the same nature that is mortal and contemptible, enduring the blows of slaps and spittle, and for which he made it, through the resurrection, immortal, glorious, and incorruptible, has been clearly shown by the doctors as indicated above: it is because Christ wanted to die our death, to undertake again, in accordance with justice, the battle to repair our defeat, and to make himself the way that leads us to glory and resurrection. Indeed, the wise John, bishop of Constantinople, has said things that haunt the ears of those who hear them: "For Christ did not have a sinful body, but one that, while being similar to our sinful flesh, was without sin and by nature the same as ours; thus it follows that the nature of the flesh is not bad." It is not, in fact, after taking another body instead of the first, or after transforming this one in its nature, that Christ prepared it to resume the battle in this state; rather, by allowing it to persist in the same nature that is his, he made it wear a crown of triumph over sin, and then, after the victory, he resurrected it and made it immortal. He also said: "... since the nature of the flesh had not yet been glorified, it did not enjoy incorruptibility and did not share in the throne of royalty. That is why he did not say 'on earth,' but 'with you.' It is from this glory that we too will enjoy, if we have been vigilant. And that is why Paul also said: 'If we suffer with him, we will also be glorified with him' (Romans 8:17)." Indeed, although Emmanuel was filled with the glory from above, since he possesses it naturally because he is God, during

the time of his humiliation and his stay among men, he did not allow his body to shine with the glory appropriate to God, which is inaccessible to anyone. For it was fitting that he be visible and not imperceptible to the men among whom he moved and for whom he became man. That is why he tolerated that it be subject to irreproachable sufferings and to death, because he wanted, as we have said, to undertake again, in accordance with justice, the battle to repair our defeat and, through his resurrection, to inaugurate, from the body that was united to him, impassibility, incorruptibility, and glory, and to establish, in favor of all humanity of which he had been the firstfruits, these considerable and wonderful privileges, as well as the resurrection of those who believe in him and are justified in him.

But let no one consider it a disgrace or ignominy that the most holy body of our Savior remained susceptible to suffering and mortal until the resurrection, and thus corruptible. Indeed, if the Word of God humbled himself to such an extent for us from the divine heights and the heavenly realms, and if he became earthly from the celestial and a slave of the Lord whom he was, believing that, to compensate for all these advantages, his sole glory resided in our salvation, what is surprising if, for our healing, he tolerated that his flesh, which came from the earth and the seed of Abraham, consubstantial with us and derived from the Holy Virgin, hypostatically united to him, became subject to sufferings and torments, to disgrace and death, in order to destroy them and achieve a legitimate victory over the empire of death and over Satan, who had triumphed over us, and so that, through his resurrection, he might become immortal and incorruptible, and that he might be glorified all the more, he who wisely passed through all our weaknesses, except for sin, and who humbled himself to the point of total self-emptying to deliver us from all the bonds in which we were held. For it is not for his own benefit that he came, he who had no need

and who had no deficiency, but to become, through his flesh which was hypostatically united to him, the way and the first fruits of the goods that will be reserved for us through the resurrection, so that in this way our condition might also imitate his, according to a measure that is sufficient and appropriate.

Indeed, Saint Cyril also provides the following teaching in the eleventh book of his Commentary on the Gospel of John: "For just as we have overcome corruption and death for the very reason that Christ, as a man, rose again for us and on our behalf, making his resurrection the origin of our deliverance from death, and the effect of this event has truly extended to us, because the one who had conquered was from us by the fact that he became man; and just as we have overcome sin, because it had previously died in Christ, who certainly transmitted this good to us as his own race, so he enables us to be bold in overcoming the world. For Christ, as a man, has conquered and opened a way for human nature. We, indeed, who previously stumbled and were defeated, have been comforted and have triumphed through him who, being from us, also conquered for us: if he had conquered as God, he would have been of no benefit to us, but since he did so as a man, it is in him that we have triumphed. For we have had 'a second Adam who came from heaven,' as it is written." Furthermore, he writes, "When the works were completed and the time that was fitting for God had arrived, he ascended to his own glory and took possession of his original honor. But while he was still clothed in human likeness, he composed an attitude of supplication and prayed as if he possessed nothing: everything that happens to man comes from God. For although, especially because he is God and begotten of God the Father, he was not devoid of the glory that is fitting for God, nevertheless, given that during the time of the economy realized for our sake he had, as it were, contracted it by assuming this despicable body, he rightly

prayed as if it had truly been removed from him." And again, he writes what we have reported above: "It is therefore in complete accordance with the economy that Our Lord Jesus Christ, while he had not yet transformed his temple into the glory that is due to him and that is fitting for him, still appeared in his original forms, because he did not want to reveal the truth of the resurrection in any other form and in any other body than the one he had taken from the Holy Virgin, in which he died after the crucifixion, as it is written." Thus, it is the same one who was Lord of glory, as God, and who was glorified, as a man, because he "became" for us without change; and he glorified himself by becoming the initiator of a similar glory for us, for whom he became the firstborn among the dead.

This teaching is clearly conveyed by the apostolic doctor Athanasius in his discourse *On the Appearance of the Word of God in the Flesh*: "It is therefore evident that it is in the flesh that the Son, the Word of God, was touched; and in both cases, divine Scripture has transmitted to us that it was the Word of life that had been touched. And when it says, 'The Holy Spirit was not yet, because Jesus was not yet glorified' (John 7:39), it is of his flesh that it declared that it had not yet been glorified. For it is not the Lord of glory who is glorified, but the flesh of the Lord of glory itself that received glory when it was raised to heaven with him. And thus, the Spirit of adoption was also not in men, because the flesh, which had been taken as the firstfruits among men, had not yet ascended to heaven. Everything that Scripture has said: 'the Son took' and 'the Son was glorified,' it has said of his humanity and not of his divinity." Furthermore, in the third book of *On the Trinity Against the Arians*, he writes: "For we must perfectly understand this, that nothing of what he said he received, he received as if he did not possess it, for he possessed it from all eternity because he is the Word of God. But it is now said that he received according to humanity, so that, taking

these goods in his flesh, they might now firmly establish themselves in us." There is therefore no reason to doubt that it is the same. As the Word and God, he was the Lord of glory, perfect in every way and complete in every aspect, to the point that when he showed only a faint ray of his glory to his disciples on the mountain—just as it can be represented by the radiance of the visible sun—they could not even bear to look at it, but fell on their faces to the ground. But it is as he became man that, arranging the economy of our salvation and tracing the path for conditions that are ours, as has been said, he allowed his flesh to be, according to its nature, subject to suffering, death, and disgrace, so that the Word himself, who cannot undergo any of these weaknesses, is said to have also suffered disgrace, suffering, and death. And it is for this reason that he became incarnate, in a flesh naturally capable of enduring all this, so that the Impassible is said to have suffered, because of the flesh in which sufferings acted and remained, and that he who is full of glory is recognized to have been glorified by the resurrection and ascension to heaven, the flesh shining with the glory that is fitting for God. And all this was established by him, as by our firstfruits, for our resurrection and elevation to the heavenly rank, thanks to the identity of race and consubstantiality with us. Indeed, the same Athanasius, in the same discourse, had previously said this as well: "In order for grace to be unlosable and firmly kept by men, he considers the gift as his own and says that he received, as man, the power that he had always possessed as God; and he declares: 'Glorify me' (John 17:5), he who glorifies others, to show that he has a flesh that needs these advantages. Therefore, since the flesh of the Word has received them—and it is by assuming this flesh that he became man—and since that which received them is in him, he himself is said to have received them.

Jules, who was a star of the Roman Church and spoke according to the spirit of the authentic doctrine of Athanasius, wrote things that align with this in the work titled *On the Punishment in Christ*, that is, concerning his body with his divinity: “And when he says, ‘Glorify me,’ this word comes from the body and concerns the glory of the body, even though it is said regarding the whole, since the whole is one. And by adding, ‘Of the glory that I had with you before the world was,’ he was referring to the divinity that is always glorified; and although this specifically concerns the divinity, it was nonetheless said globally of the composite. And thus he is consubstantial with God according to the invisible spirit, the flesh also being included under this name, since it is united to him who is consubstantial with God, and, conversely, consubstantial with men, the divinity being taken along with the body, since it is united to him who is consubstantial with us: the nature of the body is not changed by its union with him who is consubstantial with God nor by its association with the name ‘consubstantial with us,’ just as the nature of divinity has not been changed by its association with the human body nor by the designation of ‘flesh consubstantial with us.

These pitiable beings, Diodore and Theodore, have thus ignored that our Savior and Lord Jesus Christ is the only Son and that he, being God by nature, is full of glory, and that he is glorified because he became incarnate and became man for our sake; yet they divide the one who is one into two sons and declare that one is the authentic Son of God the Father, that he is Lord of glory as God from God, and that the other, taken apart from him, is a man, that he is descended from the seed of David and Mary, and that, having come from outside, he was assumed by grace due to a particular predilection of the Word of God, and that he acquires in this way, as a mark of honor, to be called the Son of God and to share in glory and sonship, according to what they

recount in their folly. They are thus confounded by the very wise Cyril, who, writing against them, teaches that the Emmanuel, because he is one, possesses everything by nature, both glory and the fact of being the authentic Son, and all that is fitting for God; he has nothing that was acquired later or that he was granted from outside, since he is recognized as God from God, and he has not lost what he was—indeed, he is immutable—while truly becoming man. Now regarding the refutation of Diodore, his language is thus conceived: “He even dares to clothe with the appearances proper to the Lord the one who, as he himself said, is a man descended from Mary, who, from the beginning, differed in no way from us, but at most, after he came from the seed, was made worthy of the name of sonship and the glory of God. Therefore, there are two sons, according to what you have said, the Christ is a new God and he has been crowned by God with an honor that surpasses nature, a degree somewhat superior to creatures, so that he who later acquired glory might be adored alongside an ordinary man, understanding this in the completion of the holy and consubstantial Trinity.

Addressing Nestorius in the fourth volume of his work *Against His Blasphemies*, he highlights the absurd and corrupt nature of this opinion and declares, "Thus, even if the Son is said to be glorified by the unique Christ, Son and Lord, confess that the incarnate God is one and the same, and similarly that he is, as God, Lord of glory and that he has, according to humanity, received glory." Furthermore, in the fifth volume, he shows that at the resurrection he vivified the flesh that had undergone death: "When you hear the theophore Paul say, 'He was crucified because of (his) weakness, but it is by the power of God that he lives,' understand it according to the faith. He indeed says that he suffered according to humanity, while, according to his nature, he was entirely above suffering. Being in this state, he submitted to weak flesh

and, after having endured death according to humanity, he was resurrected according to divinity, himself vivifying his temple, as he is the power of the Father." Similarly, in the one hundred twenty-eighth homily of his writings on the Gospel of Luke, he states, "While he is God by nature, he is said, once having become man, to have received from the Father a name above all names, so that it might be proclaimed that he was God and king of all, even with his flesh that had been united to him. But after having endured for us the sufferings on the cross and having, through his resurrection from the dead, destroyed and banished death from his body, he ascended to his Father." In the twelfth book of his Commentary on the Gospel of Matthew, he expresses similar thoughts: "For by the resurrection from the dead, the nature of men has been restored to incorruptibility, after such an event first occurred in Christ. This is why he is also called the second Adam, the firstfruits of those who sleep, and the firstborn among the dead.

It also emerges from these texts that the way, the door, and the first fruits of the resurrection of all nature, that is to say, of all humanity, were events that were accomplished in Christ our Savior, who is the second Adam, the first fruits of those who sleep and the firstborn among the dead (1 Corinthians 15:20). For his intention was not merely to reveal the excellence of the power of his divinity, but, in consideration of human weakness, to obtain healing for them and to present himself as the order and disposition of the goods that were to pass from him to us and remain permanently, as the apostolic doctor Athanasius states: "So that grace may be unlosable and firmly kept by men." Indeed, it was not because the Word of God could not, from the moment of his union with his flesh, show it as impassible, immortal, and shining with a glory inaccessible to anyone that he waited until the moment of the resurrection; rather, it was in order to become the principle of our resurrection, our immortality, our incorruptibility, and



our glory that he humbled himself and reduced, as much as possible, in light of his sublime mercy, what belongs to him to the measure of our standards, proposing his resurrection as a model and a figure exceeding all measure, which should guide everything related to the resurrection, immortality, and incorruptibility of those who believe in him. This is also clearly confirmed by the eminent Cyril in the second book of the Treasury, who writes: “Firstborn also among the dead, for he is the first to raise his flesh to incorruptibility, he who first made it ascend to heaven. That is why he said: ‘I am the way’ and ‘I am the door’: it is through him that human nature has been instructed to embark on the new path of resurrection to enter, as through a door, into heaven itself.” Furthermore, “Just as he has been called the firstborn of many brothers, because those who have been saved by him have been called by grace to divine adoption, and also the firstborn and the first fruits among the dead, in that he himself, before all, has risen for incorruptibility, so it is said that he has been created ‘the beginning of the ways’ in that through him each one can now strive for salvation.

Just as the doctors of the Church clearly convey that the flesh of our great God and Savior Christ received incorruptibility through the resurrection, becoming impassible and immortal, they also gloriously teach this other truth: that the adorable flesh is incorruptible, as it is holy and sinless, from the moment of its union with the Word. To avoid an excessive elaboration on this straightforward exposition, we will also learn this, along with the doctrinal testimonies that have been cited, through the words of the very wise Cyril, whom your piety has also quoted, found in the book called Scolies, which states: “Here, therefore, is what must be very appropriately and rightly conceived: because the Word of God, by whom all was made, wished to save what was lost, condescending to us, he lowered himself to what he was not, so that human nature might also become what it was not, being

glorified by the honor of the transcendent and divine power through union with him; and the body was truly raised to heights that surpass nature, or he lowered to conditions that are beyond nature the one who is unchangeable, as God. It was fitting that the Incorruptible should become like those who were subject to sin, so that he might destroy sin. Just as light has no effect on darkness, in the presence of incorruptibility, it was absolutely necessary for corruption to fade away, and for the one who knew no sin, by taking on what is subject to sin, to destroy sin.” This clearly shows, without any dispute, that as soon as the Word of God shared in our corruptible nature, meaning that he became incarnate and made man—since he took from the seed of Abraham, according to what is written—corruption, understood as that of sin, escaped because of the one who knew no sin, distancing itself like darkness. In this regard, the Doctor has clearly specified his language; indeed, when he says, “it was fitting that the Incorruptible participate in the nature subject to corruption to free it from corruption,” explaining what corruption he was speaking of, he added, “it was fitting that the one who knew no sin become like us who are subject to sin, so that he might destroy sin.” Again, applying himself diligently to explain the same idea with great precision and confirming it with a firm promptness free from discussion and dispute, he declares: “Just as light has no effect on darkness, so in the presence of incorruptibility, it was absolutely necessary for corruption to escape.” To show what corruption has escaped because the Incorruptible assumed a flesh that is subject to corruption, and that by this very act light appeared, he immediately added this: “The one who knew no sin took on what is subject to sin, to destroy sin.

Thus, as the language of the Doctor clearly proclaims, from the moment the Word of God took on flesh, the corruption of sin escaped him, and not even a trace of it remained, for he did not commit sin, as it

is written, and no deceit was found in his mouth (1 Peter 2:22). I am astonished—allow me to speak frankly, since we are discussing the truth—at the way your Holiness has cited this argument and other similar ones, as if they truly served your own purpose! For there is no one who disputes the corruption that resides in sin. Indeed, we all confess that the flesh of our God and Savior Christ is holy and without sin, and in this respect, it is incorruptible from the very beginning of the divine incarnation, as we have previously stated; but what was sought and what was under debate is this: you demonstrate that the flesh was not mortal before the resurrection, but rather immortal from the moment of its union with the Word, and that it was, in this respect, incorruptible, as well as being not subject to unendurable sufferings nor naturally capable of suffering, corrupting, or undergoing the trial of death. You have indeed seen how we have reported that the doctors of the holy Church say that it was in a mortal body, subject to sufferings and death, and naturally capable of corruption that Christ our God and Savior suffered and tasted death, and that it is through the resurrection that he rendered impassible, immortal, and incorruptible what was passible, mortal, and corruptible. Furthermore, the testimony you mentioned, found in the book that demonstrates that Christ is one, and which is actually cited in the book called Scolies, declares that the body is incorruptible because it is holy and pure from sin from the moment of its union with the Word. It is thus written: “The tabernacle was erected in the desert by the will of God. The Emmanuel was represented there under multiple symbols. The God of the universe then said to the holy Moses: ‘And you shall make the ark of acacia wood; its length shall be two and a half cubits, its width a cubit and a half, and its height a cubit and a half. And you shall overlay it with pure gold, inside and outside’” (Exodus 25:10-11). But the wood that does not rot will symbolize the incorruptible body, for cedar wood does not rot. As for gold, being a more precious material than others, it

signifies the excellence of the divine essence. This wood, which is incorruptible, is also called fir, from which the ark was constructed. Your Holiness has cited the testimony up to this point; however, when we supplement the missing elements in the text, they clarify the incorruptibility of the body from the moment of its union with the Word. Here are those elements: "Notice how the entire ark was covered with pure gold inside and outside." This is because the Word of God was united to a holy flesh. And this is what I believe the fact that the ark was covered with gold on the outside represents. And that he took to himself an intelligent soul that was in the body is indicated by the requirement to cover it with gold also on the inside. Thus, the addition of these words has shown how the flesh was incorruptible by the union with the Word, since the wise one clearly indicates to us: "For the Word who is God was united to a holy flesh." Therefore, in terms of holiness and absence of sin, the flesh was incorruptible at the moment of the union with the Word, but in terms of impassibility and immortality, it was so only from the resurrection.

It was fitting that Emmanuel should endure suffering for us in a mortal and suffering body, that he should die our death, and that he should render their power ineffective through the resurrection. This is further confirmed by Saint Cyril, who, in the ninth book of *On Worship in Spirit*, elucidates this question regarding Varche, declaring that the Word of God vivified his holy flesh, which was made incorruptible through its union with him, by rising from the dead on the third day. He proclaimed to the Jews, "Destroy this temple, and on the third day I will raise it up" (John 2:19), a statement he would not have made if the flesh had been impassible and immortal from the moment of the incarnation. Indeed, if it were impassible and immortal, how could it be made alive through the resurrection? The text is thus composed: "O Pallade, Parche will therefore be for us the symbol and image of

Christ. For, examining the mode of the incarnation of the Only Begotten, we see that the Word, issued from the Father, dwelt in the temple that came from the Virgin as in the ark. 'For in him all the fullness of the deity dwells bodily' (Colossians 2:9), and on the other hand, it was the Word of God that the testimonies contained in Varche referred to. Its wood was incorruptible, shining with pure and precious gold both inside and out. This is because the body of Christ was incorruptible, preserved in incorruptibility, like pure gold, by the power and splendor of the Word that dwelt in it and by the nature and vivifying action of the Holy Spirit. Thus, this is also why Christ is called Life. Indeed, as it is written, "For as the Father has life in himself, so he has granted the Son also to have life in himself" (John 5:26), the Word, issued from God the Father, by the virtue of his Holy Spirit, vivified his temple and placed it above corruption. For his flesh did not see corruption, according to the word of the Holy One. Furthermore, he also proclaimed to the Jews, "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up" (John 2:19). Peter also said, "He was put to death in the flesh, but made alive in the spirit" (1 Peter 3:18). Gold is therefore the symbol of divinity in its splendor, which was, as it were, spread over the holy body, depositing its splendor and incorruptibility in an ineffable manner known only to the divine nature and surpassing all understanding. Here is the incorruptibility that follows the resurrection of the dead, which the Word of God had deposited in his flesh through his union with it; he restored it at the time of the resurrection, saying that it was realized after the temple was destroyed and after he had died according to the flesh. He writes similar things in the tenth book of the same treatise: "For indeed, a single day truly indicates the venerable and salvific time when the Only Begotten became man, having gained for God the Father those who are on earth through the death of his flesh. The time is indeed unique; for he died only once and will die no more; death will have no more dominion

over him" (Romans 6:9). For we do not await the Son to die again for us, nor for the spirits who are in hell, nor for him to become the second firstfruits of those who sleep. Indeed, if death does not occur, how will there be a resurrection? And further: "Thus, it is certainly a famous and shining sign, sufficient for the faith of those who have a right spirit, that he is God by nature and, as Son, issued from God the Father, that he has destroyed death and that it is in him, the first, that what was subjected to death and corruption has blossomed back to life. For he has become the firstfruits of those who sleep and the firstborn from the dead. And this sign has been given to the disobedient sons, so that they may know that by the will of God the Father, Christ has become for us a holy, innocent, unstained high priest, distinct from sinners and exalted above the heavens" (Hebrews 7:26).

What Saint Gregory of Nyssa says is equally true and entirely fitting for Emmanuel, that his birth did not originate from passion and that his death did not lead to corruption: "Indeed, neither concupiscence is the origin of his birth nor does his death lead to corruption." Furthermore, what he adds is also devoid of falsehood: "He escapes the common character of our nature both by the mode of his birth and by the fact that he does not admit any alteration leading to corruption." Let us therefore question this wise and divine mystagogue: How has corruption not followed death? Could it be because our Savior Christ is said to have suffered and died in a flesh that is not subject to suffering and death? Not at all! But he answers us by saying: Because death was followed by resurrection. This is why I said that death did not turn into corruption and suffering. On the contrary, he who has risen above all nature and has destroyed the power of death is outside of all suffering and corruption. But if you please, let us hear his word which presents itself as follows: "For he who spoke of birth also added 'from the Virgin,' and he who recalled death attested, along with death, the

resurrection. Therefore, if based on what you hear, you concede that he is dead and that he is born, you will also concede, on this same basis, that his birth and his death are outside of suffering. But all this transcends nature. Thus, he who appears to be among those things that surpass nature is not also among the things of nature.

While these matters are expressed in this way, your Holiness presents the following reasoning and states: If the generation of Christ according to the flesh originated from incorruption and passed into incorruption, we are in every way compelled to acknowledge that what occurred in the interim also took place in incorruption. To this end, you have demonstrated that voluntary and blameless sufferings, hunger, fatigue, thirst, sleep, distress, sadness, anguish, scourging, blows, and the cross are not indicators of a corruptible and suffering body, but rather of an incorruptible and impassible one. These ideas, which are ancient, present themselves in this statement: "Corruption did not succeed death, just as it did not precede the incarnation." Well, the point they doubt—namely, that he who assumed in the interim the traits that pertain to our weakness, having taken on these sufferings, is not incorruptible—has been clarified by the end.

Moreover, it is stated elsewhere: "How, regarding the Lord, who was not in corruption, neither at the beginning nor at the end, are we not all the more compelled to confess that his conduct among men, which unfolded in the interval, was also free from corruption?" These texts reveal a mindset that is clearly distant from the demands of the question posed to us. For Emmanuel had a conduct free from corruption; he passed through life displaying a wholly virtuous and praiseworthy activity as long as he interacted among men, in accordance with what is written, and he presented himself as an example of virtue, as the first fruits for those who follow him: who among Christians thinks to deny this? And what is conduct but the

actions and ways of behaving? Now, the fact that has been submitted to us is as follows:—it is indeed the same thing that I repeat many times!—it is that your Holiness makes clear that the body of the Savior God was incorruptible and impassible not because it was holy and had a conduct free from sin—this, everyone will also confess—but because it was neither mortal nor subject to unendurable sufferings, the Word of God allowing, by his will, that he experience what is proper to him.

Let us therefore listen to Gregory, the wise theologian, who declared that neither the birth of Emmanuel according to the flesh nor his death shared the common characteristics of our nature; this is due to the virginity maintained even after her birth by the one who bore him and to his resurrection, which is fitting for a God. He stated regarding him that there was no trace of evil passions, which are diseases of the spirit that lead to the guilt of sin and are passions in the strict sense; however, he did experience other natural and blameless passions in a flesh that was subject to passions, which should not be called passions in the strict sense because they are free from reproach. He indeed spoke in this manner in the Catechetical Discourse: “There is a passion that is properly called such and a passion that is improperly so. The one that affects the spirit and diverts it from virtue to evil is a passion in the strict sense; on the other hand, that which unfolds according to its order and appears to proceed by natural consequence is more accurately called an action and not a passion, such as birth, growth, the sustenance of the body through the intake and evacuation of food, the assembly of elements within it, and again the dissolution of the composite and their transition into neighboring substances.” So what did our mystery say about the divinity drawing near? Was it to the passion that is said to be malice in the strict sense, or to a movement in accordance with nature? If the expositor intended to establish that the divinity was mixed with shameful things, we would have to reject the aberration of a doctrine



that would say nothing healthy about the divine nature. But if God is said to have approached the nature that is created and holds from the beginning its primary origin and sustenance, by what means does the preaching deviate from the thought that is fitting for God, since it does not introduce into the notions of faith regarding God the slightest suspicion of passibility arising from sin? We do not say of the physician who treats someone in pain that he himself is afflicted; rather, he who remedies the illness remains outside of suffering. For it is evident that although the Word of God experienced in his flesh the blameless passions, he was nonetheless impassible even under those conditions. He also uses the same expression very clearly in the fourth discourse of what he wrote Against Eunomius: "Thus the passion that is properly a disease of the spirit is not shared by him, for he committed no sin and there is no deceit in his mouth; but as for those that are proper to our nature and which, due to habit and by analogy, are also called passions, we confess that our Lord participated in them: in birth, nutrition, growth, sleep, fatigue, and everything related to bodily pains, to which the soul is usually naturally associated; such are also the desire for something necessary that, through the concupiscence of the body, extends to the soul, the feeling of sadness, fear of death, and all sentiments of this nature, except for what leads to adherence to sin." And again in his writing titled Against the Exposition of Eunomius, he writes the following: "Thus the Word also, when he became flesh, assumed, with the flesh, the entire human nature. Therefore, hunger and thirst, fear and fright, desire, sleep, disturbance, weeping, and all acts of this nature had the opportunity to occur in him. Indeed, neither does the divinity submit according to its nature to any such passion, nor does the flesh, taken apart from it, ever become the prey of these feelings without the soul being associated with it.

Through these words, the doctor teaches us that although Christ, the Word of God, was gloriously born according to the flesh from a Virgin in a manner that surpasses nature, and although he was resurrected above the common laws of nature thanks to a wholly divine power, he was not outside of our community due to natural passions, which are not called passions in the strict sense since they do not imply any guilt of sin. Rather, by his own will, he became subject to them, allowing his flesh to proceed according to what is proper to its nature whenever it seemed good to him. Thus, it was through this that he also experienced the desire for food and was capable of feeling the suffering of hunger. Furthermore, initiating us into the desire for virtuous actions so that they might reach us as their first fruits and that we might learn and find the strength not to desire what is beneficial to the body but what pleases God, he hastened eagerly toward the cross that he would endure for us. Indeed, he said to his disciples, “I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover” (Luke 22:15). He also took upon himself the suffering of fear, distress, and sorrow, which are proper to a flesh endowed with an intelligent soul, and courageously approached voluntary death so that by accessing it, he might restrain the violence of such passions and, from his flesh, as from their root, instill courage and confidence in all of humanity, of which, by becoming man, he had become the first fruits. This is why he also experienced in his flesh the trial of death and accepted the condition of a mortal, with the intention of strengthening in us the life of the resurrection, and not to gain any advantage for himself or because he needed life, he who lives perpetually as God and the Word who comes from God the Father. Gregory, the wise one, writes in these terms in the Catechetical Discourse: “It is not because he needed life that he who is from all time humbled himself to corporeal birth, but to bring us from death to life. For it was necessary that there should be a return of our nature from death, as if he had reached out to what had fallen; having thus humbled

himself to our degradation, he approached death to the point of attaining our mortal condition and giving nature a sketch of resurrection by resurrecting with him, so to speak, the whole man in his own body” (Gregory of Nyssa, Catechetical Discourse).

Thus, he assumed all natural sufferings, free from guilt, in a flesh that was subject to them, so that through each of them, he might provide health to us who were sick, and by going even to the trial of death, he destroyed death, to which we were condemned as a result of sin, and through the resurrection of his body, he resurrected the entire human race with him and restored it to the grace of immortality, which our father Adam had lost due to the serpent's cunning; for resurrection is nothing other than a return to the original state. If the Word of God indeed became man without change, it was not to reject the stripping and poverty to which he willingly reduced himself, nor to neglect or despise anything related to the state of humiliation and humanity, moving only in the conditions above and those suitable to God, thus showing the superfluous nature of his incarnation. Therefore, although he could, as God, provide for the sustenance of his flesh even without food, he did not refuse to associate with us in this regard and in similar matters, demonstrating that not only was his flesh consubstantial with ours, but also suffering like ours. Those who do not speak in this way tacitly deny the fact that he is consubstantial with us, expressing this only with their lips. Again, Saint Gregory, in the Catechetical Discourse, declares this: "But the Word of God, as has been said in what precedes, who is both God and Word, mingled with human nature, and when he became in a body that is ours, he did not establish another mode of subsistence for the nature, but it is by means that are customary and appropriate to him that he ensures the duration of his body by maintaining its sustenance through food and drink.

You see, therefore, how it is inappropriate to decree and say that if the birth of a virgin and the resurrection, if the beginning and the end, occurred beyond new conventions and exceeded the common character of our nature, it is absolutely necessary to exclude from equality with the common character of our nature the other aspects as well. For the Doctor proclaims that the Savior God did not establish a new mode of existence for the nature of his body. This is what he states in the fourth discourse of the Commentary on the Beatitudes in the following manner: "He who shared everything with us except for sin and who experienced the same sufferings as we did did not consider hunger to be a sin, nor did he exclude the suffering of hunger from his temptation, but he took upon himself the vehement desire of nature for food. Indeed, after having remained without food for forty days, he ultimately felt hunger; this is because he conceded, when he wished, to the nature to do what was proper to it.

Proclus of blessed memory, in his Letter to the Armenians, writes similar things: "The Word of God has thus become a perfect man, without this marvel that surpasses understanding diminishing the immutable nature. But we have learned this by faith and have not attained it through investigation. And, having become man, he redeemed the race that was associated with him according to the flesh by abolishing the debt of sin by dying for all as a man, and he destroyed him who had the power of death, that is, Satan, as God, for whom swaddling clothes, being laid in a manger, the progression of years according to the flesh, sleeping in a boat, and being weary from the difficulty of the journey, experiencing hunger at times, and all the characteristics that appropriately belong to one who has truly become man, have been a cause of scandal; let them know that by despising suffering they reject nature. Now, in rejecting nature, they do not believe in the economy, and by not believing in the economy, they

render redemption ineffective. For if, from the origin of creation, a man had been born in the world who had walked by another path, deviating from that of nature, let these quarrelers show him and then compose their senseless fables. But if this state marks the beginning of common nature, and the Word of God has truly become man, why, while professing nature, do they censure suffering? Let them then choose one of two things: either, if they are ashamed of suffering, let them reject nature and be counted among the impious, as they share the ideas of the Manichaeans, or, if they acknowledge the benefit resulting from the incarnation by confessing nature, let them not be ashamed of the sufferings that are fitting to nature." We also remember that Saint John, Bishop of Constantinople, declared and taught about our God and Savior Christ, in the texts cited above, similar ideas: "He emphasizes humanity and the nature that does not want to die but claims to live the life of this world, indicating that it was not outside of human passions. For just as there is no guilt in being hungry or in sleeping, there is also none in taking pleasure in life here below. Now Christ had a body pure from sin, but not free from natural necessities; otherwise, there would have been no body." And we have also heard the doctor writing, as if from the person of Christ addressing the disciples: "You will indeed see me resurrected. And what does 'new' mean? In a new manner, that is, which is not customary, since I do not have a passible body, but now an immortal and incorruptible one that does not experience the need for food. Therefore, it was not out of necessity that he ate and drank after the resurrection, for now the body no longer felt that need, but to confirm the fact of the resurrection.

The very wise Cyril, for his part, explains the following in what he wrote to the faithful queens: "When he had sufficiently fasted and, by a wholly divine power, without resorting to food and drink, had kept his flesh free from corruption, he allowed it at most to experience what is

proper to it. It is indeed said that he was hungry; and for what reason? So that through these two aspects he might be wisely recognized as both God and man, one and the same, above us according to divinity and like us according to humanity.” Who, then, upon hearing this, will not glorify with countless praises the precise herald of divine teachings? He has indeed shown everything at once: that he is the incarnate God, who, in a wholly divine manner, persevered in fasting and who, by his will, took upon himself the suffering of hunger; and that, in truth, the same one experienced hunger according to humanity, he who, as God, during all those days, did not concern himself with food. It is indeed said: “He allowed at most his flesh to experience what is proper to it,” indicating by this “at most” what is fitting for God and revealing that it was possible for him to perfectly preserve his flesh without resorting to food. Furthermore, by saying that he “experienced what is proper to him,” he made it clear that he was subject to hunger, not that he would have been merely considered, by virtue of a false conception, as afflicted by a suffering that was foreign to him, but that he truly experienced what was proper and fitting for him; for he also felt the need for food to sustain himself, because he wanted, the Word of God himself, to confirm, through all these sufferings free from guilt, his authentic incarnation. Indeed, we have heard Saint Gregory, who, in the Catechetical Discourse, wrote about our God and Savior this: “He did not establish another mode of sustenance for nature, but it is by means that are customary and appropriate to him that he has ensured his body sustenance through food and drink.” This is what the eminent Cyril has likewise made known to us when, in the words cited above, he speaks of our God and Savior in this way: “And by a wholly divine power, without resorting to food and drink, he kept his flesh free from corruption.” He highlighted two things: that the flesh was naturally apt to be so. For experiencing the need for food and feeling hunger is characteristic of a

corruptible, suffering, and mortal body, and not of an immortal, incorruptible, and impassible one. Indeed, the holy bishop John also, speaking of our Savior risen from the dead, said— I attest several times to the same words to show the agreement of the doctors—: “Because I do not have a suffering body, but one that is now immortal and incorruptible and does not feel the need for food. Therefore, it is not by need that he ate and drank after the resurrection, for now the body no longer felt that need.

Thus, all the venerable Fathers and the God-bearing doctors affirm that the body of God, who became man without change, is free from sin, that it is in no way subject to the corruption resulting from sin, that he experiences suffering like us, inasmuch as he is subject to the natural necessities of unavoidable suffering, and that he feels the need for food, the Word made flesh allowing and wanting his body to follow, passible and corruptible, the natural law; but after the resurrection, he is now impassible and incorruptible and, consequently, manifestly immortal as well, no longer experiencing the need for food, since the trial of suffering and death has once been overcome, for which it was necessary that a mortal body, naturally capable of suffering, approach and achieve victory over them in accordance with the demands of justice. How then can one demonstrate that what your Piety has written is in harmony with this: "And they add that eating, drinking, growing, and progressing are proper to corruptible nature, which is subject to diminution and transformation from a deficient state to perfection: they have as their fathers of such doctrines those who divide the one who is one into two natures"? But it is easy, friend of God, to oppose this contradiction: we will establish the truth based on the doctrine of the holy Fathers and we will dispel the blemish that tarnishes it, according to the conception found among those who, impiously, divide Emmanuel into two natures and who posit outside the Word of God, on

the other side, the man who, as they add, is the Christ born of Mary, himself imperfect, they say, in terms of virtue and who, through works of renunciation, grew and progressed to perfection. They are rightly reproached for sharing the opinion of the Jews and for lowering a truly great mystery of justice to idolatry and for introducing into the holy Trinity a man whose progress in virtue made him a God. As for the interpreters of the true faith, they proclaim that the Word of God, who is exalted above all creation and perfect in all, who became incarnate and made man without change, is a unique Christ, without scission or division, and one person, one hypostasis, and one unique nature of the incarnate Word, without saying that it is by virtue that he became perfect. Reject this blasphemy! Indeed, in what way should he have been made perfect, he who is essentially justice, wisdom, and holiness, and who himself communicates to every created and rational nature the participation in all these perfections, and is the source of all good and the dispenser of virtue? But because he became incarnate in a flesh naturally capable of growing in stature and strengthening—he was indeed subject to suffering like us and consubstantial with us, for it is written that, except for sin, he was made like us in all things, we for whom, being God, he became man—this is why they say concerning him that he was strengthened in the flesh, that he grew and that the size of the body developed, with food and the passage of time, until the state of perfect man, that he suffered and died for our sins in a passible and mortal flesh, that he rose from the dead to destroy by the power of death and to chart the way through resurrection, immortality, and incorruptibility, all things for which he became the firstfruits for himself, as it is written, in order to reduce himself to the conditions that are ours, except for all sin, and not to reject those for which he became man. Therefore, it is not a disgrace for him that it is through his flesh, which is consubstantial with us, that he descended to us, that he remained among us within our measures, and that he proposed



conditions proper to his order as advantages that were to come to us. How then is it not utterly foolish to speak of baseness, or of progress or perfection of virtue, concerning the order of our salvation and healing, by virtue of which the one who is perfect in all humbled himself, and for this reason became incarnate, except for sin, in a suffering flesh like ours and consubstantial with ours?

One can immediately see what separates the opinions of our venerable Fathers from the madness of heretics when one confines oneself to comparing the statements of both parties. Indeed, the wretched Theodoret, intoxicated by the cup drawn from the vine of Judaism, in the Critique of the diadem of Saint Cyril, where he divides the unique Christ into two—into the Word of God who is perfect in his integral nature and into the man who comes from the seed of David, who, as he says, was perfected in virtue—poses this blasphemous question: “Who then is the one who became perfect through virtuous works and is not perfect in his nature? Who is the one who learned obedience through suffering, while he was ignorant before the trial?” After having said other words in the meantime, he gives himself the answer to the blasphemous question, as if there were two Christs: the one who became perfect through virtuous works is not the Word of God, the Immortal, the Impassible, the Incorporeal, but rather that which he assumed from the seed of David. After having thus ‘decapitated’ what comes from David and having spoken of it in the neuter—meaning neither masculine nor feminine—he continues in the same critique, naming it in the masculine and confessing that it is thanks to virtuous works that it appeared free from sin and was made worthy to be for us a great priest, saying: “He who comes from the seed of David, who is free from all sin, has become our great priest and our victim.” The Wise One, defending against this critique and destroying this Jewish insanity, writes: “What troubles you about what is human? And what is

fitting for God does not free you from fears? Do you not consent to see by the very facts that Emmanuel is both God and man, but, with impudence and hardness, rather exceeding all impiety, you say that it is through works that he became perfect in virtue and that it is progressively that he was elevated to the dignity of great priest? If he was elevated by virtue, how did he humble himself and become poor? If he became perfect in virtue, it is clear that he was imperfect (as he was) and that over time he became perfect. Now, everything that is imperfect in virtue falls under the qualification of guilt; on the other hand, what is affected by guilt is subject to sin. How then is it written concerning him that he committed no sin?" And in what has been written to the faithful queens, he shows two things: that it is not permitted to speak of progress in virtue and wisdom concerning Christ and that, while the body grew in size according to the unfolding of time, he manifested his divinity in accordance with the economy and propriety, so that this progressive manifestation was considered as an increase in wisdom: "By saying that our Lord Jesus Christ is one, and attributing to him human characteristics and those that are fitting for God, we affirm that it is truly appropriate for the measures of the stripping to receive bodily increase, to be strengthened as well, the members of the body developing progressively, and even to appear full of wisdom, in that, with a progressive increase of stature fitting for the body, he corresponded with a progressive manifestation of the wisdom that is in him. These traits rightly correspond to the economy related to the flesh and to the measure of the lowering. It is fitting, on the other hand, for the nature of the Word to be always perfect and to be Wisdom. Therefore, it belongs to him, according to humanity, to lower himself to a state of stripping, and to him likewise, according to divinity, what is fitting for God. The modality of the economy realized in the flesh recognizes him as being like us and above us: surpassing the measure of creatures, as God, even if he is considered, because he

became man, as stripped of what he was.” He has said similar things in what he composed Against the impious Diodore: “In the same way, indeed, while he suffered in his flesh, he remained impassible in the nature of his divinity; in the same manner, I say, while he grew, he was perfect in all, and while he was regarded as growing in wisdom, he was himself the total Wisdom by which those capable of wisdom are made wise.

John, who illuminated the papal seat of Constantinople, teaches the same things in his eighth homily on the divine evangelist Matthew, stating, "Herod, wanting to take the child's life, had to flee and go away according to his humanity, for it was not fitting that at that moment he should perform miracles. Indeed, if he had manifested miracles from the very beginning, he would not have been considered as being human. This is why the temple was not formed in any arbitrary way, but there was also conception, the time of nine months, the pains of childbirth, and nursing, and throughout all this time, silence: he awaited a development of the body so that in every respect the mystery of the Economy would become acceptable." Similarly, in the Discourse, he says, "Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass from me": "For he did not immediately arrive at the state of being a complete and perfect man, but in the virgin womb, in such a way as to submit to conception, to birth, to nursing, and to growth over time, to the change of size, to confirm through all that occurred." Atticus, who took possession of his seat with faith in the truth, speaks as follows in the Discourse on the generation of Christ according to the flesh: "The Word of mercy humbles himself, while according to his nature he knows not humiliation; indeed, 'he humbled himself by taking the form of a servant' (Philippians 2:7). He who is devoid of flesh incarnates for you, for 'the Word became flesh' (John 1:14). He who does not fall under touch, due to the incorporeal nature of his being, is felt. He who

is without beginning has been subjected to the beginning of a body. He who is perfect has developed; he who is immutable has grown." Proclus, who occupied his seat in a manner worthy of a priest, resorts to the same sound teachings when he writes to the bishops of the East at that time: "He who is formless incarnates without change; he who is without beginning is born according to the flesh. He grows in bodily stature, he who according to his nature is perfect in all things. He endures suffering, he who is above suffering, not suffering disgrace in what he was, but assuming bodily sufferings in what he has become.

How can we demonstrate that these eminent doctors are in agreement with those who divide the unique Christ into a duality of natures after the union and introduce a man who, from a deficient state of virtue, has reached perfection through acts of renunciation and, as one lacking in virtue, has fallen under the mark of sin? For the fact that he incarnated in a flesh naturally capable of hunger, thirst, and death is not a lack of virtue subject to the contagion resulting from sin; indeed, everyone confesses that these sufferings are blameless. Just as no one accuses him of imperfection by saying, "Why did he become a little child in flesh and not immediately become a perfect man, as he had formed Adam from the beginning?" so no one can rightly and knowingly reproach him, "Why did he endure in mortal flesh the trial of death?" since it is by truly dying and according to his humanity that he wished, in accordance with justice, to abolish the debt of men and, through the resurrection, inaugurate immortality and incorruptibility for those for whom he died. It was necessary for the physician to pass through all the infirmities from which we had suffered. Why then do you accuse him of having taken on our state of deficiency, he who in all things was made like us, except for sin? and who leads in his own person their completion by rectifying these conditions according to an order that befits him? It was truly fitting for the head of the body of the Church to

present himself as the head of all: thus Paul, the herald initiated into the precision of divine teachings, wrote to the Hebrews that it was through sufferings that he was made perfect as a realization for us, and our healing was that Christ suffered in the flesh— for after sufferings came resurrection, incorruptibility, and immortality, which elevate us to our perfection and our original order as well as to the grace of the blessed life of paradise. The Word of God made man, who, in that he is God, is essentially perfect in all, is rightly said to have been made perfect in that he became man, because he took upon himself the conditions that are ours and became for us the firstfruits of our completion leading to incorruptibility and immortality, and at the same time he provided an illustrious model for those who believe in him so that, in the struggle for faith, they may strive through sufferings toward perfection. Now this is what the precise word of the treasure confirms again. Saint Cyril addresses the faithful queens in these terms: “Indeed, just as we were to know tribulation in the world, to be persecuted by enemies, to fight for the doctrine of faith, and, with toil and sweat, to practice virtue steadfastly, he did not allow us to be depressed by fear; rather, he encourages us by the fact that he himself passed through suffering, saying to persuade us as well: ‘The disciple is not above his master, nor the servant above his lord. It is enough for the disciple to be like his master, and the servant like his lord’ (Matthew 10:24-25), ‘If they have persecuted me, they will also persecute you’ (John 15:20). The Only-Begotten therefore intended to suffer for us in his own flesh; the divine Paul teaches us the reason for this when he says: ‘For since the children share in flesh and blood, he himself likewise shared in the same things, that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, He who was in the power of death, that is to say, the nature of humanity which is mortal, so that death, like some wild animal, had attacked his flesh, was renounced, having been destroyed by God, the tyranny it exercised over us. It is indeed he who,

perfected for us in the flesh according to humanity, perfects us according to divinity by destroying the power of death. Indeed, incorruptibility has come to be lacking in human nature, which at the beginning had been in that state. For God is not the author of death, and he does not take joy in the loss of those who live. He created all things for existence and the creatures of the world to be blessings. There is no venom of perdition in it, and there is no royalty of the underworld on the earth. But it is through the envy of the devil that death entered the world. Having thus accomplished these things, he said to God the Father who is in heaven, "I have glorified you on earth, having accomplished the work that you gave me to do." Indeed, it is the true glory of God the Father to destroy death through his offspring. Thus, for him, perfection is realized through suffering, while for us, what has happened constitutes the complement of our deficiency. For "if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation" (2 Corinthians 5:17).

But let no one, upon hearing this, fall into vain speculation and foolishly assert that it was before the cross and resurrection that Christ said to God his Father, "I have glorified you on earth by accomplishing the work that you gave me" (John 17:4). Nor should anyone imagine that from the moment of the incarnation of the Word, death was destroyed and the fulfillment of our redemption was complete; from the beginning, the assumed flesh was incorruptible because, being impassible and immortal, it was not subject to unworthy passions. Indeed, let him who is thus disposed understand that our Savior, when he voluntarily came to suffer for us and, as God, knew that he would truly be crucified and would rise again, destroying the power of death, became for us the way and access to incorruptibility and immortality, thereby inaugurating our state of perfection. He was making this proclamation and declaration to the Father in advance when he referred to the future as if it were already accomplished: "I have glorified you

on earth by accomplishing the work that you gave me." For to God, who is by nature all-powerful, all things are easy, and future events are present. And for him who became man for the very purpose of dying for us in the flesh and destroying the death that weighed upon us, of which we were captives, and who thus laid a foundation and a principle, I mean the very act of the incarnation, all the reasons for which he intended to become man must have already been present and accomplished: the cross, death, resurrection, immortality, incorruptibility, and the conversion of the entire world. To piety, which he was to realize by being with the apostles and acting through them with words and deeds, for indeed, this is how effects usually follow from principles.

Let us not rely on our own conceptions, but rather on the meaning of the message inspired in the doctors; John, Bishop of Constantinople, clearly demonstrates this when, in the eightieth discourse of his Commentary, he explains the phrase, "The work you gave me to do, I have accomplished," noting that although this was only the beginning of the undertaking—indeed, not even the beginning—he still states, "I have accomplished." He may mean that he has done all that was required of him, or perhaps he speaks of the future as if it were a completed matter, or, and this is what should be preferred above all else, that everything was now realized because he had established the principle of the benefits that would necessarily follow, and that he himself would be present and cooperating equally with what was to occur thereafter. It is for the purpose of dying for us and rising again that the Word of God shared in birth in the flesh, that he made death the cause of his incarnation, and that this marked the completion of our redemption; Gregory, the wise theologian and Bishop of Nyssa, attests to this in his Catechetical Discourse, writing the following: "What then do we say to this? That birth made death necessary. Indeed, once he

had chosen to share in humanity, it was necessary for him to pass through all the characteristics of nature. Therefore, if human life is situated between two exits and, after passing through one, he had not reached the other, his will would have been only half accomplished for not having attained the other characteristic of our nature. And whoever might carefully consider the mystery would confidently say that it is not because of birth that death occurred, but rather the opposite, namely, that it is for the sake of death that birth was assumed.

Why then would we claim to show that redemptive death is superfluous by saying that from the moment of the incarnation, the flesh of our Lord, our God and our Savior, Christ, is incorruptible, that is to say, impassible and immortal—since regarding incorruptibility in relation to sin, unanimous consent is beyond dispute? If from the beginning the flesh ceased to be subject to suffering (which is beyond reproach) and to death, how could the Impassible and the Immortal have died? Or how could we think we are making any sense by citing from the treatise of Saint Cyril, called Address 4 to Emperor Theodosius, what your Piety has quoted: "In the same way, therefore, as the flesh became (that) of the Word who gives life to all, it was raised by him above the power of death and corruption," without waiting to learn from the same doctor, in the same treatise, when and how the flesh was raised above the power of death, given that this was made possible by the union with the life-giving Word who, through his very flesh—because it is subject to death—grappled with death and was also resurrected after passing through death in accordance with the law and nature of the flesh? For a mortal flesh can die according to the law and nature of the flesh, but not that which is incorruptible and immortal. Indeed, that which is incorruptible and immortal escapes the law of corruptible and mortal nature, although it has not ceased to be essentially flesh. Let us therefore listen to the Doctor give us this very



teaching: "What shall we say then? That he is mortal and can become prey to corruption, the Word who comes from God the Father? Or that he is, as Life, beyond the grasp of death and above corruption? And how is it not known to everyone that he is, as Life, above death? And then, how has he, according to what is written, 'been among the dead and free'? The one who died is not the Word himself taken apart from himself. We therefore say that his flesh being dead, he himself is said to have suffered. Thus, it is not outside the flesh, but rather in it and with it that he has clothed himself with the glory proper to the Lord; he who died according to human suffering has, in resurrecting, revealed a divine operation, so that he might be recognized both under the two aspects, like us, and above us as God, and that it might appear that he had become the Lord of all, he who even before taking flesh exercised kingship with his Father." But he who died according to the law of the flesh and our nature has risen above the law of nature, breaking, after his descent into hell, the bonds of death, and submitting to corruption and the non-decomposition of the tomb. Thus, death and suffering occurred according to the law of nature, the Word willing and permitting it; as for the resurrection and the other wonders, they were accomplished above the laws of nature. Indeed, the doctor who said of Emmanuel that he died according to the law of the flesh and our nature has taught us that he himself rose above the law of nature and did not undergo corruption in the tomb, when, in the twelfth book of the Commentary on the Gospel of John, he writes as follows: "It was necessary, yes, it was necessary to believe that he died and that he was buried: it results indeed that we truly believe that, breaking the bonds of death, he was raised, as God, to the life that is his own. For it was not possible that he should be under the power of death: being life according to his nature, how could he have undergone corruption? And he 'in whom we live, move, and are,' how could he have obeyed the law of nature and did he not rather, as God, easily give life to what was

devoid of life?" Have we not clearly learned from this what we stated in our previous examination, that "not being seized by death and corruption" means not remaining in it (implying complete detention), and not that he did not in any way undergo the trial of death and corruption? After having said indeed: "It was necessary, yes, it was necessary to believe that he died and that he was resurrected," he added: "for it was not possible that he should be under the power of death" and "as God, he gave life to what was devoid of life." Now, what was truly devoid of life is the body that was dead and not the Immortal and Incorruptible!

Consider, I implore you, the degree and quality of the precision of orthodoxy, which does not tolerate that violence and division have been exercised upon Emmanuel. He indeed said, "breaking the bonds of death, he was raised, as God, to the life that is his own," because the Impassible was hypostatically united, without division, to a body that was naturally capable of being subjected to the bonds of death. In the Letter to the Monks, he also writes: "How then did he become the firstborn of the dead and the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep? It is because he took on a flesh subject to death; 'by the grace of God,' as the very wise Paul says, 'he tasted death for everyone' in a flesh that was capable of receiving it, without abandoning himself as being life. Thus, although it is said that he suffered in the flesh, because the Word became flesh, the suffering was proper to the Impassible, who suffered in his own flesh subject to suffering. Here it is clear again that he did not merely say that "the Word of God took on a flesh subject to death," so that we would be allowed to explain it at our discretion by saying that the flesh was derived from a nature subject to death and from the mortal and human race, but that it ceased, through the union with the Word, to be mortal and subject to death. He indeed added: "he indeed tasted death for everyone in a flesh capable of dying," and again: "the

suffering was proper to the Impassible who suffered in his own flesh subject to suffering." Similarly, in what he wrote to the queens, he said: "As we are baptized in the name of the Father, so also we are baptized in the name of the Son, as well as in his death and in the Holy Spirit." Those who divide the unique Christ and Son into two sons and who speak, by dividing the natures, of a man joined to God solely by equality of honor and authority, in whose death we are baptized, teach us this! If it is in the death of the Word of God taken in isolation, we attribute corruption to the immortal nature and assign death to life by nature; if they say on the other hand that it is in the death of the one who is born of a woman, conceived in isolation, apart from him and separately as Son, how do they not clearly declare this: In any case, it would truly be the same one who is placed on the same level as the Father and Spirit, but who, as the Word from God, would have perhaps been deprived of true sonship, if it is true that the one in whose name we are baptized is subject to death? But certainly, the one who has an awakened spirit perceives the incongruity of such thoughts. It is therefore necessary to understand that, having become like us, the Word of God voluntarily suffered in the flesh, for we are thus baptized into his death, as he is the only Son, impassible according to the nature of divinity, but passible according to the flesh. And that Christ restores us through his resurrection to a new life, how could one doubt it? He places us before himself and before the Father, returned alive from among the dead, according to what is written: "We have died to sin and we live for righteousness" (1 Peter 2:24). Whoever lends an unfaithful ear truly perceives in these words how the teacher clearly declares: if we say that it is in the death of the stripped Word, and not the incarnate one, that we have been baptized, we properly assign corruption to the immortal nature and assign death to Life by nature.

Thus, death is proper to the body that is under the law of corruption; and since it is subject to death, the flesh is also found to be subjected to corruption. It is in this flesh that the Word of God, when he became incarnate without change or division, tasted death and corruption, and while suffering in his own flesh, he remained, as God who is impassible by nature, above suffering. He was not held and did not remain in death and corruption thanks to the resurrection, for it was impossible for the source of life to be seized by them, he who inaugurated for us immortality, incorruptibility, and eternal life, who came to undergo all our trials except for the likeness of sin, to achieve a total victory in our favor in accordance with the law and to implant in us his own benefits. Therefore, he is also anathema who does not declare that after the time of the economy of redemptive sufferings, the flesh of our Lord, our God, and our Savior Jesus Christ is incorruptible, impassible, and immortal in all respects, meaning that very flesh in which the Word of God Jesus became incarnate and made man. But because he is undivided, one from two, from divinity and humanity, it is necessary that we examine in spirit what he was—he was indeed God before the ages—and what he became, for he became man for us without undergoing change. We must consider what language is appropriate to divinity and what, on the other hand, is suited to the economy; what is the origin of our Savior according to the flesh, what are the sufferings and death, what is the resurrection, and the reason why each of these characteristics was assumed; who it is that healed us and removed us from the evils in which we previously found ourselves, and who was the dispenser of grace, given that the Word of God came to us in this world, not for himself, and that, without undergoing change, he became what we were, so that henceforth, as one of us—although he exists in conditions that surpass us, that is, which surpass every creature—he became the source of all good, whatever it may be, that reaches us, becoming a second Adam for all humankind.

Therefore, let us not read the texts of the inspired writings and the holy Fathers, their interpreters, disregarding their integrity, but let us approach the entire doctrine; and, in examining the words, which are by no means inferior to those of the apostles, Gregory the Wonderworker teaches in a chapter: "Whoever declares Christ subject to change or alteration and does not confess him immutable in spirit and incorruptible in the flesh, as it is written, let him be anathema" (Galatians 1:8-9). Let us adhere to his doctrine with docility, complete modesty, with all our soul and a pure heart, as it is written, "without allowing ourselves to comment on the thought of the teacher; let us rather listen to him clarify and elucidate the meaning of these words." In the same work, he indeed states that Christ was not defeated or weakened by sufferings, like an ordinary man, but that, being the Word of God incarnate and made man, not merely in appearance, he did not only assume a flesh endowed with a soul and intelligence, but he also took on its passibility and suffered voluntarily, given that he had become not only consubstantial with us but also a man who suffers like us, without difference, and that, with the sole exception of sin, he took on our likeness, as other theophoric Fathers have also said. This is why he endured the sufferings of the body and the rational soul and manifested them clearly in his works. The teacher's language is as follows: "How could one say that the body of Christ is devoid of soul and spirit? For trouble, sadness, and affliction are not the marks of a flesh devoid of soul, nor of a soul devoid of spirit, nor of immutable divinity, nor merely an appearance, nor an inferiority of human weakness; rather, the Word provided in himself the proof of the sufferings that are ours, by taking on passibility, according to what is written: 'He himself took our weaknesses and bore our afflictions' (Isaiah 53:4). Now, trouble, sadness, and affliction are weaknesses of the soul, while fatigue, sleep, and bodily mutilation are infirmities of the flesh." Let him say, therefore, who dares to explain otherwise the

words and thought of the teacher: If before the resurrection it had been incorruptible, that is to say, impassible and immortal, how could the flesh endowed with a soul and intelligence of our Lord, our God, and our Savior Christ, have been subject to trouble, sadness, and affliction, which are irreproachable sufferings and weaknesses of the soul, and how could it have experienced fatigue, sleep, and bodily mutilation, which are infirmities of the flesh? For if he were immortal and impassible, he would not be subject to weaknesses or infirmities. Now, if our Lord submitted to manifestations of suffering, while the flesh was not subject to them—as it is indeed written that he experienced trouble, anguish (Matthew 26:37), that he was fatigued (John 4:6), that he slept (Mark 4:38), and that he was crucified—what was seen was merely appearance and not truth, if it is true that the body, as incorruptible, that is to say, impassible and immortal, had ceased to be naturally capable of suffering!

But here, Gregory presents himself anew in the debate, and through his words, he refutes the slander by stating in his work *On the Incarnation and Faith* that corruption was destroyed in the burial of the body by the first fruits of the resurrection, by virtue of which he inaugurated, first for our sake, incorruptibility and immortality. He indeed writes: “... and that death was destroyed in such a way as to no longer reign, that corruption was annihilated in the burial of the body, and that the first fruits of the resurrection were shown” (1 Corinthians 15:20). Moreover, the same doctor, in the *Exposition of Faith* in parts, explains that after the completion of the economy and after Emmanuel took upon himself the sufferings for us, the passibility of the flesh was destroyed because it was seized by immortality and immutable incorruptibility, which is the return and recovery of the original beauty that humanity possessed when it dwelled in paradise, so that henceforth those who believed, by appropriating the faith, received

from him, as new first fruits, the same advantage. He writes: “The divinity has removed the passibility of the flesh through the completion of the mystery. After the destruction of death, there was in the whole flesh a perpetual impassibility and an immutable immortality; the original beauty of humanity has been recovered thanks to the power of divinity, and it has been granted to all men by the fact that they appropriate the faith. If there are those who also alter the divine faith on this point or who attribute to divinity human characteristics, such as growth, suffering, or an adventitious glory, or who separate from divinity the body that grew and suffered, as if it existed in isolation, they too are outside the salvific and ecclesiastical confession.” Should we then also rank this apostolic man with those who divide our Lord into two natures? And will he be accused, like the impious, of considering Christ as imperfect because he declares that glory and immortality were added to the holy flesh after the resurrection and the destruction of death, so that he became the access and the way leading to our immortality, our incorruptibility, and our glory, which we would acquire after death through the resurrection? But it is he himself who has precisely expressed in the same work these true and divine words: “He is also true God, perfect in divine and true perfection, not two persons nor two natures. We do not say, in fact, that we will worship four: God, the Son of God, man, and the Holy Spirit. That is why we also anathematize those who commit this impiety of placing a man in the divine confession.

We must therefore read in full the teachings of the venerable doctors who have succeeded one another in the holy Church, ensuring that we do not quote them partially and that we do not dangerously reduce their entire thought to a single statement, letter, or exposition, for it is not possible to present the whole of religion in such a manner; sometimes we find the divine heralds applying human measures to Christ, while at

other times remaining within the conditions appropriate to God, wisely superimposing everything related to the state of humiliation and the divine economy, the conditions from above and those fitting for God. If someone extracts any part without examination and presents it in support of their opinion for another party, they come into conflict with all the holy books and are cornered by the truth because a unanimous consent emerges from the preaching of all. This is what the great Athanasius also wrote in an Apology for Dionysius when the Arians, based on a single letter of his, claimed that he adhered to their opinion: “It is therefore an occasion for them to speak with audacity—because their boldness attacks everything!—that the apostles themselves share the ideas of Arius, since they declare Christ to be a man from Nazareth and subject to suffering! Behold how far they delude themselves! Is it because they have recourse to similar statements that the apostles recognize in Christ only a man and nothing more? Not at all! One could never conceive it, even in thought! But they did this as wise architects and stewards of the divine mysteries, with a legitimate reason for acting in this way. Since the Jews were then in error and misleading the pagans, believing that Christ was an ordinary man, merely descended from the seed of David like other sons of David—because they did not believe that he was God nor that the Word became flesh—for this reason, the blessed apostles wisely began by revealing to the Jews the human characteristics of our Savior so that, after persuading them of the coming of the Messiah through visible signs that had occurred, they might also lead them to faith in his divinity by showing that the works produced were not those of a man but of God. Thus, Peter, after saying that Christ was a suffering man, immediately added that he was the initiator of life. In the Gospel, he confessed, ‘You are the Christ, the Son of the living God!’ (Matthew 16:16), and in another epistle, he declared that he was the guardian of our souls, his Lord and that of the angels and powers. Paul, for his part,



who had said of the Son that he was a man, descended from the seed of David (Romans 1:3), wrote to the Hebrews that he is 'the radiance of his glory and the exact representation of his being' (Hebrews 1:3), and to the Philippians, 'Who, being in very nature God, did not consider equality with God something to be used to his own advantage' (Philippians 2:6). Now, to speak of the initiator of life, the Son of God, the radiance, the exact representation, and the equal of God, the Lord and guardian of souls, what does this mean other than that the Word of God, through whom all things were made, was in a body and was not separated from the Father, just as the radiance relates to the light?

Saint John, Bishop of Constantinople, in the twenty-seventh discourse of his Commentary on the Gospel of John, writes in similar terms: "Indeed, it is because he said, 'We know that you have come from God as a teacher' (John 3:2), that he corrects this expression as if to say: Do not think that I am a teacher in the same way as the multitude of prophets who are of the earth. For now I have come from heaven, and among the prophets, no one has ascended to heaven; yet I dwell there! Behold: even what seems the highest is entirely base and unworthy of his greatness. It is because he is not only in heaven but everywhere, and he fills all things with himself. But again, he speaks with regard to the weakness of the listener, intending to elevate him gradually. Here, he does not call the Son of Man in reference to the flesh, but now it is a name drawn from the vile nature that he has given to himself entirely, so to speak. Such is indeed his habit, to frequently give the whole a name drawn from divinity and frequently also a name drawn from humanity.

In a similar manner, the very wise Cyril, in the treatise "Christ is One," speaks of the Apostle, noting that there are instances where he writes about Emmanuel solely as God and not as if he had equally become man for us: "While knowing that he has become flesh, Paul dares,

when he happens to contemplate him in the heights of divinity, not to declare everywhere that he is man. He thus wrote to the Galatians: 'Paul, an apostle, not from men nor through man, but through Jesus Christ' (Galatians 1:1); and in another place: 'I make known to you that the gospel which was preached by me is not according to man; for I neither received it from man, nor was I taught it, but it came through the revelation of Jesus Christ' (Galatians 1:11-12)." Furthermore, in the Discourse to the Pious Emperor Theodosius, he states: "The divine Scriptures also proclaim him sometimes as entirely man, omitting the divinity in accordance with the economy, and at other times as God, omitting humanity. But in no way does he suffer any detriment because of the conjunction of the two in one unity.

Thus, when Scripture, inspired and interpreted without distortion by the holy Fathers, declares that our Lord Jesus Christ is constituted without division from two natures, divinity and humanity, each perfect in its own kind, and that at times they speak solely as if referring to God while at other times they give the whole a name as if it were drawn from humanity, expressing themselves as if it were a man while remaining silent about his divinity, we must not seize upon a single word of what they have said and, by virtue of it, establish what pleases us, separating it from other words that allow us to recognize the integral spirit of the faith. Therefore, your Holiness should not have relied solely on the text from Saint Cyril, found in the third book Against the Blasphemies of Nestorius, to demonstrate that the flesh of our Savior Christ is incorruptible, that is, impassible and immortal, by citing the passage where the blessed Paul writes to the Corinthians: "And just as we have borne the image of the earthly, we shall also bear the image of the heavenly" (1 Corinthians 15:49), referring to the image of our father Adam as the earthly and that of Christ as the heavenly. What, then, is the form of our father Adam? It is the ease of

inclination to sin, the fact of becoming prey to death and corruption. And what is that of the heavenly? It is to be in no way subject to suffering, to be ignorant of injustice, to be neither prey to death nor corruption, but to be holiness, justice, and all that is related and close to them. After citing this text, you seemed to think it sufficient to demonstrate that the flesh of our Savior Christ is incorruptible, impassible, and immortal even before the resurrection, because the doctor had said it was not subject to death and corruption! However, you needed to add and cite what is appended to the text, by virtue of which it becomes clear that here we are speaking of Christ only as God, who, according to divine nature, is immortal and impassible, and that it is not in the sense that he has an impassible and immortal flesh, in which he suffered for us and truly died, while remaining above death and suffering by virtue of being God. Indeed, he appropriately added to his words and said: "But I think these traits are suitable to be the possession of the divine and immortal nature; it is indeed above sin and corruption and is holiness and justice." In all this, the Word from God the Father also elevates us by making us participants in the divine nature through the Holy Spirit. Here he restricts the scope of the statement to the divine and immortal nature, that is, that of the Word, while remaining silent about the flesh, even though it too is holy and above the corruption of sin.

It was necessary, moreover, with these words, to also cite those found in the book that demonstrate how wisely the Doctor, grappling with the wretched Nestorius, highlighted in his exposition of orthodoxy the traits that appear in the unique Christ, who is undivided, and how he states that, on one hand, he is perfect in all things and without any deficiency in relation to the order of virtue, as those impious ones claim; indeed, from his childhood he rejected evil and knew no sin (Isaiah 7:15). On the other hand, in the earthly body, consubstantial

with us and naturally capable of suffering, he suffered and was the firstborn and the firstfruits of our resurrection. He expressed it as follows: “How then, tell me, was he elevated to the supreme priesthood? By being made perfect in virtue? How could anyone doubt that what is stripped of perfection in virtue is under the weight of guilt, is not worthy of admiration in any way, and perhaps even bears the mark of sin? But it is certainly true that he did not commit sin and that no deceit was found in his mouth, as it is written. Therefore, he is entirely perfect, being such in all things, and he has no deficiency in any way compared to one who behaves perfectly in the fulfillment of his virtuous work. And when was he imperfect in good, he who is God even in the womb? Of whom the prophet Isaiah also said: ‘He will eat curds and honey; before he knows how to refuse the evil and choose the good’ (Isaiah 7:15), because before the child knows good or evil, he rejects evil to choose good. How then is it possible for you to demonstrate the imperfection of Christ in good? Or what progress did he need, he who was perfect to the point of rejecting all evil, preferring good, and choosing only it?” And after sufficiently teaching from the divine Scriptures that he was without sin from his very childhood and that he needed no progress to attain virtue, he who is not subject to any of the passions related to evil and sin and who, as God, is solely good, he also adds how he suffered and died for us in a flesh that was capable of suffering and undergoing death: it was impossible for God, impassible and immortal, to undergo passions and death in any other way than by uniting with what is naturally capable of suffering, so that a true death might be accomplished for a true resurrection to occur. For we also needed a true death and a true resurrection, we who were truly dead and fallen and who needed to be raised up. It is as firstfruits that those for whom he became the firstfruits will truly follow him.

At this point, he adds and cites this: "It is evident everywhere that the Word of God is impassible; and that he suffered for us in the flesh, the voice of theologians confirms this truth. If you separate the Word of God from the earthly body, everything for you amounts to nothing! Indeed, if he did not become man, he did not die for us either, and if he did not surrender his body to death, how can it be said that he became the firstborn of the dead? Therefore, Christ did not die, and he was not resurrected! Let divine Paul intervene for us in this debate and declare loudly: 'If the dead do not rise, Christ has not been raised either!' Furthermore, in the fifth book, it is stated: 'Thus, although it is said that he suffered, we recognize him as impassible like God, but we say that he underwent death in his flesh, according to the economy, so that, by trampling on it and rising again, he who is naturally life and life-giving restored for incorruptibility what death dominated, that is, the body, and in this way the effectiveness of his work, accomplished well, reached us, extending to our entire race.' A little further on, it is said: 'Now the work completed, we are completed, in that, in him first, we conquer corruption and trample on the power of death; for he returned to life and rose from among the dead, while we were all in him.' It is easy to clearly understand from this that the Doctor, in his own words, declared God impassible, who is life, the life-giving Word who underwent death in his own flesh, according to the economy; that by rising from the dead, he restored for incorruptibility what death dominated, namely the body in which he had suffered death. And he immediately indicates the very reason: it was to help us, for whom it was necessary to achieve a true victory over death, which was destroyed and conquered by the resurrection. Now, there would not have been a true resurrection if a true death had not preceded it. But death is real, since Emmanuel died for us, as it is written, in a body that was dominated by death, and he returned to life and rose from the dead, while we were all in him, restoring for incorruptibility the body

that death dominated; by this very act, he destroyed the power of tyranny, so that the effectiveness of his well-accomplished work might also reach us, extending to our entire race.

It is therefore very clearly demonstrated by all this that everything realized in the resurrection of our God and Savior Christ constitutes the way, the image, and the order of our resurrection, our impassibility, our immortality, and our incorruptibility. For we too begin by dying and then we come to life again, and at the resurrection, this corruptible body will put on incorruptibility, and this mortal body will put on immortality (1 Corinthians 15:53). How then can we still speak of what is unprovable, impossible, unrealizable, contrary to all the intention of divine economy, and even in conflict with inspired Scripture and those who have explained it with such competence, knowing that the body of our God and Savior, Christ, would have been incorruptible from the very moment of the incarnation, and thus impassible and immortal, and that subsequently, only through the resurrection, would it have appeared that he was incorruptible and immortal? Indeed, the very wise Cyril, along with all the testimonies of the doctors we have previously cited, openly proclaims, through this very word we quoted a little earlier, that Emmanuel, by rising from the dead, restored to incorruptibility the body that death had dominated, so that the effectiveness of the work accomplished might also reach our entire race.

If we say that it would have been inappropriate for the body not to be incorruptible, that is, impassible and immortal, from the moment of the union with the Word of God the Father, we are, so to speak, criticizing the physician; we accuse his treatment of lacking wisdom, his plan of being inconsistent, his humility of being weakness, and his economy of being unreasonable. We also imitate the Jews who, ignorant of the purpose and end of divine incarnation, reproach him for his voluntary

death and consider it a weakness to wait for the resurrection to destroy the power of death and inaugurate immortality and incorruptibility for us, for whom he became man and for whom it was necessary that he become in all things a way and an access. Thus, shaking their impious heads and mocking him, they said, “If you are the Son of God, come down now from the cross!” (Matthew 27:40). And we can hear the pagans declare loudly even to this day: Could he not, if he is God and Almighty, redeem humanity from death by a command and mere assent and decree that it would henceforth be immortal, so that a God would not be compelled to undergo crucifixion and death and thus to resurrect? Claiming a human and demonic wisdom that believes everything is accessible to its mortal thoughts, they do not possess the Spirit of God and are ignorant of the intention of the divine Scriptures; they have not learned, as Paul did, to think and say, “For since death came through a man, the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man; for as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive” (1 Corinthians 15:21-22). This is what he willed; in accordance with wisdom and justice, he renewed the battle to repair our defeat and, passing through a true human death, destroyed death by the resurrection that was fitting for a God. For this reason, too, without undergoing any change, he became man: to have a God who is stripped and not incarnate grapple with death and triumph over it would be ridiculous and would not escape the mark of folly, since he is superior to every creature, sustains all, and possesses by his nature victory over all.

However, it is also necessary to scrutinize this other point, to clarify it carefully, and to bring a diligent effort that is worthy of your venerable and pious old age. I remember that you required me to examine what you had written; thus, it is fitting for an examination to leave nothing unchallenged. Indeed, you have drafted a similar exposition intending

to show that the body of our Lord, our God, and our Savior Christ is both passible and impassible, that is to say, incorruptible in suffering: "Now we have examples that confirm these truths, which surpass understanding, more through experience than through reason. If someone believes that the bush, which is merely a body, burned without being consumed, while the fire itself spread with the matter, how can he not believe that, while the passible body of our Lord suffered voluntarily for others, incorruptibility was always maintained within it? Likewise, will he not also believe that, while the bush was aflame, it simultaneously enjoyed its incombustibility?" It is good, here again, to reiterate for your piety what has been expressed many times: if you say that it is incorruptibility recognized in the absence of sin and holiness that was always maintained in the flesh of our Lord, we all agree, and anyone who contests this bears the mark of impiety; but if you claim to assert that it is an incorruptibility understood as resulting from impassibility and immortality that made the flesh of our Lord incorruptible, impassible, and immortal in suffering and in death, you would need to state clearly that in the passible body of our Lord, even while he voluntarily suffered for others, impassibility and immortality were always maintained; and not, under the name of incorruptibility, which is understood interchangeably and signifies both the absence of sin and impassibility and immortality, leave the meaning of what has been said in such obscurity that anyone who later claims that the flesh of our Lord is not incorruptible before the resurrection is considered a blasphemer because he thinks to attribute to the holy and sinless body the corruptibility of sin.

However, as I mentioned earlier, this is not what concerns the matter proposed for our examination, as everyone professes that the corruption resulting from sin never reached the most holy body of our Lord. What is sought here is whether, while he endured the



unendurable sufferings, hunger, thirst, fatigue, blows, tortures, and the cross, he was incorruptible, impassible, and immortal. Indeed, incorruptibility, which opposes unendurable sufferings, is impassibility and immortality; that the passible is opposed to impassibility and immortality is what Saint John, Bishop of Constantinople, already said about our Savior, alluding to Christ in the texts cited above: when he rose from the dead, he did not have a passible body, but one that was now immortal and impassible. Now, by clearly writing that in the passible body of our Lord, even when he voluntarily suffered for others, incorruptibility always remained, as well as impassibility and immortality, your piety declares that it remained to such an extent in suffering that he was at once passible and impassible and immortal! You indeed added, in support of this, as if to reprimand those who contest it: "Nor will he believe that, while the bush was on fire, it simultaneously enjoyed incombustibility?" Therefore, know, my dear among all, that all those who have successively been the teachers of the mysteries in the holy Church, following as a leader the prince of the apostles, Peter, who writes that Christ certainly suffered for us in the flesh (1 Peter 3:18), have unanimously taught that he is one and the same, composed of two perfect elements, divinity and humanity, and a single person, a single hypostasis, and a single incarnate nature, that of the Word of God himself, Emmanuel, who, in truth, is neither split nor divided and is, himself, impassible in his divinity and passible in the flesh. But that his flesh is at once passible and impassible, that is, suffering and not suffering, like the bush, as you said, which was on fire and was not consumed, absolutely no one among those who have taught competently has thought so. This will become evident when we have cited somewhat from their writings that can confirm what has been said.

Athanasius, the great mystagogue, in a work *On the Faith* against those who share the opinions of Apollinaris, writes: “Indeed, this is how death also came about: the body, receiving according to its nature, and the Word voluntarily submitting to it and willingly delivering his own body to death, so that he might suffer for us according to his nature and rise for us according to his divinity. And the whole matter of birth and death in him is considered in view of our search and conversion.” He continues: “Thus, he is himself the one who suffered and the one who did not suffer; he is, according to his divine nature, immutable and unchangeable, but in his flesh he suffered, as Peter said, and by his will he tasted death, because he became the mediator between God and men; now the mediator is not one of the two, and God is one. Those who say that another is the one who suffered and another is the one who did not suffer are mistaken. For it is not someone else, apart from the Word, who has assumed suffering and death, but the Word himself, impassible and incorporeal, in assuming the birth of human flesh, has accomplished everything so that he might have something to offer. How then could we bring something that is not suitable and in affinity with the suffering that Christ our God suffered in the flesh, as you brought the example of the bush, while the doctor clearly proclaims that it is according to its nature that the body welcomed death and that it suffered naturally, because the Word of God himself willed it and that of his own accord, by his will, he incarnated in order to suffer in the flesh, but that the bush existed in a manner surpassing nature without being consumed or suffering? It is therefore impossible for us to say that the flesh is altogether both passible and impassible in suffering. This is indeed opposed to the purpose of the economy, which desires that it be through death, which naturally occurs to a flesh naturally capable of dying, that the death which held us be condemned through the resurrection. This is why the Word of God, immutable and immortal, became incarnate and made man so that he himself might

truly suffer in a body that was naturally capable of suffering and impassible according to divinity, dying also according to humanity, but rising by a divine operation and destroying death.

Indeed, we have cited Saint Cyril, who states in his discourse addressed to the pious Emperor Theodosius, "He who died according to the law of the flesh and our nature and who is resurrected. If dying is a human suffering, in resurrecting, he revealed a divine operation." Furthermore, he remarks in the Scholies, "He suffers and he does not suffer, according to both aspects: he suffers indeed according to humanity, in the flesh, by the fact that he became man, but he is impassible as God." He writes the same in his letter to the pious queens: "We are indeed baptized into his death inasmuch as the Son is one, impassible according to the divine nature, but passible according to the flesh.

Gregory the Theologian, bishop of Nazianzus, defines in Letter 4 to Cledonius that "our Lord and our God, Jesus Christ, is passible according to the flesh, impassible according to the divinity." Furthermore, in his discourse On Baptism, he states, "He is entirely man and, at the same time, entirely God for the one who suffered entirely, in order to give you salvation entirely, by completely destroying the condemnation resulting from sin, impassible according to the divinity, passible according to what he assumed." Similarly, Saint Epiphanius, the bishop of Salamis—located in the city of Constantia in Cyprus—in his exposition Against Heresies, discussing the Eunomians, writes as follows: "Thus, being Wisdom and impassible God, knowing that through suffering he would redeem those afflicted by the sufferings of death, he did not send before him either an ambassador, or an angel, nor even prophets, but the Lord himself came and, after taking on what was passible, truly suffered, while his divinity remained impassible.

Thus, they all equally recognize not the flesh as both suffering and impassible in the sufferings, but the one Christ, impassible in divinity and the same, suffering in the flesh that he assumed to suffer and die, and not in an incorruptible flesh, that is to say, impassible and immortal, before the resurrection. This is also what we are informed of by Saint Cyril, who provides in the previously examined passages the following teaching: "... the power of death rushing upon the flesh alone from which it has also been expelled. For if it is not his body that has known death that has been resurrected, what death has been defeated? And how could the power of corruption have been found without force, when none among rational creatures has died, neither man nor angel, to speak of the Word of God? Therefore, when the power of death was felt only upon that which is naturally subject to corruption, it is rightly understood that it is also upon this that the power of resurrection operates, so that the strength of the tyrant may also be destroyed." If indeed it was in the incarnation and union with the Word of God that the body ceased to be naturally subject to corruption, that is to say, to suffer and to die, and if it had been incorruptible, that is to say, impassible and immortal, suffering and death would not have reached one who was not naturally able to suffer and die. Now, if death was not authentic, the resurrection is also in any case found to be false. The Doctor indeed said that "it is upon that which is naturally subject to corruption that the power of death has been felt" and that "if it is not his body that has known death that has been resurrected, what death has been defeated? And how could the power of corruption have been found without force?" Here it is clear that it is the same power that he called the power of death and corruption, and that it was after being felt in that which is naturally subject to corruption that it was found without force thanks to the resurrection. If indeed it was in an immortal and impassible body that Emmanuel wished to engage and deliver the combat for us, why was the incarnation required of one who by his

nature, because he is God, possessed impassibility and immortality? But because he wanted to conquer and destroy the devil, who held the power, through a death that is real, he therefore suffered and died in a body consubstantial with humanity, suffering as humanity does and naturally able to suffer and die; and, like a victorious wrestler, after voluntarily coming to grips with the adversary and having been dominated by him, he was resurrected by a power that befits God and destroyed the bonds of death, because it was impossible for the source of life and resurrection to be held and remain in death and corruption. For it is he who brought us from nothing into existence, since it is through him that all was made and without him nothing was made; and, while we had fallen into death and lost the grace of immortality, he brought us back through the resurrection, becoming for us the firstborn among the dead and the source of incorruptibility and future life. This is why Isaiah also called him the father of the age to come, while he is the author of all ages. He indeed was in the sufferings that are human and irreproachable, suffering voluntarily in the flesh, not to remain and be completely held in the conditions that are human, but so that, undergoing everything in his own flesh that had been affected by each of our passions, he might bring healing to a flesh of the same race as that of all men and consubstantial with the flesh derived from Adam, destroying its weaknesses and strengthening its energy in the struggle for piety.

Gregory the Theologian writes in his Apologetic Discourse that "this is why wood stands against wood, hands against hands: against that which was stretched out licentiously, those which were extended forcefully; against that which is slack, those which are held by nails; against that which expelled Adam, those which bring back the extremities of the world to their intimacy. This is why exaltation opposes the fall, harshness opposes goodness, and death opposes

death; darkness takes the place of light; the grave opposes the return to dust, and resurrection takes the place of resurrection; all of this was for us a divine pedagogy and treatment of our infirmities, to restore the old Adam to what he had fallen from." The doctor stated that "darkness takes the place of light" for the following reason: even while Emmanuel was buried in terms of the flesh, he had declared in advance through the prophet in a psalm, "They have laid me in a deep pit, in darkness and in the shadows of death" (Psalm 88:6). Thus, through the descent into hell, the light emerging in those dark places allowed him to say to the prisoners to come out and to those who were in darkness to go into the light, according to the word of Isaiah (Isaiah 9:2).

The divine Athanasius understood that the infirmities of our flesh had been healed and removed because our Savior Christ suffered in a passible body, while remaining impassible as God, above suffering. He indeed writes the following in the Letter addressed to Epictetus: "And it was a marvel that he himself was the one who suffered and who did not suffer; he suffered because his body suffered and he was in that which suffers; on the other hand, he did not suffer because the Word of God is naturally impassible. The incorporeal one was indeed in a passible body. Furthermore, the body contained in itself the impassible Word, which destroyed the infirmities of the body that was his. This is what he accomplished, and it was realized in this way so that, by assuming the conditions that are ours and offering them in sacrifice, he destroyed them, and subsequently, by clothing us with his own, he made Peter say, 'It is necessary for this corruptible being to put on incorruptibility, and this mortal being to put on immortality' (1 Corinthians 15:53).

Saint Cyril, in the apology of the tenth chapter where the anathemas are found, writes against the criticisms of the impious Theodore, saying, "He wept in a human manner to suppress your tears; he

experienced fear in accordance with the economy, sometimes allowing his flesh to endure what is proper to it, in order to make us magnanimous. He rejected the cup so that the cross would accuse the impiety of the Jews. It is said that he was rendered powerless in accordance with his humanity to put an end to your own weakness. He offered prayers and supplications to draw the Father's attention to your own prayer, so that you may learn not to sleep in temptations, but to stay awake in prayer.

The venerable Fathers teach us, based on inspired writings, that although the sufferings and death of our God Savior were voluntary and healed our infirmities, they were nonetheless natural and proper to a truly suffering and passible flesh: the incarnate Word allowed himself to suffer according to the joy of nature, so that we might understand that, in the aspect of the flesh, he himself suffered in his own flesh while remaining impassible in the aspect of divinity. Indeed, listen to the great Athanasius as he speaks: "And death occurred because the body was naturally subject to it, while the Word voluntarily submitted to it and willingly offered his body to death, so that he might suffer for us according to nature and rise for us according to divinity" (Athanasius). And Gregory the Theologian, in his Discourse on the Appearance of God, declares: "... since he was weary, he hungered and thirsted, he experienced fear and wept according to the law of the body" (Gregory of Nazianzus). The wise Cyril, in the fifth volume Against the Blasphemies of Nestorius, writes similarly: "Thus he delivered his body to the law of its nature and willingly accepted death. And it is appropriately that the Word who was united to him allowed him to undergo it: he was raised by the divine power of the Word who was hypostatically united to him. Therefore, we understand Emmanuel entirely—interpreted as: our God with us—when we hear the divine Peter declare: 'This Jesus, God raised

him”” (Acts 2:24). Furthermore, Basil, the interpreter of divine teaching, who was meticulously instructed in the royal way, writes in his Discourse on Thanksgiving: “Our Lord thus endured hunger, once the solid food was dissolved, he admitted thirst when the humor in the body failed, and he experienced weariness when the joints and nerves faltered due to the fatigue of the journey, not that the divinity succumbed to fatigue, but the body underwent the accidents that accompany nature; thus he also admitted tears, allowing a suffering that is natural to the body to arise” (Basil of Caesarea). O admirable and authentic wisdom of the Doctor! Or rather, the divine operation of the Spirit that acted in him to make this declaration! Indeed, he summarized everything without omitting anything that contributes to precision! He began by stating that the Lord had hungered, without separating the incarnate God into two; secondly, he highlighted the role of will in the sufferings through numerous and significant words, clearly stating that he endured hunger, admitted thirst, and tolerated tears; thirdly, he professed to refer these to the natural character and truth of the sufferings of the body, calling them natural accidents of the flesh and assigning to each suffering a natural cause, by virtue of which it is naturally brought to satisfaction: to hunger, the dissolution of food; to thirst, the deficiency of humor; to the fatigue of the journey, the failure of the nerves; to tears, the exhalation of affliction through the humor that spreads through the outlet of the eyes: this he also clearly added to the words cited above. This is because the author of nature, the Word of God, willed to be incarnate in a flesh that is passible, to voluntarily submit to the laws of nature, and to place himself, by his will, under the binding conditions of suffering, thereby winning for us the healing of each of them and transmitting to the entire race, through his true flesh, what was accomplished. We previously cited John, the bishop of Constantinople, who said: “Now Christ had a body free from sin, and not exempt from natural



necessities; otherwise, there would not have been a body,” while also adding that it was voluntarily and willingly that he bore this and died, until he had accomplished all that contributes to our redemption; the text itself is thus conceived: “... and death reached the body only at the moment when he himself willed it. Now he willed that it be after he had accomplished everything” (John 10:18). For indeed, the all-powerful Word of God, who even healed the infirmities of others and raised the dead by the touch of his flesh, could have prevented this flesh from experiencing passions and death! But that would have been nothing other than to destroy the entire economy for which he became man. For it is to endure our sufferings and destroy their power, to die our death and abolish the fall through the resurrection that, without change, he became man. This is what the venerable Cyril has already instructed us about concerning the thirst experienced on the cross when he said: “... in the end, the flesh experienced something that is proper to its nature. It admitted thirst, dried out by various wounds. For violent pains generally provoke an overwhelming thirst, absorbing, under the effect of an indescribable physical heat, the humor hidden in the depths of the body, and consuming, through inflammatory pangs, the interior of the patient. It was not difficult, indeed, for the Word of God who can do all things, to also remove this from his flesh. But since he had, by his will, tolerated experiencing everything else, he also experienced this by the will of his spirit. And that is why he asked for a drink” (Cyril of Alexandria). In the same manner, the most illustrious Athanasius, in the third discourse *On the Trinity*, in the book *Against the Infamous Arians*, said: “Therefore, one should have been much more astonished that the Word was in such a passible flesh, that he did not prevent those who tortured him and did not take vengeance on his murderers, when he could, he who had removed others from death and had raised the dead from among the dead, but that he consented to let his body suffer. For this reason, indeed, he also came, as I have said

previously, so that he might suffer in the flesh and that henceforth the flesh might be constituted impassible and immortal and, as we have frequently repeated, so that in him, the reproaches and everything that happened to him would no longer reach men, but that they would be completely annihilated by him, and that they would remain forever incorruptible, as a temple of the Word.

All confess unanimously and without dispute that the flesh of our Savior Christ suffered voluntary sufferings that healed our weakness, being itself passible in its nature and in no way, while it suffered, both passible and impassible and immortal, like the bush that, as your Piety says, burned and enjoyed its incombustibility; but the incarnate Word, wanting his flesh to undergo what is proper to it, accepted death according to the law of nature, so that the same one, considered as having become man, truly suffered and died in a body naturally capable of suffering and dying, and that it might be believed, according to his divinity, that he remained above all sufferings and death and that he would become for us, through his own body, the first fruits of resurrection and, consequently, of incorruptibility, that is to say, of impassibility and immortality. The wise Athanasius has indeed said, “This is why he also came, as I have said previously, so that he might suffer in the flesh and that henceforth his flesh might be constituted impassible and immortal.” Therefore, it is after the sufferings that the flesh was constituted impassible and immortal by the resurrection, and it did not have, in the sufferings themselves, either impassibility or immortality; this is impossible, far removed from the holy Scriptures and inspired words! For in the psalms of the divine David, the sufferings of Emmanuel have also been clearly prefigured in many places, in which it is proclaimed in advance, as emanating from his person: “They gave me gall for my food, and for my thirst they gave me vinegar to drink” (Psalm 69:21) and “They have added to the pain

of my wounds” (Psalm 69:26). Indeed, while he was nailed to the cross and was struck because of our sins, the Jews added sarcasm, reproaches, insults, and mockeries filled with the audacity of blasphemies. Also observe, I pray you, the precision of the Spirit's word; he did not say, “They have added to my wounds” but “to the pain of my wounds” to clearly show that it was not merely in appearance that the sufferings of the flesh in which the wounds had been made occurred, but that it had been afflicted and had suffered, the Word himself wanting it so; and not that it had been without suffering or affliction, which would have seemed to suffer, while in truth it did not feel or suffer at all.

This is also attested by the venerable John, who was the bishop of Jerusalem, along with the words of the doctors cited earlier. It was during his time that the precious body of Saint Stephen, the first martyr, was discovered through divine revelation. His proven symbol, directed against those who think impiously about the incarnation, was taken up in his treatise by Timothy, the bishop of Alexandria; throughout his life, he offered armed resistance, both through his words and actions, to the error of the Phantasiasts and to those who speak of two natures and two persons. Here is what he cites in this very symbol: "We confess that when the Word of God, the eternal and only-begotten Son of God, was conceived by the holy Virgin Mary and the Holy Spirit for the redemption of humankind—of a woman, as the Apostle has said (Galatians 4:4)—and that he truly took from her a flesh that is consubstantial with our flesh, he truly suffered for us: he experienced the fatigue of the journey, just as we do and not merely in appearance, and like us, he slept and, like us, he felt the pain of blows when he was scourged before Pilate; and when his cheeks were slapped, he bore the suffering, and when his hands and feet were pierced by nails, he truly felt the painful suffering, as Isaiah said about

him: 'He himself bore our sins and was wounded for our transgressions; we thought he was stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted; but he was wounded for our transgressions and crushed for our iniquities' (Isaiah 53:4-5), and again: 'a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief' (Isaiah 53:3). We share the sentiment of the divine Paul when he says this about him: 'For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin' (Hebrews 4:15). We confess that he had a rational soul that truly endured suffering for us, just as our souls do, and that he truly experienced the sufferings of our soul, namely sadness, distress, and anguish. Indeed, this is what the evangelists teach about him when they attest that he said: 'My soul is very sorrowful, even to death' (Matthew 26:38) and 'Now is my soul troubled' (John 12:27). It is also written about him in the Gospel of Mark: 'He began to be greatly distressed and troubled' (Mark 14:33). Just as we confess that the passions of his flesh occurred in truth and not merely in appearance, so we believe that those of the soul occurred in truth and not merely in appearance. As for those who say that while he was being scourged, he did not feel pain, or that while he was crucified, he did not suffer, even as the nails pierced him, we anathematize them as heretics. But we confess that he truly died for our sins, that his body was laid in the tomb, where it remained without his soul, and that after three days, he truly rose from the dead; that after his resurrection, he ate and drank with his disciples, truly and not merely in appearance, that he ascended to heaven, and that at the end of the world, he will come to judge the living and the dead and will raise the entire human race from the dead in incorruptibility, the bodies in which men have died and been buried possessing the same nature, just as he also possessed the same body when he rose from the dead.

Everywhere, it is in a flesh that felt and experienced pain—a living body that is naturally capable of feeling and suffering—that the action of suffering truly took place, just as in the soul, sadness, affliction, and distress are by nature particular sufferings of the rational soul. However, all of this was proper to the impassible Word of God, who is not affected by any feeling of suffering, because, by the hypostatic union, the body endowed with soul and spirit is subject to such sufferings. Therefore, due to the inseparable nature of the union, it is he himself whom we rightly believe to have experienced pain, to have been in sadness, affliction, and distress, even though in this state he felt none of these sufferings, since he is impassible as God. Indeed, he said, "Just as we confess that the sufferings of his body occurred in truth and not in appearance, so we believe that those of his soul also occurred in truth and not in appearance" (2 Corinthians 5:21). Thus, even if the sufferings were naturally proper to the body and the soul, the Word, incarnate in a flesh endowed with an intelligent soul and naturally capable of enduring them, truly assigned to himself the feeling and pains of suffering, by the fact that he had become man, while remaining impassible as God, who, according to his nature, is not subject to suffering.

In the same way, the very wise Cyril also declares in the twelfth book of his Commentary on the Gospel of Matthew: "Our Savior knows anguish and sorrow, and he embraces our sufferings, although he is God who transcends and is above suffering, so that in all things it may be truly recognized that he possesses humanity. Indeed, just as it is written that he was weary from the journey, while he is the master of powers and is himself entirely Power, it is also said that he was hungry, even though he is the living bread that came down from heaven and gives life to the world; likewise, he has known anguish, even though he is himself total joy, the enjoyment and happiness of all. And we do not

say in any way that he embraced our sufferings in his nature, the impassible and inviolable Word of God, nor in what is recognized as being God, but that what was proper to humanity became common to him, because likewise what was proper to the Word of God taken in isolation and concerned only him alone became common to the flesh due to the ineffable and inexplicable union. And although it is the Word who descended from heaven, he also said that the flesh descended from heaven: 'For no one has ascended into heaven except he who descended from heaven, the Son of Man' (John 3:13). Furthermore, he submits to sufferings, taking upon himself for us those characteristics that are ours, to deliver us from torment and condemnation. 'For it is by his wounds that we have been healed' (Isaiah 53:5), according to what is written.

It is therefore not appropriate for those who, along with the doctors of the holy Church, confess that things happen this way, to imitate Nicodemus, who, driven by disbelief and a carnal spirit, declared regarding the divine regeneration brought about by baptism, "How can a man be born when he is old? Can he enter a second time into his mother's womb and be born?" and again, "How can this be?" For the Fathers, being instructed by God, understood from the inspired Scriptures this: "If you do not believe, you will not understand" (Isaiah 7:9) and this: "If you will, seek and remain close to me" (Jeremiah 29:13), and this: "Search the Scriptures" (John 5:39). It is both by believing and by seeking in a legitimate manner that they remained close to God, without straying outside or allowing their thoughts to pursue a profane, foreign, and deceitful wisdom, acquiring, through the Holy Spirit who searches all things, the understanding of what they were coming to know. This is why the insightful Cyril, in the fourth book of his Commentary on the Gospel of John, commenting on what the disciples said to our Lord, our God and Savior, Christ: "And we

have believed and known that you are the Christ, the Son of God," declares this: "They indeed say that they have believed and known, uniting the two things. For it was necessary that they both believe and know. And it is not because divine realities are perceived by faith that one must henceforth refrain from seeking on their subject, but rather apply oneself to rise to a limited knowledge, in a mysterious manner and as in a mirror, as Paul has said (1 Corinthians 13:12). And it is with precision that they did not say that they first knew and then believed, but after having put forth faith, they also added knowledge afterward. For it is after faith that knowledge is born and not before faith, as it is written: "If you do not believe, you will not understand" (Isaiah 7:9).

Your Holiness should know that the Fathers did not apply the sign and example of the burning bush, which burned without being consumed, to the suffering of our Savior in this manner, as it is indeed poorly suited and contrary to the overall intention of the economy, as the exposition has shown; rather, they brought it forth as a glorious illustration of the birth of Emmanuel according to the flesh, to demonstrate that, beyond all understanding, God dwelled in the womb of a virgin, that he was incarnated from her without undergoing any change, and that he neither consumed nor annihilated his mother who bore him, nor the flesh that was united to him, endowed with a soul by the one who gave him birth. Indeed, the very wise John, Bishop of Constantinople, in his homily titled On the Birth of Christ, writes: "O bush, which Moses saw on the mountain burning and not consumed! Virgin Mary, who gives birth and is not corrupted!" Similarly, the venerable Theodotus, Bishop of Ancyra, declared regarding the same account: "For the mysteries are prefigured by ancient symbols; that is why the bush burns, the fire appears without accomplishing the effects of fire: it illuminates and does not corrupt, it shines and does not

consume, it is beneficial to it and does not deform it. Do you not see in the bush the Virgin? Do you not grasp in the fire the mercy of him who has come?" And the eminent Cyril, in the treatise On the Unity of Christ, states: "O our friend, it is rather extravagances that are uttered by one who says there was confusion or mixture if we profess that the unique nature of the Son was incarnated and became man. For it is impossible for anyone to prove this with solid and compelling reasoning. And while they impose their will as law, they conceive a design that they cannot sustain, for we prefer to adhere to divine Scripture and not to them! If they think, moreover, that the nature of man, because it is nothing compared to divine greatness, has been frustrated and absorbed by it, as they say, once again we say: 'You are mistaken, because you do not know Scripture and the power of God.' For it was not difficult for the merciful God to be carried by the measures of humanity. And this is what he foreshadowed in advance for our sake in a figurative manner, by initiating Moses into the mysteries and describing, in symbolic form, the mode of the incarnation. He indeed descended upon a bush in the desert in the form of fire; and the fire shone upon this modest plant, which nevertheless was not consumed. At this vision, Moses was struck with astonishment: How did the fire not alter the wood? And how could a material easily inflammable withstand the violence of the flame? But the fact was, as I have said, the sign of the mystery that reveals that his divine nature, because the Word of God willed it, was capable of bearing human measures; for there is absolutely nothing that is difficult for him!

It is therefore rightly that he used this sign and example, in accordance with the spirit of divine Scripture, to highlight the intimate relationship and union of the Word of God with a flesh endowed with an intelligent soul. However, regarding redemptive suffering, he employs another



example that shows, as far as possible, that the same one suffered in the flesh, yet remained impassible in his divinity, and that it was not the flesh that, while suffering, was impassible amid the sufferings. First citing the question of a contradictor in these terms: "How then do they say that, while he himself suffered, he did not suffer?" he then responds: "By suffering in his own flesh and not in the nature of divinity; the expression of this matter is absolutely indescribable, and the mind, whatever it may be, does not reach ideas as subtle and elevated as these! But following the path of correct reasoning and considering things with the appropriate standard, we do not render the Word foreign to what is said to have suffered, especially to avoid saying that the birth according to the flesh is not his, but someone else's, nor do we establish that what is proper to the flesh was realized in his divine and transcendent nature. It is acknowledged, as I have said, that he suffered in his own flesh, while he did not suffer in a similar manner in divinity. The strength of examples is entirely powerless and does not reach the exactness of the truth; however, it provides in the spirit a deficient representation of the very reality and elevates us from things that are within our grasp toward heights and realities that surpass reason. Just as when iron, or another material of this kind, placed within the assaults of fire, allows itself to be consumed by the fire and the flame penetrates to its very core; if it happens to be struck from somewhere, the material receives the wound, but the nature of the fire is not harmed by the one who struck. Understand also things in this way, when the Son is said to have suffered in the flesh without having suffered in his divinity. The strength of the example is limited, as I have said, but it brings closer to the truth those who do not wish to oppose the divine words. Thus, the iron, which has entirely become fire and has welcomed within itself all the consuming force of the flame, to the point of no longer being separated from it and being considered one with it, receives the wound

when struck and is subjected to blows while being straightened or expanded, while (in all this) the fire suffers nothing. It is the same with the Word of God who became incarnate and became man without undergoing change: while, in a manner that surpasses all understanding, he was without separation in relation to his flesh—indeed, he was hypostatically united to it—he himself suffered nothing, for he is, in his nature, impassible as God; yet suffering was proper to him and not foreign, since the flesh that was united to him was proper to him and not foreign, and in that very flesh suffering acted; it advanced only as far as itself and was incapable of surpassing it and reaching the divinity of the one who is impassible; thus, one can believe and recognize, according to what is fitting, that the same one is impassible in his divinity and passible in his humanity.

The divine Scriptures and those who have interpreted them have indeed sought numerous signs and examples in order to grasp, as much as possible, an aspect of the divine incarnation. Thus, when pagans and heretics, afflicted with the same spirit, asked, "How could a pure and immaculate God be united with this foul and impure flesh?" they refuted this senseless objection with another example, demonstrating that the body of Christ our Savior is entirely holy and free from any contamination of sin—this alone being understood as impurity—while, on the other hand, God indeed perfects and enriches those whom he approaches without contracting any impurity. The very wise Cyril writes in the eighth discourse of the second book *Against Julian the Apostate*: "Just as a ray of sunlight, which descends upon muddy places or other filthy objects, does not contract any pollution, so too, although the pure and invulnerable nature has joined itself to bodies that come from the earth, it is rather beneficial to them and does not contract any of the evils that could harm it." However, as long as this example is applied solely to the purity and immaculate character of the

divine incarnation and is used only for this purpose, we avoid its ambiguity; for it indeed suggests, in some way, the idea of a nearby illumination: thus it is said that God shone in the prophets and holy men when he acted in them, illuminating them and making them participants in his grace. For it is in this way that the sun and fire illuminate a dark place into which they penetrate and communicate their own warmth, without forming a union according to nature, as the same wise teacher also teaches in the work called Scholies: "We believe that a very intimate and true union has been realized in Christ. But if it is said that he dwelt among us, it is not a dwelling of complacency that he has realized—indeed, the whole fullness of the deity dwells bodily in us (Colossians 2:9)—that is to say, it is not by a simple association or by complacency, like a light that illuminates or a fire that imparts its natural heat to what approaches it; rather, so to speak, the divine and inviolable nature has made the temple taken from the Virgin something that is suitable as a dwelling but by a true union, as I have said. Christ Jesus is indeed recognized in this way." And because the example of the light of the sun and fire is not suitable to express the natural and hypostatic union, he resorted to another example and declares in the same Scholies: "We say, therefore, that it is appropriate to think—since our language is in any case inferior to the truth—that the union of Emmanuel is of the kind that one would represent as that of the human soul with its own body." Thus, every symbol, like every example, is chosen with regard to the only aspect that suits it, but for the aspect that does not suit it, it becomes irrelevant and is rejected. Also, when he refers to a symbol while addressing Acacius, bishop of Scythopolis, he says: "But let us allow the examples to be understood in the manner that suits them. They are inferior to the truth and sometimes provide only a partial meaning of the figurative things." Similarly, Gregory the Theologian, in the treatise On the Holy Spirit, states regarding the question of the Holy Trinity that we must

draw from every image and example only the aspect that will be appropriate, and reject and disregard the others that do not fit: "And in short, there is nothing that does not fix the thought when I examine in an example a thing to which the Spirit applies, except in the case where one takes from the image only some aspect and, in a correct thought, rejects the others.

Thus, the symbol and example of the burning bush that was not consumed have been taken by the doctors in accordance with the appropriateness and spirit of divine Scripture to represent the union of the Word of God with the flesh or the indwelling in the Holy Virgin, so that it appears, even if only faintly, how human flesh could endure the proximity and indwelling of the divinity, to which no one can approach without being absorbed, consumed, or perishing. Gabriel said to Mary, "The power of the Most High will overshadow you" (Luke 1:35), but no one has cited the bush as an image of redemptive suffering, in the sense that it would imply that the suffering flesh, amidst its sufferings, both suffered and did not suffer, like the bush that burned but was not consumed. While one might limit the term to call it, misleadingly, subject to suffering, one would deny, upon closer examination, the full meaning of the term, especially since the holy Scriptures openly proclaim that Christ endured suffering like us, apart from sin (Hebrews 4:15), and that he truly tasted death without rejecting for this reason the passibility of a flesh that suffered like ours, nor did he experience either true death or authentic suffering, because it was for our sins and not for his own—our Savior is indeed without sin—and without any compulsion upon himself, he suffered voluntarily, he died, and, due to the swiftness of his resurrection, he rendered the experience of his death, so to speak, unknown.

And let it be so, John, bishop of Constantinople, also demonstrates this in the fourth discourse of his Commentary on the Epistle to the

Hebrews, writing: "And it is indeed true that he said he tasted death for all, and not that he would die; for just as he truly tasted it, he remained only a short time in it and was immediately resurrected. Therefore, in saying, 'Because of the suffering of death,' he signified true death; and in saying 'superior to the angels,' he made the resurrection understood. Just as a physician, who does not feel the need to taste prepared food for the sick, first tastes it himself out of concern for the patients, to persuade them to boldly take nourishment, so too, since all men feared death, to persuade them to despise death, he himself tasted death, even though he had no necessity to do so. He indeed says: 'The prince of this world comes, and he has no claim on me.'" And again in the fifth discourse: "Our sufferings do not escape him; he knows them not only as God, but he also knows them as man through the temptation that tested him. He has endured much: he knows how to suffer with us, even though he is an impassible God. But he recounts here what pertains to the incarnation, as if to say that the flesh of Christ has endured many evils, that he knows what affliction is, no less than we who suffer." And after this, in the seventeenth discourse, he says: "And for what reason did he die 'once for all'? Because he became a ransom for a single death. It had indeed been established that all men would die. Now, this 'he died once' is understood: for everyone. What then? Will we not die from this death? Certainly, we will die, but we will not remain in it; that is no longer dying! There is indeed the tyranny of death and true death when it is not permitted for one who dies to return to life; but when, after our death, it is possible for us to live, and to live a superior life, that is no longer death, but sleep. Because death was destined to seize all men, it is for this reason that he died to deliver us.

As I have said, no prominent doctors have used the example of the bush to signify that while our Lord's flesh suffered at the time of his sufferings and death, it was at the same time incorruptible, that is to

say, impassible and immortal; rather, it was to recognize in this thing, which became prey to the flames, his passibility and mortal nature at the time of his sufferings and death; and in the fact that it was not consumed, the idea of not remaining in death, of not being completely imprisoned, and of being rendered, through the resurrection, immortal, impassible, and incorruptible. Look, I pray you, John, in the thirteenth homily of the Commentary on the First Epistle to the Corinthians, which takes the example of the bush in the intention I have mentioned: “And how is what the Scriptures declared presented, that he was also buried and that he would rise on the third day? By the symbol of Jonah, which our Lord himself cited by saying: ‘Just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the heart of the earth’ (Matthew 12:40). By the bush in the desert: just as it burned but was not consumed, so also this body died but was not held forever by death. There is the dragon, which in Daniel is depicted: just as after having eaten the food given to him by the prophet, he was broken in the middle, so also, when Sheol had absorbed this body, it was broken, because the body itself perforated its entrails and rose again.” Thus, the mortal nature of the body and its immortality are distinguished according to the times. On one hand, it was mortal at the time of death and suffering—our Lord indeed suffered voluntarily in the flesh and died, according to what is written—on the other hand, it was immortal, that is to say, incorruptible and impassible, at the time of the resurrection. And this other thing also clearly follows from the Doctor's words: what the doctors have repeatedly stated, that our Lord's flesh was not held by death, was said in reference to complete detention; for he clearly said this: “This body also is dead, but was not completely held by death” (Acts 2:24).

It is, however, a significant deviation from what is appropriate and necessary to introduce the miracle into the debate and declare this: just

as our Savior walked on the sea and multiplied five loaves to the point of feeding five thousand men, not counting women and children, and showed twelve baskets filled with leftovers, just as he entered a house with the doors closed and stood in the midst of the gathered disciples, so it must be said that even in the passible body of our Lord and during his sufferings, while he voluntarily suffered for others, incorruptibility, that is to say impassibility and immortality, always remained. Indeed, concerning natural and human sufferings, the doctors have taught us to understand and say that the flesh naturally received them, but that the Word of God, who remained impassible above all, also assigned to himself, due to his ineffable union with the body, the passions, allowing, voluntarily, the flesh to endure them; as for the miracles, we should understand and confess them as befitting God and not as befitting man; that the passions occurred according to the natural law, the Word willing it so, while the miracles, on the other hand, were accomplished above the laws of nature. Thus, indeed, the death that our Savior died for us in the flesh occurred according to the law of human nature, but it was an operation befitting God, who willed to die in a human manner, which was the resurrection. And in this regard, we have cited the wise Cyril, who, in Discourse 4 to Emperor Theodosius, taught in this way: "... he who died according to the law of the flesh and our nature and who is resurrected. If dying is a human suffering, in rising, he revealed a divine operation.

Thus, it is not because of the divine and supernatural operation of the resurrection that we deny that our Lord and God Jesus Christ underwent death and other sufferings according to the law of the flesh and in our nature, nor is it because miracles are above nature that we claim that sufferings are not natural. It is not because those things are divine that these are no longer human. Rather, it is one and the same that possesses both divine and human characteristics, without them

being in any way divided between the two natures, because Christ is one, coming from two, from divinity and humanity, a unique person, a unique hypostasis, and a unique nature of the incarnate Word of God who, according to his divinity and above man, and indeed above all created nature, performed miracles, and according to his humanity, experienced voluntary human sufferings that healed our wounds. Emmanuel, as the doctor states in the same discourse, "is composed of human characteristics and also of characteristics that surpass man in something unique situated in the middle. For he is the mediator between God and men, according to what is written, who is, on one hand, God by nature and not outside of the flesh, and on the other hand, truly man and not an ordinary man like us; and he is what he was, even though he became flesh." Therefore, when the Roman pierced his side with a spear, that wound constituted a human suffering, for it was the nature of a human body, even an inanimate one, to be torn and pierced by iron; indeed, after he had given up the spirit, as the Evangelist John says, the Roman had this audacity; yet that blood and water flowed from his side at the same time, and from it gloriously sprang the source of the life-giving mysteries in which we are purified, there is the perfection and divine operation. Indeed, even if the soul and body were separated from one another in death, the Word of God was united to both by a superior union, because he is fullness as God and is not divided in space: through the soul he accomplished the descent into hell by breaking the bonds of those below, and on the other hand, through the burial of the body, he cast into the tomb the seed of the resurrection, thus rising as befits God and breaking the power of death and corruption, because it was absolutely impossible for him to be held by them; he became for all men the firstfruits of incorruptibility, impassibility, and immortality because he died and rose for all; he voluntarily accepted the human characteristic of sufferings because he truly became man, and he performed miracles



as befits God because he was God by nature; and he deified us through his flesh and raised us from the dead so that we might become gods.

This is what Saint Athanasius also confirms in the third discourse of his work *On the Trinity* against the infamous Arians: "Indeed, the flesh was resurrected and deified, and it was no longer fitting for him, while ascending to heaven, to respond according to the flesh, but rather to teach henceforth according to divinity: 'It is not for you to know the times and the seasons which the Father has fixed by his own authority'" (Acts 1:7). He indicates that he was, for us, the origin of what we became, so to speak, gods, meaning of immortality, and that he accomplished everything for our sake by establishing even for the conditions that are ours a path through what belongs to him, as he states in the second discourse of the same work: "Thus, the truth itself shows that the Word is not among the creatures, but rather their own creator. Indeed, it is in this way that he also assumed a created and human body, so that, renewing this body in himself as creator, he might deify it and thereby introduce us all, in his image, into the kingdom of heaven." He further adds: "In him, therefore, the human race has been made perfect and has returned to its original state, such as it was when it was made at the beginning, by a grace distinctly greater. For after we are resurrected from the dead, we will no longer fear death, but we will reign forever in Christ in heaven." And again: "It is therefore to bear witness, to accept death for us, to resurrect humanity, and to destroy the works of Satan that our Savior came, and this is indeed the reason for his coming in the flesh; otherwise, if death had not occurred, there would have been no resurrection; and how could death have occurred if he had not had a body capable of dying?"

Thus, these ideas are clearly distinguished by the doctors and by the holy Scriptures: it is in a mortal and suffering body that our Savior endured suffering and death, and it is through the resurrection that he

became incorruptible, that is to say, impassible and immortal, while from the beginning he possessed within himself the incorruptibility of impassibility and holiness; both aspects are indeed clearly reported by Scripture, that he did not commit sin, that he suffered in the flesh, and that he died in the flesh. Therefore, let us not be troubled in any way if, while reading their works and their words, we find them declaring that it is through the incarnation of the Word of God that death and corruption have been destroyed. These declarations indeed anticipate the term of the resurrection; for from the foundation and the beginning, the entire reason for the economy is perfect, and everything is considered complete: it is because of the term, that is to say, of death and resurrection, that the very foundation of Christ's becoming in the flesh has been established. I have also shown that the venerable John, bishop of Constantinople, taught this when he explains the word of Christ to his Father: "The work that you gave me, I have accomplished" (John 17:4). And this, although until that moment it had only been the beginning, we might say: not even the beginning of the work! How does he say: "I have accomplished," or does he speak of the future as if it were a past thing, or rather, and this is what must be said above all, that everything was now realized by the fact that the root of good had been planted, from which the fruits must necessarily emanate.

It is certainly for this reason that the most holy Athanasius states, while also referring to the term of the resurrection, that from the incarnation of the Word of God, death and corruption had been destroyed, and that henceforth the body, according to its nature, would not be subject to corruption. He indeed writes in the Catechetical Discourse on the bodily appearance of Our Lord Jesus Christ this way of seeing: "The body then, inasmuch as it possessed the common nature of all—indeed it was a human body—and although it had been constituted by a new

miracle solely from a Virgin, it was nonetheless mortal and, following the order of beings similar to it, was susceptible to death. However, by the coming of the Word into it, it no longer corrupted according to its nature, but, because of the Word of God who dwelt in it, it was freed from corruption.” To indicate that the fulfillment of what he has said would coincide with the term of the resurrection, the doctor immediately clarifies what he has declared and shows that he incarnated in a body capable of dying only to destroy in a marvelous manner, through a death that truly occurred, the power of the corruption of death thanks to the resurrection; this is what he adds by saying: “And it happened that the two (miracles) were gloriously realized in him: the death (common) to all was accomplished in the body of the Lord, and death itself and corruption were destroyed because of the Word united to the body! Indeed, a death was needed, and it was necessary that a death occur for all, so that what was said by all might take place. Thus, as I have said previously on several occasions, since it was impossible for him to die—he was indeed immortal—the Word took upon himself a body that could die, in order to offer for all this very body, as being his own, and, as one who suffered himself for all, to have made the body his own, in order to destroy Satan who held the power of death and to deliver all those who, through fear of death, were subject to lifelong slavery.” And again: “It is for this reason that he did not allow his body to remain long in the grave, but showed that death had only touched him, and on the third day he quickly resurrected him, removing from him the yoke of death and granting men, as a sign of victory over death, incorruptibility and impassibility of which his body had been the seat. It would indeed have been possible for him to immediately resurrect the body of the dead and to exhibit it alive again. But while he had considered this in advance, our Savior did not do it. For one might have said that he was not dead at all, or that death had not approached him at all, if

immediately after death he had manifested the resurrection; furthermore, if the moment of death had coincided with that of the resurrection, the grace of incorruptibility would not have been made manifest. Therefore, in order that it might appear that the body was dead, the Word even allowed a day to pass in the interval, and after three days he showed it to all as incorruptible. Thus, in order to demonstrate that death had indeed occurred in the body, he resurrected it on the third day; on the other hand, to prevent, when he would have finally resurrected after having remained long and completely corrupted, any denial that it was indeed (the body) itself, but that (the Word) had produced another body—indeed, it was possible over time that one might not recognize what was being manifested and forget what had occurred—for this very reason he did not allow more than three days to pass.

This doctrine also emphasizes what Peter, the leader of the apostolic college, specifically said about our Savior Christ: "Because it was not possible for him to be held by the corruption of death" (Acts 2:24), and not that he did not experience death in the flesh or was not subjected to its yoke; rather, he tore it away through the resurrection from the dead on the third day and did not submit to total corruption or dissolution. The Doctor indeed stated, "On the third day, he quickly resurrected the body, detaching from it the yoke of death." Furthermore, he said, "He will rise on the third day to prevent, if he had finally risen after having long remained and completely corrupted, that it would be said that this was not the (body) he had produced, but rather another." Thus, he experienced the violent generative force of the corruption of death, coming to know it even to the tomb; this was indeed what was foreseen: to pass through all our sufferings, except for sin, thereby destroying the power and strength they exerted upon us, as well as the kingship that death held and exercised, through the means of the

resurrection. From this resurrection originated incorruptibility, which is impassibility and immortality, making its way into the entire human race of which he was the firstfruits; just as death came through one man, so also the resurrection of the dead came through one man, as the Apostle said (1 Corinthians 15:21). Therefore, he who, while being God and the author of all creation, became man without undergoing change for the very purpose of becoming for us a principle of resurrection, incorruptibility, immortality, and impassibility, how could the irreproachable and voluntary sufferings, death, and burial diminish him, which he accepted and endured for the very purpose that resurrection, immortality, and incorruptibility might occur and be granted to us in addition? For if death had not preceded, how would resurrection have followed? This is why the Word of God has hypostatically united with a corruptible body, that is, mortal and passible, so that, necessarily, suffering and death would immediately be succeeded by resurrection, incorruptibility, immortality, and impassibility. It was therefore impossible for death not to come, just as it could not be that resurrection would not come, because the Word willed to become man for this very purpose and made this the reason for his incarnation: to have accepted to die for us and to destroy through the resurrection the power of corruption and death, proclaiming through the prophet Isaiah, "My entire plan will be realized, and I will accomplish all that I have thought" (Isaiah 46:10).

This is why the very wise Athanasius also declares in the same treatise: "He who is not certain of the resurrection seems to ignore the power of the Word and the Wisdom of God. For, in a word, if he took upon himself a body and appropriated it according to the mercy of the Father, as the exposition has shown, what was it that our Lord was to do, or what was the fitting end for the body once the Word had come to it? For it was impossible not to die since he was mortal and was offered

to death for all, which is why our Savior was attached to it. On the other hand, it could not be that he remained in death because he had become the temple of Life. Thus, he died as a mortal; he returned to life because of the Life that was in him, and his works are a demonstration of the resurrection. Furthermore, in the third discourse of the book *On the Trinity* against the impious Arians, it is stated that since he was in a body that suffered, we must attribute to him, along with the body, also what is proper to the flesh. Therefore, if he wept and experienced distress, it was not the Word himself, inasmuch as he is the Word, who wept and experienced distress, but this belonged to the flesh. If, on the other hand, he asked that the cup pass from him, it was not the divinity itself that experienced fear, but this suffering was also proper to his humanity. And the words, ‘Why have you forsaken me?’ (Matthew 27:46), as has been shown above, while the Word himself endured nothing—he is indeed impassible—were spoken by the evangelists as if they were his, because he became man and it is through man that they were said, so that by removing these sufferings from the flesh, he would have rendered it free from them! Thus, it was also impossible for our Lord to be forsaken by the Father because he was always in him, both before he spoke and after he uttered that word. Nor should we say that the Lord experienced fear before whom the gates of hell trembled and abandoned the graves, the tombs opened, and many bodies of saints arose and appeared to their relatives. Let every heretic therefore be silent and tremble to say that the Lord experienced fear, he before whom death fled like a dragon, whom the demons dread, and whom the sea fears, because of whom the heavens are divided and all powers are shaken! Indeed, at the moment he said, ‘Why have you forsaken me?’ the Father showed that even then, as at all times, he was in him; for the earth, recognizing its Lord who spoke, was immediately seized with fear, the curtain was torn, the sun was hidden, and, as I have said, the tombs opened and the dead who were

there arose. And here is what is marvelous: those who were there and had previously denied him finally confessed at this sight that he was truly the Son of God. As for the word, ‘If it is possible, let this cup pass from me!’ (Matthew 26:39), they learn how, while having said this, he rebuked Peter and declared to him, ‘Your views are not those of God’ (Matthew 16:23). It is that he wanted precisely what he rejected and why he had come. But it was proper for him to will—because this is why he came—while it was also proper to the flesh to fear; thus, it was as a man that he pronounced that word. And it is also by the same that the two statements were made, to show that he was God, the very one who willed and who possessed, having become man, a flesh that feared, for which he had combined his will with human weakness; in this way, by removing the latter, he would restore man’s courage against death. Behold then the truly glorious thing: he whose adversaries of Christ thought spoke under the effect of fear, himself rendered men courageous and undaunted through this imaginary fear. Thus, after him, the blessed apostles, based on these words, despised death to the point of not caring for those who judged them, but saying, ‘We must obey God rather than men’ (Acts 5:29). As for the other holy martyrs, they were so valiant that they thought they were entering into life rather than suffering death.

We should therefore feel neither fear nor confusion regarding the voluntary stripping and poverty of the Word, given that, being God, he became man for us without undergoing any change, and he hypostatically united himself with a body endowed with a soul and spirit, suffering as we do and being consubstantial with us, so that by enduring our sufferings, which were free from all sin, and dying our death, he destroyed their power through the resurrection. Indeed, he is the same one who was, without division, both God and man, that is to say, God made man, a single person, a single hypostasis and incarnate

nature, that of the Word of God himself. By divine signs, on the one hand, he clearly manifested that he was God, and by his voluntary and human sufferings, on the other hand, that he truly became man. It is therefore not out of piety that some, in the thought of instituting a defense, disrupt the order of the economy regarding the divine character of the miracles and the glorious birth of the Virgin Mother of God, deny the passible and mortal character of the body, turn the authenticity of the sufferings into conjecture, and fall into the traps of the Eutychians and the atheistic Manicheans; or conversely, regarding the human character of the sufferings and death, they blasphemously declare, like Paul of Samosata, Photinus, Nestorius, and those who follow them, that he is merely a man who suffered and not a God incarnate who, in what is naturally capable of suffering, that is to say, in the flesh, truly endured everything and confirms, through his passions and death, that by grappling with death through sufferings in a corruptible body, that is to say, mortal and passible, and by undergoing their trial, he rendered powerless the strength of corruption through the resurrection and inaugurated incorruptibility, impassibility, and immortality for us, men of his race according to the flesh, because he became the firstborn among the dead. For the Doctor has also clearly taught in the text just cited that to say the body of our Savior Christ is corruptible is the same as saying it is passible and mortal, writing this: "For it is not in what has not taken body that what belongs to the body would have occurred, unless he took a corruptible and mortal body." Indeed, it was mortal, the holy Mary from whom the body was derived. Therefore, since he was in a body that suffered, we must attribute to him, along with the body, also what is proper to the flesh. Here he calls the same body indifferently corruptible, mortal, suffering, and not distant, from the moment of the incarnation, from the capacity to suffer and die, but also undergoing, in the very trial of death and sufferings, what is proper to him, and, through the resurrection, rendered alive and



becoming incorruptible and immortal. He indeed said: "Therefore he died as mortal; he returned to life because of the Life that was in him, and his works are a demonstration of the resurrection.

However, if it frightens us to say that the body of our Savior was corruptible before the resurrection, even though the doctors of piety have clearly expressed it this way, if we feel inclined to attribute to him the corruption and contamination resulting from sin, we should not hesitate to confess him as passible either, because it is the shameful passions, which fall under the guilt of sin, that are properly called passions, as the venerable Gregory, Bishop of Nyssa, taught in what has been examined above, while the others are improperly called passions. Nevertheless, just as the doctors have confessed him as passible because the body is naturally capable of undergoing irreproachable passions, they have also called him corruptible because he is likewise naturally apt to be corrupted by these same irreproachable passions and by death, without in any way denying the authenticity of the flesh of our Lord or the similarity of his passions to ours, due to the divine character of his birth from the Virgin and the glory of the miracles. Thus, let us listen to the eminent Cyril declaring: "When, therefore, the power of death is exercised only on what is naturally apt to be corrupted, it is also rightly acknowledged that the force of the resurrection is recognized, so that the force of this tyrant may also be destroyed. The fact that our Lord entered while the doors were closed will be classified by the wise among his other wonders." Therefore, if death occurred in a natural manner in the body because it is naturally apt to be corrupted, entering while the doors were closed is a miracle. Now, a miracle is accomplished above nature and beyond all reason. However, we will not deny, because of his glorious miracles that surpass nature, that the voluntary sufferings of the Savior occurred according to the law of human nature; nor do we say in an impious

manner, due to the humiliating nature of the sufferings, that he who was affected by them is not the one who, as God, performed the power of miracles and wonders. For it appears from these two aspects, from what he accomplished in a divine manner and from what he suffered according to humanity, that the same one, while being God by nature, truly became man.

And let it be so, Saint Athanasius further confirms this in his Letter to Maximus the Philosopher, writing: "Thus, even when he became man, we saw his glory, as it is written, the glory befitting the Only Begotten, full of grace and truth. For what he suffered in his body, he magnified as God. He experienced hunger in the flesh and, according to his divinity, satisfied those who were hungry. And if someone is scandalized by these bodily characteristics, let him believe because of what he accomplished as God. He inquired, according to his divinity, where Lazarus had been laid, but he raised him according to his divinity. Therefore, let no one be scandalized when speaking of a little child or when pronouncing the words of age and growth, of eating, drinking, and suffering, to avoid rejecting what is proper to the body and thus entirely denying his coming to us. Just as it was not according to the order of nature that he became man, it was also fitting that after taking a body, he manifested what is proper to the body, so that the illusion of the atheist Manes would not prevail. On the other hand, it was also fitting that after coming in bodily form, he did not hide what is proper to divinity, so that Paul of Samosata would not find a pretext. Therefore, considering all this, let the unbeliever learn that he was a little child in the manger, but on the other hand, he ruled over the Magi, being adored by them; that as a child he went down into Egypt, but he destroyed idolatry, the work of hands, and that, crucified in the flesh, he brought back to life the dead who had decayed for a considerable time. And it is evident to anyone that he did not suffer all

this for himself, but for us, so that, being clothed through these sufferings with impassibility and immortality, we may remain for eternal life.

Indeed, it is not to deny the consubstantiality with us or to suggest that he shares in our passions that Christ God and our Savior was born according to the flesh of the Holy Spirit and the ever-Virgin Mary; nor is it to condemn marriage and the union of man and woman as a corruption and a stain resulting from sin; rather, it is because he needed to show us born of the Spirit through holy baptism: he conferred upon us the washing of regeneration as a pledge of the renewed washing through the resurrection, so that he himself became, for us who are formed and born anew, the firstfruits of this spiritual birth, being born himself first in this manner and becoming a second Adam. For according to the word of our Savior himself, "In the resurrection, they neither marry nor are given in marriage, but are like angels of God in heaven" (Matthew 22:30). Indeed, after Adam lost the grace of immortality due to sin and was destined to decay into the earth from which he was taken, the aid of marriage was presented in its time to preserve the race through the generation of children. This aid had been established in advance by God, who foresees all; in making man at the beginning, he created him male and female. Thus, there is no stain of contamination resulting from sin in marriage itself, but rather it is because of the fall of man, which resulted from sin and the transgression of the commandment, that this aid has appeared in this world and at this time. This is why Christ became man, transforming us in view of a higher birth, the renewal of the resurrection, and an angelic life that lasts forever.

This is what the eminent Cyril wisely teaches in his work addressed to the faithful Emperor Theodosius, stating, "It is indeed to become the first in all things, as it is written, that he was born of a woman. But

since he is the firstfruits of creation, which is renewed in holiness for God, he appeared before others, born of the Spirit, without waiting for the union of man and woman; not that he condemned nature as a disgrace or guilt—after all, marriage itself is honorable, and he who formed them from the beginning made them male and female (Genesis 1:27)—but because, in bringing humanity to a state far superior and incomparably higher, he wanted us to be called born of the Spirit and no longer born of man.

John, the bishop of Constantinople, in his Commentary on the Fourth Gospel, when our Lord speaks to Nicodemus, writes this: "For what is born of the flesh is flesh." He diverts him from sensible things and does not allow him to scrutinize mysteries with these eyes. For he says, "We are not speaking of the flesh, but of the spirit, Nicodemus." From this moment, he has, through this word, sent him back to things above, so that he does not seek anything among sensible things. For the spirit does not appear to these eyes. Therefore, do not think that the spirit begets carnal objects. Someone might say, "And how is it that our Lord is flesh, since he was not born of the Spirit alone but of the flesh?" It is for the same reason that Paul says, "Born of a woman, born under the law" (Galatians 4:4). The Spirit indeed created him thus: not from what is not—otherwise, why was the womb required?—but from the virgin flesh; as for the "how," I cannot explain it! Now this was accomplished so that no one would think him a stranger to our nature. For there are some who, even when this is accomplished, do not believe it; in what impieties have they not fallen, unless he had shared in the flesh of the Virgin? Similarly, in the commentary on the first letter to the Corinthians, he states, "For it is not the fact of being born of the earth that gives, in an absolute manner, the earthly character, since our Lord was also made from the same clay and the same matter, but the fulfillment of things proper to the earth; just as he is celestial because

he has seen things worthy of heaven.

Theophilus, who demonstrated divine and fervent zeal tempered by the precision of divine doctrine against pagans and all idolaters, and who illuminated the see of the Church of Alexandria, writes in his Twenty-First Festal Letter the following: "He was born a man of a virgin, coming to meet our race in all that we are, except for sin; but coming in an admirable mode of appearance, he blessed human nature." Furthermore, in his Twenty-Fourth Letter, he states: "For the Word of God could create a body as a temple from a body that had not undergone the trial of marriage when, for our salvation, he came into the world; nor can the order of our nature, which originates from marriage, ever hinder the glorious operation of God; and our Savior, who redeemed us, was neither contaminated nor profaned when he gave the virginal blood the substance of flesh for a full and merciful association with us.

Similarly, the great and wise theologian Basil, in composing a polemical work Against Eunomius, writes, "The nature of those who are begotten is the same as that of those who beget, even if the one who is begotten comes into being in a different manner. Indeed, he was neither different nor like Adam; Abel was begotten as a result of a coupling, for Adam was not begotten but fashioned." Furthermore, he states, "If those who have a different mode of coming into existence also have a different nature, then men do not belong to a single nature; indeed, the manner of coming into existence of Adam, who was fashioned from the earth, is different from that of Eve, who was taken from his side; different again is that of Abel, who came from a coupling, and different is that of the one who was taken from Mary, who was born of a virgin alone.

Athanasius, the apostolic doctor, states in the previously cited text, "The body, therefore, as it had acquired a nature in common with

all—since it was a human body—and although it was constituted only from a virgin by a new miracle, was nonetheless mortal." He further explains, "For what belongs to the body would not have occurred in what has not taken on flesh, if he had not taken on a corruptible and mortal body. Indeed, the body from which holy Mary was derived was mortal. Thus, since he became incarnate in a body that suffered, wept, and experienced pain, it is fitting that what is proper to the flesh be attributed to him along with the body." Saint Proclus also adds in the previously mentioned text, "The Word of God therefore became a perfect man, without this miracle that surpasses understanding diminishing the immutable nature. But this we have learned through faith and have not attained through investigation. And, having become man, he redeemed the race that was associated with him according to the flesh by suffering as we do.

Why then, when the doctors refer to the most holy body of our Lord, God and Savior Jesus Christ, as corruptible before the resurrection, in that he is mortal and suffers like us and is subject to ungovernable passions, does your Holiness divert the discussion from what is corruptible by virtue of sin? Indeed, all confess that he is both sinless and full of all holiness and that, by the same token, he is incorruptible from the Incarnation. You have written, in fact: "If they understand what Cyril, who is among the saints, says—that after the resurrection, our Lord had acquired an incorruptible body, and that before the resurrection he was corruptible, let them also say that he is in sin." But it is easy for us to counter this with the words that have been frequently repeated. As Scripture tells us about our great God and Savior Jesus Christ, these two things: that he committed no sin and that no deceit was found in his mouth (1 Peter 2:22), and that from the very swaddling clothes he rejected evil (Luke 2:7), and furthermore, that he suffered in the flesh and died in the flesh, the Fathers, who teach the

mysteries to those under the sun, have declared that incorruptibility has always existed in the body of our Savior; but when, by virtue of submission to ungovernable sufferings and death, he suffered, died for us, and was resurrected from the dead, they professed him to be incorruptible and have transmitted to us in writing to confess this. For no one ever claimed that our Lord appeared suffering in a body that was impassible and immortal; rather, all instructed and taught the assemblies to which they were entrusted to believe in one and the same, passible according to the flesh and impassible according to divinity, as the exposition has abundantly demonstrated.

Let your piety consider how he expresses himself, questioning whether it is justly that he has declared the human body to be "in sin." Indeed, its unusual character struck my ears in a strange way; for until this day, I have found no one among those who have taught in Greek within the Church who has included it in their teachings, as it seems to me it would give a bad impression to those who hear it. Just as one who speaks of the animated body signifies a natural conjunction of soul and body, so too does one who speaks of the body "in sin" seem to indicate that sin is naturally included in the body. I mention this because of the unpleasantness of the expression and its unusual character, for it is clear that your holiness confesses everywhere that sin comes upon man like a disease. Furthermore, wise individuals like you must apply themselves to the accuracy and precision of terms. Yet perhaps someone might say: we also say of one who has attended a course in rhetoric and has perfected himself in this discipline that he has eloquence, and we say of one who has undergone many trials that he has experience; this does not mean that we think rhetorical discipline and the wealth of experience—due to the composition involved in expression—are naturally inherent to man as the body is, naturally, inherent to the soul. Thus, let it be clear to anyone who declares such

things that no one among the heretics has ever said that rhetorical discipline, art, or experience are naturally included in the constitution and nature of man. However, concerning sin, the Manichaeans and those who reason like them have said, in their blasphemous delirium, that it is mixed, like a natural element, with human substance. And that is why we have said that one should not call the body "in sin," but rather distance oneself from the suspicious and unusual character of the expression.

However, we must also examine this point with you and engage in a brief and focused discussion. You have indeed written, directing your discourse against those who confess Christ as suffering in the flesh, and in formulating the absolute decree, that the sufferings should in no way be called corruption, especially since, along with the holy Scriptures, even the wise of this world supported you. What you have said is, in your own words, that "the sufferings are not called corruption, nor are they among the wise of this world." I would also like to calm your piety on this point and recall the statements made regarding this by the wise of this world, if at least a memory of what comes from them still remains in me after such a considerable time. However, I rather consider the holy Scripture which, terrible and with anger, fixes its eyes upon me, so to speak, and cries out in my ears some reproach: "Drink water from your own cistern and from the wells of your own spring" and "In the assemblies, bless the springs of Israel, the Lord God." Now, the springs of Israel are those that nourish the holy assemblies: those that have been signed and written by Moses, the visions and revelations of the prophets, and all the writings that comprise the Old Testament; then, the writings of the evangelists and apostles, which constitute the New Testament, perfectly harmonize with the Old and show us that it is one unique God who has expressed both; from which it also follows that the coming in the flesh of the



Only-Begotten Word was announced in advance by the voice of the prophets and recognized by that of the apostles. As for the vessels that draw from the wells and springs of living water, filling themselves to overflowing so as to also pour out the drink for others, who are they, if not those eminent men who have been the ministers of the mysteries in the Churches and the teachers who, as David said, opened their mouths and breathed in the Spirit, who were not merely aware of the thoughts of the wise of this world, but who, like Moses, had been instructed in the total wisdom of the Egyptians and were made the most capable? Thus, the apostolic word requires and describes what the teacher of piety must be: that he should exhort with sound words and refute the contradictors who had sought to cunningly deceive those who believed in the great mystery of piety, as Paul himself said, "through philosophy and empty deceit according to human tradition and the elemental spirits of the world, and not according to Christ." Therefore, it is from the Scriptures cited above and from the teachers who have commented on them in the Spirit that we will undertake the discussion of the opinion that has been proposed to us.

Therefore, since your Holiness has absolutely defined that suffering should not be declared a corruption in any way, we understand this to refer to those sufferings that do not fall under the guilt of sin—indeed, it is these that concern the present inquiry, because we all profess to call the passions of sin corruption, as I mentioned earlier—I will provide a brief exposition on this subject. Now, regarding any wound, blow, weakness, alteration, disease of any kind, destruction, or complete loss, such as we see not only in the bodies of men but also in those of animals and plants and in seeds, I find that Holy Scripture consistently uses the term corruption, as well as words expressing decay or destruction. As for the corruption of sin, whose origin is the evil intention of man, it is unnecessary to cite testimonies, for the

profession of all is unanimous, as I stated above, and without any hesitation. However, it is easy to show immediately, from the book of Genesis, that it is by this same word that the passion residing in sin is named: "And God saw that the earth was corrupt, for all flesh had corrupted its way on the earth" (Genesis 6:12). And immediately, it is by the same name that He calls the judgment and complete annihilation of all flesh by the flood, for He says: "Behold, I will destroy them along with the earth" (Genesis 6:13). To clarify what is at stake, He added as He continued: "And behold, I will bring the floodwaters upon the earth to destroy all flesh in which is the breath of life under heaven; everything that is on the earth shall perish" (Genesis 6:17). Likewise, the punishment sent by God, which chastises for utility and brings death, to restrain malice and alleviate the torment for sinners in the age to come, He expressed no differently than by the term corruption. Furthermore, in the book of Exodus, regarding the plague of locusts, it is written: "Before them there had been no such locusts, nor will there be such after them. They covered the face of the whole earth, and the land was darkened. They devoured all the grass of the land and all the fruit of the trees that the hail had left, and there remained no green thing in the trees or in the plants of the field throughout all the land of Egypt" (Exodus 10:14-15).

The pain felt in the body causes excessive fatigue and weakness, and perhaps the resulting death, which divine Scripture calls by the same name of corruption. Indeed, just as Moses dedicated an entire day to inquiries and judgments for the people and resolved disputes among the contestants, Jethro, his father-in-law, seeing his excessive labor, said, "You will surely wear yourself out, for this thing is too heavy for you; you are not able to perform it by yourself" (Exodus 18:18). After advising him to appoint other judges to assist in hearing cases, he added, "And they will bear the burden with you" (Exodus 18:22). Who

then is unaware that it is for the benefit of his soul that Moses, in the service of God, led the people, rendered judgments, and bore such a burdensome task? What could be more beneficial to someone than to serve God for the well-being of those he leads and judges, who enjoy his divine voice, the care of his command, and the diligence of the support he provides, equal to that of a father? Nevertheless, this burdensome task is also called corruption in Scripture, and not simply corruption, but intolerable corruption! It indeed states, "You shall be corrupted with an intolerable corruption" (Deuteronomy 28:22). Now, Moses, the servant of God, received the words of Jethro, obeyed, and put them into practice! I mention this now because your Holiness, when you declared absolutely that "all sufferings are not called corruption, nor are they among the wise of the world," also added the following: "Especially when sufferings do not dominate the one who wishes to suffer, but become remedies for those who suffer." However, concerning the sufferings of Christ, the wise of the world have never said a word, but they have always spoken of other men afflicted by sufferings. In judging what occurs among men, we find no others who have shone and been filled with divine love, who have suffered voluntarily for their own well-being and that of their loved ones—without being dominated, defeated, or depressed by sufferings—like the holy martyrs and, before them, the prophets and patriarchs, of whom one, and the most notable, was Moses. Holy Scripture calls fatigue and the weakness that must naturally result from it corruption, for the body of one who was in the service of God and concerned for the members of his tribe was so diligent that the span of an entire day could not suffice for him, even though he was fatigued and enjoyed no rest!

I return once again to the authoritative statement that your Piety has made: that sufferings are not called corruption. For holy Scripture

refers to bruises, cuts, and bodily amputations as corruption, even in animals, in which, due to their irrational nature, there is neither guilt nor responsibility resulting from sin, despite the symbols (inspired by the body) that the book of the Law provides to warn us to offer and dedicate to God, in sacrifice, our healthy and immaculate souls; as Paul also stated in writing to the Romans that we must "present our bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and pleasing to God" (Romans 12:1). Thus it is written in the Book of Leviticus: "You shall not offer to the Lord an animal that is blind, crushed, mutilated, or has a discharge, or is leprous, or has a scab; you shall not offer any of these to the Lord as a food offering" (Leviticus 22:22). You shall make for yourself a sacrifice from an ox or a sheep that has a severed ear or tail. And you shall not offer to the Lord an animal that has crushed, broken, or torn testicles; you shall not offer it in your land, even by the hand of foreigners, nor shall you present any of these offerings to your God, because they contain blemishes. The prophet Malachi made a similar declaration: "You bring what has been taken by violence, the lame and the sick; if you offer them as a sacrifice, I will not accept them from your hands, says the Lord Almighty" (Malachi 1:13). Cursed is the cheat who has an acceptable male in his flock and vows to give it, but sacrifices a blemished animal to the Lord. Various kinds of infirmities that afflict the body are also referred to in this way. Indeed, he states in Deuteronomy, while enumerating the threats that weigh upon those who transgress the Law: "The Lord will strike you with madness, blindness, and confusion of mind; you will be oppressed and robbed continually, and no one will save you" (Deuteronomy 28:28-29). And in the same book, he uses the same term for the decrepitude of old age, the wrinkles of the face, and the dimming of sight; for indeed this suffering, common to old age, did not appear on the face of Moses until his death. He expresses it thus: "Moses was a hundred and twenty years old when he died; his eyes were not dim, nor his natural vigor

diminished" (Deuteronomy 34:7). And in other manuscripts, it is written, "And his face was not pale.

In the Book of Judges, the fact that the enemies harvested and cut down the fruits is described in a similar manner: "When Israel had sown, the Midianites, the Amalekites, and the sons of the East came up against them and encamped against them, and they destroyed the produce of the land as far as Gaza, and left no sustenance in Israel" (Judges 6:3-4). Also, regarding those who had fallen, killed in battle, the same Book of Judges uses the term "corruption": "And the sons of Benjamin came out of Gibeah and struck down on that day twenty-two thousand men of Israel" (Judges 20:21). A little further on, it states: "The sons of Israel engaged in battle with the sons of Benjamin on the second day; and Benjamin went out from Gibeah against them and struck down again eighteen thousand men of the people" (Judges 20:25).

David, the just man and prophet of God, who was unjustly harassed by Saul, while preparing to shut himself in the city of Keilah, said, as it is written in the first book of Kings, which is the book of Samuel, the following declaration: "And David said: Lord, God of Israel, your servant has heard that Saul intends to come to Keilah to destroy the city because of me, if it is shut in. And now will Saul come down, as your servant has heard? Lord, God of Israel, make it known to your servant" (1 Samuel 23:10-11). Furthermore, in the second book of Kings, according to the Greeks, which is also from Samuel, it is written: "And David sent Joab with his servants and all Israel, and they destroyed the Ammonites and besieged Rabbah" (2 Samuel 12:26). Later, as Joab was engaged with the city of Abel and a wise woman cried out to him from the wall, urging him not to destroy the entire city with its inhabitants, saying: "You intend to make perish the city, the mother of cities in Israel!" Joab replied: "Far be it from me! I will not

destroy it nor lay it waste" (2 Samuel 20:19). Thus, the total subjugation and destruction of cities are referred to by divine Scripture as annihilation, and this does not mean, as your piety suggests, the beginning or passage to corruption. Furthermore, in the same book, it is in the same manner, and not otherwise, that divine Scripture calls the plague sent by God upon the entire people, as correction and punishment for the judgment that befalls sinners: "And the Lord sent a plague upon Israel from the morning until the appointed time, and the plague struck the people, and there died among the people from Dan to Beersheba seventy thousand men; for David had stretched out his hand against Jerusalem to destroy it. And the Lord was moved by this calamity; he said to the angel who was destroying the people, 'Enough, now! Withdraw your hand'" (2 Samuel 24:15-16).

In the second volume of the book of Chronicles, regarding the massacre carried out by a band of enemy raiders, it is written: "After a year had passed, the army of Syria came up; it invaded Judah and Jerusalem, and it struck down all the leaders of the people and sent all the plunder taken from them to the king of Damascus" (2 Chronicles 24:23). In the book of Job, we find that the decay of trees and their foliage is referred to in order to illustrate the loss of the wicked: "The wind will dry up its shoots, and its blossom will fall off; let him not trust in emptiness, for emptiness will be his reward. His branch will be cut off before its time, and his root will not yield fruit" (Job 15:30). He will be gathered before the time like unripe grapes, and he will fall like an olive blossom. The waning of the moon, when, after its fullness, the light it emits diminishes, is expressed by the same term that Job uses when he declares: "Do we not see the sun rise and set and the moon wane?" (Job 9:7). In the prophet Isaiah, regarding the subjugation that results from a battle or war, it is written: "And now, is it without the Lord that we go up against this land for its desolation? It is the Lord

who said to me: Go up against this land and destroy it!" (Isaiah 10:6). In Jeremiah, concerning the complete destruction and annihilation of Jerusalem, it is said: "Who will have pity on you, Jerusalem? Who will feel sorry for you? Who will turn aside to ask about your welfare? You have turned your face from me, says the Lord; you will turn your back, and I will stretch out my hand against you, and I will not grant them any rest!" (Jeremiah 15:5-6). In the Lamentations of the same prophet, he wrote similar things: "The Lord has become like an enemy; he has destroyed Israel and laid waste all its strongholds; he has multiplied in the daughter of Judah mourning and lamentation" (Lamentations 2:5). In the prophet Ezekiel, it is written: "And I will deliver you into the hand of brutal men who are skilled in destruction. You will become fuel for the fire; your blood will flow in the midst of your land; there will be no remembrance of you, for I, the Lord, have spoken" (Ezekiel 21:31).

In the prophet Daniel, regarding the three children who were not consumed in the midst of the furnace but who blessed and glorified the God of the Universe, King Nebuchadnezzar said, "Behold, I see four men walking unbound in the midst of the fire, and there is no trace of harm upon them!" Thus, the burning and the resulting injury for those who are burned is called corruption. This incident did not occur for the three children due to a miracle, as the Son of God accomplished the wonder of descending with them into the furnace. It was he whom Nebuchadnezzar saw advancing in the flames alongside the three others, opening his eyes and performing such wonders. The king also added to what had been said and declared that the appearance of the fourth was like a son of God. Yet, it was for piety that they fought, and it was voluntarily that they fell into the fire from which no one escapes; moreover, it was not recklessly, based on the hope of being delivered in any case, but solely for the good, to render homage to God and out

of love for him that they accepted being burned, to die, and to contribute, through suffering, to their personal perfection and that of all God's servants, both of that time and those who would be until the last day of this world's existence. Who, indeed, has not been comforted by their noble and vigorous resolution in the battles for piety? Or who would not be moved by such words, inscribed on the exploits of their struggle and attesting, even before the trial of their bodies, to the firmness of their admirable souls standing against the tyranny of the king, to divine love? They indeed said, "Our God, whom we serve, is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace and to rescue us from your hand, O king! But if he does not, let it be known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up" (Daniel 3:17-18). And what is surprising about the barbaric Nebuchadnezzar calling corruption what would have been a testimony of manliness and piety, the burning of such heroes, in a case where they would have truly been burned? Daniel himself, who distinguished himself in similar circumstances when he was thrown into the lions' den, called the bites and devouring actions of those animals, from which he was miraculously spared, corruption. It is concerning this that he wrote, "And they brought Daniel out of the den, and no injury was found on him because he had trusted in his God" (Daniel 6:23). And when the same Daniel had mysteriously received divine visions, and his body, through painful works of penance, had undergone affliction, he wrote in one of the visions, "In those days, I, Daniel, was mourning for three weeks. I ate no pleasant food, nor did meat or wine come into my mouth, nor did I anoint myself at all, till three whole weeks were fulfilled" (Daniel 10:2-3). After such penance, when a fearsome and divine vision appeared to him, he added, "I saw this great vision, and no strength remained in me; for my vigor was turned to frailty, and I retained no strength" (Daniel 10:8). He also called this praiseworthy suffering, namely the alteration of his



brightness, that is, the appearance and aspect of his body, the weakening and lack of strength that occurred solely for the benefit of the one who suffered and for all those who would read his divine book and form the Church of our great God and Savior Christ. Indeed, this suffering clearly instructed both the prophet himself and those who subsequently and even to this day hear it, that it does not belong to human power, even purified by penance, to receive visions of the mysteries of God unless he provides help and support to weakness; that it is also necessary that those who are deemed worthy, even if only to hear—let alone to see, as he did—such revelations be purified and formed in chastity.

How does all this align with your definition of piety, which firmly establishes as a decree that such sufferings are not called corruption? While I believe it is good to omit many testimonies on this subject to avoid giving our exposition an unlimited scope, it seems both appropriate and necessary, as far as possible, to cite a single text from the New Testament. Paul, who died daily for Christ, who loved this degree of intensity and fervor, and who rushed into danger for him to the point of saying, "Who will separate me from the love of Christ? Tribulation? Distress? Persecution? Famine? Nakedness? Danger? Sword?" (Romans 8:35), and who elsewhere detailed his sufferings, stating, "Far more than that, in labors, abundantly through stripes, often in dangers of death. In dangers from rivers, in dangers from robbers, in dangers from my own countrymen, in dangers from the Gentiles, in dangers in the city, in dangers in the wilderness, in dangers at sea, in dangers from false brothers; in toil and hardship, through many sleepless nights, in hunger and thirst, often without food, in cold and exposure" (2 Corinthians 11:23-27), called all these glorious sufferings, which were desired and ardently loved and which healed the entire Church, "corruption of the outer man," meaning his body. He

said, "But even if our outer man is decaying, yet our inner man is being renewed day by day" (2 Corinthians 4:16). In commenting on this passage, the wise John, bishop of Constantinople, in his commentary on the first letter to the Corinthians, in the eighth homily, states: "We do not lose heart; but even if our outer man is decaying, yet our inner man is being renewed day by day. How does it decay? When it is struck and suffers persecution, when it endures countless evils! In contrast, the inner man is renewed day by day through hope, faith, and the disposition of thoughts that now leads us to despise evils. Indeed, the more numerous the evils the body endures, the better the hope that the soul acquires, and the more it shines like gold tested by fire.

If, therefore, the precious sufferings of the saints, the bodily wounds endured for piety, the bruises and various afflictions are clearly referred to in Holy Scripture by the name of affliction or by the term tribulation, because all of this has been endured in a corruptible, suffering, and mortal body, and if the eminent doctors who have explained this have used the same names and words, how can I feel unnecessary fear and not call tribulation the sufferings that have occurred in the corruptible and earthly bodies of the blessed apostles, prophets, and martyrs? For a great power emanates from it, and nothing is to be despised. The great Paul also said: "We have this treasure in earthen vessels, so that it may be made clear that the greatness of this power comes from God." He who, from the corruption of the sufferings of the members that had been tortured in every way and lacerated by torment, brought forth rivers of incorruptibility and gifts of the Spirit and of healing; he who, for this purpose, became incarnate, without undergoing change, in a flesh consubstantial with ours and suffering in the likeness of our nature, and assured in all things, without sin, the resemblance to us, so that by enduring all the irreproachable sufferings of our death and our burial, he conquered and

destroyed their power and who, truly taking upon himself their violence in actions and in deeds, transmitted victory to us as well, as the firstborn of our race; thus we could scorn sufferings with strength and brave death with courage and we could hasten toward the incorruptibility and immortality of the resurrection, having before our eyes the firstborn among the dead. It is for this reason that after having endured persecution on many occasions from the Jews, he said to the apostles and the disciples: "If they have persecuted me, they will persecute you also." And he who appeared before the wicked assembly of the high priests and who was scourged before the governor Pilate, he indicated to them in advance that they would endure the same evils by saying: "For they will deliver you up to councils, and they will scourge you in their synagogues, and they will bring you before governors and kings." He who was covered with reproaches and countless insults, he predicted in the same manner and taught: "When they persecute you, and revile you, and say all kinds of evil against you falsely for my sake, rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven; for so they persecuted the prophets who were before you." And he who was struck and ultimately killed for our iniquities and who endured all this in the flesh for us, he commanded us to be bold, saying: "Do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul," not that he accomplished all this in word and made it easy as God alone, but also as man, becoming consubstantial with us without undergoing change, suffering as we do in the flesh and rising as the leader in the struggle and battles in favor of piety. And from then on, he humbled himself to this total stripping away so that by taking on these traits that are ours and dying our death in a passible and mortal body, he might also rise there, becoming for us a way and a door to the incorruptibility that flows from the resurrection. Therefore, let us not feel any dread in calling a passible, mortal body corruptible and subject to sufferings that cause corruption, which are of a nature to strike, injure, and harm

the flesh, but which are without sin and pure from all malicious guilt; by truly enduring them, Emmanuel destroyed their power and even corruption itself, transforming it into incorruptibility through the resurrection. Indeed, this is what Saint Cyril teaches us to think and say and profess with these words in Letter 4 to Acacius, regarding the question of Azazel, writing as follows: "The choir of the holy angels, too, in their multitude, was struck with astonishment when they saw in a form that is ours the King of Glory and the Lord of hosts, and they said: 'Who is this who comes from Edom, — that is, from the earth, — his garments stained red from Bosra?' Now, Bosra is translated as flesh, or as tribulation or oppression." And furthermore, they questioned him: "What are these wounds in your hands?" and he replied to them: "Those with which I was wounded in the house of a friend." For indeed, just as Thomas, in a manner entirely consistent with the economy, even after he had risen from the dead, showed his hands and the places of the nails that were there, and he urged him to touch also the perforations he had in his side, so too when he ascended to heaven, he convinced the holy angels that it was justly that beloved Israel had been banished and rejected from his intimacy. To this end, he showed his garment stained with blood and in his hands the wounds that remained. Indeed, by his resurrection from the dead, he had stripped away corruption, and with it, all that it entails; but it was, as I have said, so that, in accordance with the economy, the manifold wisdom of God, which he had prepared before the ages and realized in Christ, might now be made known to the Principalities and Powers that are in the heavens, through the Church, as the divine Paul wrote to all.

These words are clearly spoken and proclaim the truth in a lucid manner. Therefore, we do not need to comment on the content of Letter 6 to Succensus and the Treatise to the Pious Theodosius, nor engage in a vain debate or conjecture a meaning to attribute to them as

one does with unknown texts, when we should take the one who speaks himself as the interpreter of his words! Indeed, as the Doctor has said, once resurrected from the dead, he stripped himself of corruption, no longer having a passible body, but incorruptible and immortal, which is no longer subject to hunger, fatigue, and other sufferings naturally capable of corrupting, nor to the infirmities of the flesh. Even though, after the incorruptibility derived from the resurrection, he showed the marks of the wounds, appearing affected by them and allowing them to be felt by touch—he said to Thomas, "Put your finger here and see my hands; put your hand and place it in my side" (John 20:27)—he persuaded that he truly suffered, while every incorruptible body excludes the lesion of sufferings by the virtue of the resurrection, of which we also await the realization in our bodies! How could we be ashamed of the truth, we who are its defenders? And shall we not confess that in the corruptible body, that is, the passible and mortal one, he endured sufferings and death for us? He wanted to establish the truth to such an extent that, even after the resurrection, incorruptibility, immortality, and impassibility, he appeared with the traces of the stigmata that are proper to the corruptible body! Such was the infinite greatness of the authentic and all-merciful condescension of the economy that in this very thing he submitted, so to speak, to a measure even lower than the creature, while excluding from his mystery any deception and suspicion of illusion!

Let us once again consider the words of Saint Cyril, who, in the twelfth book of his Commentary on the Gospel of John, teaches us in a very spiritual and complete manner: "Thomas touched the side of our Savior and examined the marks from the Roman spear; he saw the places of the nails." Someone might ask: how could signs of corruption be perceived in an incorruptible body? Indeed, it is a sign of bodily corruption that the perforations of the hands and side, the appearance

of the marks, and the wound made by iron were still present and visible in him, while the truthful and irrefragable language regarding the reformed body for incorruptibility expresses the necessity of shedding, along with corruption itself, the consequences that arise from it. If someone is lame, will he return to life still affected in his foot and leg by lameness? And if someone has lost his sight in this world, will he rise again deprived of vision? How, then, will we have rejected corruption if the sufferings that result from it still persist and dominate our bodies? I certainly do not believe that we should dismiss the necessary discussion on this matter; however, we say this—within the limits of what is possible to discuss regarding these difficulties presented to us—that at the time of the resurrection, no residue of the corruption that occurred will remain in us, but, as the wise Paul says regarding this body: "What is sown in weakness is raised in power; what is sown in dishonor is raised in glory" (1 Corinthians 15:43). Now, the expectation of the resurrection of this body in strength and glory is nothing other than returning to its original constitution after having shed all natural weakness and all dishonor arising from corruption and suffering. It was not made for death and corruption. Because Thomas had made this request in order to gain clearer assurance, it was necessary that our Lord Jesus Christ, to provide no pretext for the smallness of our faith, appeared to him in the very manner he wished to see him; for also, when he ascended to heaven and manifested the strength of the mystery concerning him to the Powers above, to the Principalities and Dominions, to the leaders of legions and the presidents of the angelic orders, he was seen in that same appearance, so that they would believe that the Word, who is from the Father and in the Father, had truly become man for us, and that they would know he had such care for his creatures that he first died for us to secure life for us. It is clear that the Doctor referred to the marks from the perforation of the nails and the spear as bodily

corruption, for which there is no longer any place after the incorruptibility resulting from the resurrection, because we too, at the resurrection, will shed both the lameness of feet and the blindness of eyes, and any member that bears a vile, shameful, and disfiguring lesion, and all corruption of this kind that penetrates and affects the body, and we will assume integrity, the absence of disease, and health, which we possessed in paradise before losing the grace of immortality that He abundantly gave us from the beginning in creating us, so that we would not die like men, as holy Scripture says (Wisdom 2:23), but that we would remain in the incorruptibility in which we were also created. He himself, however, to confirm the truth of his death and the sufferings he endured for us, even after the resurrection, appeared to Thomas as well as to the rational spirits in heaven bearing the marks of the scars that are foreign to the resurrected, incorruptible, immortal, and impassible body—just as the act of eating is—yet these marks are proper to the corruptible, suffering, and mortal body.

This is what the eminent Cyril clearly teaches us, as he writes in the same book: "Just as after the resurrection, especially of the sacred body, corruption no longer existed at all, since he was raised for incorruptibility, it is believed that he no longer needed the usual food as before. He showed the places of the nails and did not refuse to take food, to confirm the great mystery of the resurrection and to implant faith in our souls; however, he performed these actions that are entirely foreign to spiritual nature. For the places of the nails, the marks of the wounds, and the consumption of bodily food raise the question of how these could be found in a spirit that is completely free and not immersed in a body, given that it is the body, as is fitting to the reason of its nature, that is inclined to present itself in these states. Furthermore, to prevent some from believing that our Lord was resurrected as a subtle spirit or as something impalpable, which would

be akin to a shadow—a body or airy, which some commonly call spiritual—he wanted it to be believed that he had resurrected the very same body that had been sown in corruption, according to the word of Paul, and he realized and demonstrated what is appropriate to the density of the body. One must again understand how the doctor clearly stated that after the resurrection he had dispelled what pertains to the corruption of the holy flesh, because he was raised for incorruptibility, and that before the resurrection he had experienced the need for food, as he did not yet possess impassibility and immortality, which constitute incorruptibility. It was indeed fitting that this occurred in a flesh subject to suffering and death, which the Emmanuel endured through true sufferings and died a true death, to destroy through the resurrection their power and strength that weighed upon us. And here is what is astonishing! Paul compares the resurrection of our bodies to seeds, namely to wheat and all others, and he shows that just as they fall to the ground, grow, and emerge according to their nature, donning brilliance and splendor as a result of growth, so the bodies of those who believe in Christ are sown in corruption and rise clothed in impassibility, immortality, and the glory of the resurrection; and this is precisely why he said: it is sown in corruption and it rises without corruption! In exactly the same manner, concerning the very holy body of our Lord, God, and Savior Christ, who came to death and burial in the earth, Saint Cyril declared: "That very same body which was sown in corruption, according to the word of Paul, is believed to rise.

Thus, he participated in the very modality of the experience of death, as well as in the sowing of corruption, which is the burial of our bodies; however, he did not remain in corruption and did not descend, as we do, into the dissolution that follows burial. For his soul was not abandoned to hell, and his flesh did not see corruption in the tomb, anticipating through the resurrection the dissolution that results from



this state. Christ came to resurrect and also to raise us with him, we who had fallen, and not to remain in the grave. Indeed, through the resurrection, death has truly been conquered, and it is for this reason that he became incarnate and took on human form, with the intention of becoming the first fruits of our resurrection. This is also what John, the holy bishop of Constantinople, states in his Commentary on the First Epistle to the Corinthians, saying: “The first fruits are indeed the first fruits of something! But how can he be the first fruits if those of whom he is the first fruits do not rise? How then do they not rise? And if they do not rise, why has Christ risen? Why has he come? For what purpose did he take on flesh if he was not to resurrect his flesh? For he himself did not have the need, but it was for us.” Furthermore, the statement “What is sown in corruption also rises in incorruption” alludes to the burial and resurrection of our bodies, which the same Doctor indicates in the same commentary on the letter, writing: “And it is not our birth in the womb that he has called here sowing, but rather the burial in the earth, the decomposition of the dead bodies, their reduction to ashes. That is why, after saying, ‘what is sown in corruption,’ he immediately added, ‘rises in incorruption.’ What is sown in disgrace; what could be more repugnant in appearance than a decaying corpse? ‘Rises in glory; what is sown in weakness’: indeed, thirty days do not pass before everything has perished, and the flesh cannot preserve itself, nor can it even suffice for a single day. ‘Rises in power’: then, indeed, nothing will prevail against him.

Regarding the places of the nails and the action of touching the body of our Lord, as posed after the resurrection by the Apostle Thomas, and concerning the food he took once risen from the dead, the same things that were said by Saint Cyril are also written in Homily 672 of his Commentary on the Gospel of John: “It is right to inquire how an incorruptible body exhibited the places of the nails and was touched by

a mortal hand. But do not be troubled: what was happening was due to condescension. Indeed, what was so subtle and light as to enter through closed doors was devoid of any density; but it was so that he might testify to his resurrection that he showed this and to teach that it was he who had been crucified and that it was not another who had risen in his place. This is why he rose bearing the signs of the crucifixion, and it is for this very reason that he ate. And the apostles everywhere made this a sign of the resurrection by saying, ‘We have eaten and drunk with him’ (Acts 10:41). Similarly, just as when we saw him before the resurrection walking on the waves, we do not say this body is of another nature but of ours, so also, after the resurrection, in seeing him bearing the places of the nails, we do not say that he is now corruptible. For it was for the disciples that he exhibited them.” And a little further on: “And after this, he showed himself to the disciples by the Sea of Tiberias (John 21:1). You see that he did not remain with them continuously nor as before. He appeared one evening and disappeared; and again eight days later, and once more he disappeared; and after that by the sea and amidst great fear. What does it mean that ‘he showed himself’? It follows that he would not have been seen if he had not lowered himself, because his body was now incorruptible and immortal.” And even further on: “As for the fact that he did not remain continuously nor as usual, he said: ‘This was the third time that Jesus appeared to them, after he was risen from the dead’ (John 21:14). And he ordered them to bring fish, to make it known that what they saw was not a phantasm; however, here he does not say that he had eaten with them, but Luke, elsewhere, has said: ‘He was eating with them’ (Acts 1:4). How? It does not belong to us to say; certainly, all this happened in a wonderful manner, not that nature still needed food, but it was by condescension, to confirm the resurrection.

Saint Epiphanius, who was the archbishop of the island of Cyprus, left us in his treatise called *Ancoratus* a doctrine that aligns with these ideas regarding the resurrection, in which he states: "It is characteristic of unbelievers to say that he is absolutely not resurrected, or it is the error of those who believe wrongly to say that it was not he who had died and had fallen asleep that was resurrected; rather, it belongs to believers to affirm that it is this very body that has been resurrected and that it is from this very body that our own has been placed in authentic hope. This is why he left the marks of the nails intact as well as the place of the spear, even though he entered through closed doors. Indeed, his fleshly body was resurrected as spiritual; it was not different from what it had been, but what it had been, when it was united to divinity, was endowed with the subtlety of spirit. For if it were not the subtlety of the Spirit, what fissure would allow passage to the density of the body? But he wished to show that this corruptible nature, which had been born, had truly put on incorruptibility. For if it is mortal, it will put on immortality. He entered through closed doors to demonstrate that what is dense was subtle, what is mortal was immortal, and what is corruptible was incorruptible; and to confound all those who do not believe in our redemption, I mean in our resurrection, he who transformed the body into subtle matter and penetrated the resurrection with spirit did not erase the scars of the nails nor the place of the spear, but by what he suffered on the cross, he showed that what was resurrected was not different and that it was not something else that came from it, but that it was the very one who had suffered who had become impassible, that the grain which had fallen had been resurrected and that it had risen incorruptible. And so that we do not believe that only a part of him was resurrected, it is he himself, entirely, who did not see corruption, for he indeed said: 'You will not allow your holy one to see corruption' (Psalm 16:10), and on the other hand, it is he himself entirely who is resurrected, for he said: 'He is

risen; he is not here!' (Mark 16:6). Now if he is resurrected and is not here, he is truly resurrected. The Scriptures, which are our life, do not lie! And so that those who err do not find a pretext, he showed his bones and his flesh to Thomas and said to his disciples: 'You see me; it is truly I! A spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have' (Luke 24:39). And if someone were to insidiously claim that the body of Christ was of a superior condition because it was conceived by Mary alone, without male seed, then Adam's body would also have been different from that which is born because it was taken from the earth alone and not from male seed! But no one can declare or demonstrate such a thing! And if someone were to further insidiously claim that it is only that of Christ which is entirely resurrected, but that the rest does not resurrect itself but that it is another that does, how can he say that Christ is the 'firstfruits of those who sleep' (1 Corinthians 15:20)? Now if he is the firstfruits of those who sleep, it is a unique and the same body that is the firstfruits of those who rise. Thus, the body of our God and Savior Christ has acquired resurrection as the principle of incorruptibility, which consists in impassibility and immortality, and it is through this that he has become the firstfruits of our bodies.

The text cited earlier by your Piety, which is found in the book *Ancoratus*, was written in full regarding the incorruptibility that follows the resurrection. You limited yourself to quoting this: "All together spiritual body, all together incomprehensible divinity. What has suffered has not been corrupted. The impassible is incorruptible. He is entirely incorruptibility, the Lord God." However, the words that precede and follow this clearly show that they pertain to the incorruptibility and immortality that follow the resurrection and to the contact by which Thomas's spirit was healed. The complete statement is as follows: "...but he enters, with the door closed, and he is touched

by Thomas, so that one does not grasp a phantom but the truth, he in whom Thomas believed, after what had been said was accomplished: 'I have sought God with my hands and I have not been disappointed' (Job 23:9). The same, God, and the same, man, without realizing confusion, but combining the two elements into one, without being reduced to nothing, but affirming through divinity the earthly body into a unique power. He is therefore our Lord Jesus Christ; there are not two Christs nor two gods; all together spiritual body, all together incomprehensible divinity! What has suffered has not been corrupted; the impassible is incorruptible; he is entirely incorruptibility, the Lord God, who sits at the right hand of his Father.

Let us no longer fear to follow all those apostolic and eminent teachers who, in the one Holy Spirit, have explained the books that were spoken by him; they teach us to confess that, throughout the time of his incarnation, the body of our Lord, God and Savior Jesus Christ was corruptible, that is to say, mortal and subject to unavoidable sufferings, death, and burial, so that, having endured these and being truly dead in what is naturally capable of suffering and dying, he fought again for our victory by destroying, through the resurrection, the power of corruption that arises from suffering and death. But after the resurrection, he taught us to be immortal. Indeed, with all the others, Saint John also clearly stated this in the preceding context: "...because henceforth the body is impassible and immortal." However, no one declared his body to be immortal before Emmanuel willingly bore the cross. The denial of his death is repugnant to true redemption because it leads to the impiety of the fantasists. Furthermore, it has always existed in the body of our Lord and Savior Christ the incorruptibility that consists in impeccability and total holiness, which has been unanimously transmitted by all those who initiate others into the mysteries of truth. Likewise, I believe this is what has been previously

demonstrated comprehensively in the exposition and demonstration I have undertaken regarding what has been said, drawing on the words of the teachers and the Fathers who have been cited concerning each point. Following them, I, the least of all, also declared in summary during the Sermon on the Holy Mother of God and Ever-Virgin Mary, which I delivered in the holy church of Antioch, this: "Thus, the body of Christ is demonstrated to be incorruptible, he whose corruption from sin has not approached at all. As for that which results from death and burial, he was subject to it, but he destroyed it within himself and was not held by it, due to his union with the Word who is, by nature, incorruptible, impassible, and immortal." And it is in these words that the entire exposition of the theory on this subject is encapsulated.

However, despite all this, in submitting this question with the sole intention of demonstrating that the body of our God and Savior Jesus Christ is incorruptible, due to his impassibility and immortality, even before the resurrection—because this is what mattered to him—your Holiness diverts the discussion to incorruptibility resulting from impeccability and writes the following: "Indeed, as a woman was afflicted with an incurable flow of blood, by touching the fringe of the Lord's garment, she took what she sought. And the Lord said, 'Someone touched me'; as the disciples told him, 'The crowds are pressing against you,' he said again, 'Someone touched me. For I know that impurity did not approach me, but that a power has gone out from me; I have given and not received; I have acted and not suffered. Indeed, everything foreign, when approaching me, becomes corrupt from a distance, and if it is close to me, it does not add to me; for the fullness from which all have received does not receive an addition. Now, if corruption does not reach the fringe of the garment, what shall we say of the incorruptible body itself? For if it contracts corruption, it will be said that it has been subjected to the movements of desire as

well!’ But we will remind your honorable Reverence, and appropriately on this point too: Why do you speak of impiety and movements of desire, when no one contradicts this, but rather all confess that the body of our God and Savior Christ is holy and sinless, and therefore always incorruptible, and a distributor of holiness and all kinds of healing? And shall we consider it something great if we believe we show him to be pure from these impurities, he who gives and grants in great abundance such benefits to his servants, because he is the source of all good? For it is in the name of Jesus Christ that the apostles and disciples performed such exploits. Thus it is written concerning Paul that the grace of Christ was so effective through his hands that if handkerchiefs or aprons that had touched his body were laid on the sick, they were healed of their diseases and evil spirits went out from them. Who then would be so impious as to say that the garment of our God and Savior Christ was inferior to the clothing that had touched the body of Paul, and that the Master who worked should be placed second to his servant who worked through him? But we do not say that the body of Paul was impassible and immortal and that it was not subject to hunger, fatigue, torment, suffering, and blows; nor do we deny, with regard to a health and miracles befitting a God, that the body of Emmanuel, who was in all things like us, except for sin, who is the Lord and God of Paul, was not suffering like ours and consubstantial with ours: it is in him that he grappled with death and won a just victory over it for our benefit by rising from the dead. For if, from the incarnation, he had been incorruptible, that is to say, impassible and immortal, with no one having died, what death would have been defeated, as Saint Cyril taught in the texts examined above? But we declare that it is in what is naturally apt to corrupt that the operation of death was exercised, and in this also that the resurrection which followed death was realized; it is for this reason that the Word of God became hypostatically united, so that it could be said that he

himself had suffered, had died, and had risen, while he possessed, as God, the impassibility that suffering did not reach.

What, then, does the eloquence of your Holiness claim when you declare, "If corruption does not reach the hem of the garment, what will be said of the incorruptible body itself?" Indeed, what kind of incorruptibility do you assert has affected the hem of our Savior Christ's garment? If you speak of that which consists in holiness, no one contests your words, but it is confessed that he is holiness and that he grants healing to those who approach him for help, since it is also written in the holy Gospel, "They brought to him all who were sick, and they begged him to let them touch even the fringe of his garment; and all who touched it were healed" (Matthew 14:36). However, this is not the matter at hand in the controversy presented to us, since Saint Athanasius, in the remarks that were previously examined regarding the most holy flesh of the universal Creator, God and Savior, Christ, taught us this: "Therefore, it would have been better to admire that the Word was in such passible flesh and that he did not prevent those who tortured him nor exact vengeance on those who killed him, even though he could have, he who had prevented others from dying and had raised those who were dead, but he consented to let his body suffer. For this is why he also came, as I have said, to suffer in the flesh so that henceforth the flesh would be constituted impassible and immortal." Who, indeed, is so deaf to the words of the Gospel as not to clearly know that our Lord, when the time for voluntary suffering came, declared, indicating that it was to suffer that he had become incarnate and made man, "What should I say? Father, save me from this hour! But for this purpose I have come to this hour!" (John 12:27).

If, on the contrary, it is because of incorruptibility, which consists in impassibility and immortality, that you declared the fringe of the mantle to be incorruptible, in that it does not age or wear out over time,



or that it is dissimilar and does not undergo the same accidents as our garments, which of the evangelists or apostles wrote this? And among the eminent doctors, who taught that our Savior's garments were impassible and immortal? Indeed, concerning his seamless tunic woven from a single piece from top to bottom, the wise John the Evangelist writes that the Romans who crucified him did not tear it but cast lots for it; as for the other garments, they divided them among themselves, while the prophecy was fulfilled as if it emanated from the person of Christ: "They divided my garments among them and cast lots for my tunic" (John 19:24). Now, the tunic simultaneously signifies allegorically the unbroken concord of the Church, which is the body of our Savior Christ and, so to speak, his mantle and his garment, according to what Paul said to the Ephesians: "We are members of his body" (Ephesians 5:30), and because each of us is said to have clothed himself with his body like a garment, as Job wisely declared somewhere to the God of the Universe: "You clothed me with skin and flesh; you knit me together with bones and sinews" (Job 10:11). As for the impassibility and immortality of the garments, as well as their incorruptibility that one recognizes in relation to them, absolutely no one has said or taught anything about this. And to the sons of Israel who had abandoned the worship of the Egyptian idols, who constantly wanted to return to Egypt and were complaining and grumbling, as it is written, who nourished childish and foolish thoughts about the Egyptian meat pots, Christ, who had led them into the desert, granted them similar advantages and condescended as to little children by saying: "Your garments have not worn out on you, and your feet have not swollen during these forty years" (Deuteronomy 8:4), and "Recognize in your heart that, as a man disciplines his son, so the Lord your God has disciplined you" (Deuteronomy 8:5), and again: "Your garments have not worn out, and your sandals have not worn off your feet" (Deuteronomy 29:5), so that, through the garments themselves,

their hearts, which had forgotten his miracles, would be put to shame. And when he was incarnate and, excluding all change and appearance, truly became man, he not only shared our nature but also our way of life, our concerns, and our manners, offering the outward appearance of a man. In every way, his purpose was this: to take upon himself our despicable character, since, when he was in the form of God, he humbled himself and took the form of flesh, not wishing to astonish us either by the greatness of the body or by the adornment of imperishable garments; on the contrary, he resorted to everything that suited humility and, through his actions, showed that he had been in every way like us, except for sin, and that he presented himself to us as a rule of life and a standard of wisdom. This is what John, the bishop of Constantinople, also taught in his Commentary on the Epistle to the Ephesians: "But he appeared as a man, not by astonishing us with exploits, but by exhorting us to humility." Therefore, when he said his purpose was "as a man," this is what he meant, since elsewhere he also calls him man when he says: "For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus" (1 Timothy 2:5). And again, in the Commentary on the Gospel of Matthew, regarding the fact that our Lord sat on a donkey, he said: "For my part, it does not seem to me that it is only for this reason that he sat on a donkey, but also to provide us with a standard of wisdom. For he did not limit himself to fulfilling the prophecy and establishing the teachings of truth, but he also set a standard for our conduct, establishing everywhere through these gestures the rules of necessary practices and giving direction to our lives. That is why, when he was about to be born, he did not seek a glorious dwelling or a fortunate mother, but a poor one whose husband was a worker; he was born in a cave and laid in a manger; and in choosing his disciples, he did not select rhetoricians and wise men or the rich and descendants of noble lineage, but poor descendants of the poor and from all sides unknown.

And when he prepared the table, sometimes he placed barley bread on it and sometimes commanded the disciples to buy according to opportunity. And when he made a meal, he did it with herbs. He wore coarse garments and not different from those of the masses.

Thus, while the proposed question was whether it is through impassibility and immortality that the body of our Lord, God and Savior, Christ, was impassible even before the resurrection, how has your Holiness provided evidence for the incorruptibility, impassibility, and immortality of the mantle, since no one, as we have said, has stated or written that the garments pertain to the Commentary on the Epistle to the Philippians. And even if those things that have not been written down, which the world could not contain, surpass those that are written in the Gospel—this is what John the Evangelist has declared—it is nonetheless necessary that we do not make any dangerous conjectures in the realm of what is unwritten. At this point, I could fear that those who delight in innovations and are capable of nothing other than saying or hearing something new, considering that Christ has been treated by such profane individuals who rob him of his voluntary stripping in accordance with his divinity, would begin to declare that it must be said that his garments were also impassible and immortal. Therefore, it is fitting that we spare innocent and simple souls and not provide pretexts for those who wish to disturb them.

Therefore, I pray your Holiness not to imitate the disputers, but to keep the Zome that she sent me and not to share it with anyone, for I have discovered other ideas within it that attack sublime doctrines and have similarly troubled me. Moreover, as I mentioned earlier, I did not want to leave anything unexamined; however, seeing our exposition take on excessive length, I omitted the examination and discussion that pertained to them. The vocabulary related to the teachings of faith is indeed abundant in multiple subtleties, and we must greatly fear and

dread being easily carried away to write on these matters unless a necessity arises that we cannot avoid, which compels us to do so. It is also necessary for your Piety to understand that even what I have written, I have drafted with sadness, considering that my silence would have fallen under the weight of divine laws if I had not done what you requested on my behalf, and this without saying anything that would reflect on me, but only citing what comes from the doctors of the holy Church.

Pray, then, you who are in everything the love of God, that our weakness may resist promptly and firmly against those who persecute us because of piety, so that we may reach a happy end and find at least a modest salvation from our many sins on the terrible and fearsome day of judgment.